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KENNY WRIGHT

BULL'S EYE 5

Beyond the Hotwife Fantasy

A man and a woman are shown in a close, intimate pose, nearly kissing. The man is on the left, looking up at the woman on the right. The lighting is dramatic, with strong highlights on their faces and hair, and deep shadows elsewhere. The woman has long, light-colored hair and is wearing a dark top. The man has short hair and a beard. The overall mood is sensual and romantic.

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Beyond the Hotwife Fantasy

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Kenny Wright



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Foreword

Just a quick word up front (there are more words at the end of the story if you just can't get enough).

This is the fifth and final book in the Bull's Eye series. It's available at all major online retailers. If you haven't read the previous four, then I recommend pressing the pause, going back, and checking those out. While each book has its own story arc, there's a thread that runs through all the books that ends here. Also, you're not going to know many of the characters or references in this one.

For the rest of you, thank you so much for picking up this final installment. The journey is nearly complete. Sit back, get comfy, and enjoy.

Paul

Keynote

“I think we first realized my dad had Alzheimer’s disease when he started confusing my mom with his mistresses.” The joke earns me a few chuckles in the sea of people. I’m at Global Philanthropy Conference, the unlikely keynote speaker to open the second day of workshops. “Turns out it got worse after that.” The crowd grows somber. “He started calling his mistresses by my mom’s name.”

The laughter that washes over me feels good, even if it comes cheap. I’ve never talked much about this time in my life. I don’t love the vulnerability required. I glance at Heather, sitting in the front row. She nods in encouragement.

“When it really did get bad, though, my mom didn’t stick around. I didn’t blame her then. Still don’t. Caring for someone with this disease...” That’s not emotion I feel in the wings of my mind, ready to strike. “Well, many of you know that it’s not easy. Takes more strength than you think you have. I was just eighteen at the time, but those years made me the man that I am today.”

This story, before all these people, glosses over so much, but it’s not a lie. I learned so much about myself in those years, taking care of my dad during his slow spiral. I learned a lot about who he was, too, back then, and how unhappy he and Mom were together as they tried holding it together for me—how in the end, they couldn’t do even that.

“I didn’t have a support network back then. I was a kid. We didn’t have other family. We had some doctors, a social worker, but mostly, we were

just trying to figure it all out on my own—Dad, me, and whoever Dad decided I was that day.”

My favorite was when he thought I was Howie, one of his drinking buddies. We had some hilarious conversations about the nurses back in those days. Nurse Amelia, with her long, golden hair and sexy French accent, was his favorite. I ended up hooking up with her after her home visits were over, then telling Dad all about it when I was “Howie”.

I don’t share that story with this audience. They’re not ready. Heather, though, would get a kick out of it.

I’m on a headset mic so I can walk the stage like I’m doing a TED Talk. I smile to myself at how ridiculous this is. Behind me rises an enormous picture of me with my dad, just to further pull at the heartstrings. He gifted me his hard set jaw and the utter inability to keep it clean shaven.

The stage is flanked by two screens broadcasting that five o’clock shadow to the back of the room. I wear a slim-tailored suit without a tie, and only spend a fraction of a second admiring myself, literally larger than life, before getting back to my speech.

Manhattan catches it, though. Even calls me out after the applause dies down and my audience filters out to start their day of learning.

“You were not just checking yourself out up there.” She’s basking me in that amused smile that I remember when we first met.

“Not like I was the only one.”

We keep a safe distance from one another, although every part of me wants to take her into my arms. I watched her get dressed this morning. I know that beneath her gray pencil skirt and black blouse, she’s wearing a lacy black bra and a matching thong. I know that her pussy is smooth because I watched her shave it just before going down on her. And I know that her normally lily-white skin has begun to tan in the Vegas sun, leaving her with the tan lines of her small swimsuit.

Here in public, though, we stay apart. As far as anyone looking is concerned, I'm the responsible head of a charity that's at the tail end of a scandal, and Heather Kingsley-Fletcher is my PR rep and a professional colleague.

She's not the only one to approach. A couple of young women come to the front of the conference hall, clutching their program guides and eager to speak to me. They all but ignore Heather. "We just wanted to say how beautiful that speech was."

"Well, thank you. I'm glad you enjoyed it."

Both are good looking—the one speaking has curly brown hair that she's tamed with a headband, and the other has auburn locks that shimmer with copper hues in this light. I calculate my odds with them at about fifty-fifty. The large diamonds they wear edge those odds higher, if anything.

Heather checks something on her phone, but judging from that smirk, I'm pretty sure she saw my quick appraisal.

"That thing you said about how you and your dad tried to manage it all on your own, until you realized that you needed help." The one with the auburn hair touches her chest. "Just breaks my heart."

"Seeing that kind of vulnerability in a man these days is so remarkable," the other agrees.

Heather laughs before she can stop herself. When the women give her a dirty look, she just holds up her phone. "Sorry, read something funny." She takes a single, polite step backwards.

"If you haven't already, consider donating to the... Memory Project." I still stumble over the new name for the Dawning Foundation. "We're about to launch some exciting new initiatives."

The brunette hands me her card. "Send me some information."

I look at the card, which only features her name, email address, and phone number. No company. “I will, Denise. Nice to meet you.”

“Allison and I are here through Sunday. Maybe we can get together some time and you can tell us all about those... exciting initiatives “

Allison, with the auburn hair, blushes furiously at her friend’s forwardness, but doesn’t contradict her. My odds just went way up. Despite all the sex I’ve been having with Heather since we got here, my cock and my pulse go up at the possibility.

“Sounds good. I’ll look you up if I get a free moment. Heather there has me running ragged.” Inside joke. Heather grins without looking up from her phone.

“Great.” Denise seems relieved that I didn’t reject the advance outright, and gave her an out in case I didn’t actually call. Which I don’t plan on doing. “Well, we better get to the next session.”

“It was nice meeting you, Paul.” Allison can barely meet my eyes as she retreats with her friend.

“That was amazing,” Heather says once they were out of earshot. “I thought that kind of thing only happened to women.”

“You can at least pretend to be jealous.”

She snorts. “You don’t really want that, do you?”

“I don’t know. Could be fun.”

“It was a brilliant speech.” The compliment doesn’t come from Heather, but from the president of the Memory Project’s board, Eleanor Heller. She walks down the aisle with the poise of royalty, like her feet don’t even touch the ground. “Very touching, Paul. How much of it was actually true?”

The Eleanor that I first met never would have challenged me so openly. This awakened version of her does it all the time. As always, she’s in a

dress that's both elegant and sexy all at once. This one's white, hangs just off her shoulders, and skims her curves like a sheath.

"Are you suggesting that I would lie in front of a thousand do-gooders?"

Eleanor shares a look with Heather. "Lie, no. Embellish?" She tips her head from side-to-side. She and Heather share a look.

Her chestnut brown hair is shorter now, cut into a strong bob along her jawline. It embodies her bold, edgy evolution while preserving the elegance that comes so naturally to her and her posh, British accent.

"It was a good speech," Heather concedes. "Explains a few things."

She's not being glib, although she gives me enough room to interpret it that way if I want to. Our transition from friends to something more has been interesting. We're still trying to figure out how serious this all is.

"Well, I think this calls for a celebration," Eleanor says. "The Memory Project is now live, thanks to you, Heather, and we're off to a smashing success. I've already got loads of interest from new donors—almost enough to make up for all those who left after Gregory Hamilton."

Gregory Hamilton scammed the Alzheimer charity out of millions of donor dollars before being caught, and left a stain on us that we're still trying to scrub free.

"This one here still needs to get me his final edits to his 'Accounting for Giving' blog post," Heather says to me. She checks her phone. "Looks like I've got to go over my presentation for tomorrow's panel, and June's lined up some client meetings this afternoon." She tears her eyes away from her phone. "But right now, my evening's free."

"Mmm, evening celebrations are my favorite ones." Eleanor winks at me. "Especially in Vegas."

"Do I want to know?" Heather asks.

"As my PR representative, probably not."

Heather laughs. I look at Eleanor and wonder. She has a kinky side that rivals my own. What has she been up to in Las Vegas these past few nights? “We should fire her,” I say. “She’ll be more fun then.”

Heather raises her brows. “Oh, I’m not fun enough for you?”

“Uh oh.” Eleanor smiles, flicking her blunt bob back. “I’ll let you two work that one out, and be in touch for this evening.”

Heather and I look at one another. “She’s right. We should work it out,” she says.

“Definitely. Maybe we could go over those blog post edits together...”

“I’ve got some free time now. Sounds like a plan.”

Eleanor’s smile is bright as she looks between us. “I’m glad you two are working this out. Watching you two over the last couple months was annoying.”

“I’m not sure what you’re talking about,” Heather says.

I nod. “We’re just friends.”

Heather

Meetings

“Oh that feels so... so... nah!”

Bright, Las Vegas sunlight pours over my body, glistening with sweat, as I writhe on the conference table. Above me, Paul rises like a granite monolith, holding my thighs against his chest, my legs up over his shoulders as he pumps his hips. God, the man looks good even with his face screwed up in concentration.

Our eyes meet, his dark irises so brilliant, so captivating, that I can't look away. He sees me. He slows the cadence of his thrusts, and together, we savor the connection. I see it confuses him. Paul's not a man who welcomes feeling and emotion—especially during sex.

It's cute, and I can't help but giggle as he stares down at me like that. He smiles, too, leaning down to gather me in a kiss.

“What are you grinning at?” I ask.

“Says the one who's giggling during sex.”

“That feels more of a judgment on you, not me—”

Snaking his hands beneath my ass, he lifts me up off the table. I clutch his neck and yelp in delight. In his arms, I feel weightless. I wrap my long legs around his waist and squeeze him into me. He's not going to bow. He's not going to break. He's solid. He's real. This dream hasn't ended. Not yet.

Paul takes me to the windows of the en suite—expansive floor-to-ceiling panes of glass that look down over the surreal landscape of the Las Vegas

strip. There's the Luxor pyramid, the faux New York skyline, the glinting gold of Mandalay Bay.

He presses me against the glass, and we gasp together at how exposed this feels. Like we're floating hundreds of feet above the world. It's how this last week has felt, ever since I left Eleanor's. Floating and riding this high.

I wrap my legs behind his back and my arms around his neck, squeezing him hard as I try to ignore my intense fear of heights. He digs his fingers into the taut flesh of my ass, lifting me up and down on his thick dick.

"Oh, yes. Ohhhh, yes!" I go off on him again, shuddering in his arms as my pussy squeezes his shaft and tries to milk another orgasm out of me.

He's not quite there. We already fucked that morning, when we woke together in my hotel room too early due to the jet lag, and entertained ourselves until the sun came up.

He has to let me down. Even as strong and as amped up as he is, he can't hold me suspended like that forever. All things end, even this phobia inducing fuck.

"You know I have a fear of heights?"

He laughs. "We're all about confronting our fears, right?"

"And what's your fear, Mr. Sharpe?" I play my fingers along his muscular, hairless chest. I can feel his heart race beneath all that hard muscle.

He ponders my question, and for a second, looks like he's to give a serious answer. Then, like all things with Paul, a grin breaks across his face and he gives the typical-for-a-guy response. "Going a week without sex."

"Heaven forbid." I snort, turn, and head for the bedroom.

My PR firm, Smith & Kingsley, reserved this penthouse suite to entertain clients, although this certainly isn't the kind of "entertaining" we had in mind. I'm still wearing my towering pumps—white Christian Louboutins

that are as painful as they are expensive—but my business dress is a crumpled pile at the foot of the conference table.

“Should we hide the evidence first?” he asks.

“Grab it. I’m going to take a shower.”

I know it rankles him when someone bosses him around. It only makes me want to do it more. I don’t bother looking back, although I can feel his eyes on my ass.

In the bedroom, I check my phone. The emails have piled up. The texts. I shouldn’t be up here. I should be down on the expo floor, networking, using the publicity that the Memory Project has brought me. This is the best venue of the year for new clients, and judging from all the communication, we’re raking it all in.

One text sits at the top of them all, though, putting a damper on my mood. Joshua.

We need to talk. Call me.

My stomach squirms in a way that I wish it wouldn’t. Joshua is a bastard. I’m better off without him in my life. But he was also in my life for so long. We still share some great memories. We always will.

Nothing lasts forever, I remind myself.

“Thirty seconds and I’ve already lost you to your phone.”

I darken it and put on a smile. “Don’t worry, you’re way less stressful than this.” I toss it down.

“That bad?”

He knows about all the emails and all the business. He knows that I should be downstairs, yet he’s somehow talked me into coming up here.

“Joshua again.” I’ve been straight with Paul from the beginning. No secrets. He’s not the kind of man easily threatened by others, and if he was, this wasn’t going to work anyway.

“Maybe you should just call him.” Paul comes up behind me, enveloping me in his arms. “You’re going to have to eventually.”

“Says you.” I reach behind me, encircling his cock, which is still half erect.

“What are you worried about?”

Forgiving him, my gut says. It’s true, and in the interest of no secrets, I just say it. Kind of. “That he’ll trick me into feeling sympathy for him.”

Paul kisses my neck and cups my breasts. “Then I should be there.” Pinching my nipple, he adds, “For moral support.”

I laugh. I can’t help it. That’s Paul in a nutshell. He somehow cuts through all of the drama and makes me laugh. He’s like the anti-Joshua.

“I’ll keep it in mind.” I swivel in his arms to face him, his boyish smile beaming down at me. “But I can’t deal with that now. Too much to do.”

“I’m ‘too much’ now? Thought I was ‘just right’.”

“You get one more squeeze, then I need to jump in the shower and get ready.”

When he kisses me, though, I forget the meetings and clients I’ve got lined up. I forget everything but his body, his touch, how he makes me feel safe and good. But still—

“I have a practice session, Paul...”

He dips down, wrapping his lips around my nipple this time.

“...I really need to...”

His hand slides between my thighs, parting my soft, wet pussy lips. I gasp. I want this. I want this all day. I want to cancel all my meetings. I want to lock the door and turn off my phone and feel this man play my body like a fucking Stradivarius.

“...shower...”

“I can be quick,” he whispers.

I push him back, coming back to my senses. He’s not the only one who can disarm with a smile. “That’s not been my experience.”

“Well, then, we can be even more efficient.” He scoops me into his arms, cradling me like a bride on her wedding night, and carries me into the bathroom.

I laugh out loud, but don’t squirm out of his grip. “You know, it’s been my experience that you make our showers much longer.”

“But much more entertaining.”

“Can’t argue with that.”



“You’re not returning my texts.”

I freeze dead in my tracks right in the center of the wide corridor that heads towards the Expo Hall. People stream by me on their way to and from their next sessions, oblivious to the confrontation about to unfold. I feel like a gunslinger walking down the middle of some small, dusty town.

“Joshua.” I glance at him out of the corner of my eye, not wanting to give him my full attention—not yet, anyway. “I had a feeling you’d follow me out here.”

He leans against a column, his arms folded coolly. “I’m that predictable, huh?”

He wears a GPC badge with a first-timer ribbon stuck to the bottom. In his suit and with the flecks of gray in his hair, he could fit right in with all of these philanthropists. Looks like he hasn’t shaved recently, either. His scruff comes in even grayer than his salt-and-pepper hair, and I hate how much I like it.

“No, you’re not predictable at all.” Reluctantly, I go to him. “But why are you here, Joshua?”

“I’ve...” He looks down at his hands, seems to realize how weak that looks, and meets my eyes. “I made a mistake. I’ve made so many mistakes.” He runs his fingers through his hair, and suddenly I see all the weariness in him. This man hasn’t slept well. His cheeks are gaunt. His tie isn’t quite as snug as it normally is. “I know you’re pissed off at me right now. And that’s fair. But I’m...” Even the halting way he speaks is so unlike Joshua. “I’m sorry.”

I wonder how many times he’s practiced that speech. I almost believe it. “The last time you saw me, you threatened me and my client.” I still haven’t turned to face him fully.

“I was upset. Heat of the moment.”

“Why should I believe you?”

He detaches himself from the column, and when I don’t flinch or step away, he moves closer. “You know me. I’m all talk. I’ve never actually followed through on a threat.”

“You’ve never had to, but you make them all the time. You’re like a big, fucking... guillotine over our marriage. What kind of relationship is that?!” The emotion springs forth. My vision blurs with tears that I don’t need right now. It’s so crazy, going from the highs that I’d just felt with Paul to this.

Others start to notice. We draw their eyes. We draw whispers. I don't need this drama. I'm the woman behind the PR, not the splashy headlines. "Go home, Joshua. I don't need this right now."

He's upon me then, although when he reaches out, his touch is gentle. When he speaks, his voice is soft. "I know you're... with him. Here."

Color springs to my cheeks.

"It's okay. I deserve all of it. I realize that. But don't fall for him, Heather. He's not that kind of guy. You're a good time for him. Just make sure that's all he is for you."

I turn on him. "Oh, he's a great time, Joshua. I know how to take care of myself. You should know. You've done all the research."

I storm off, unable to see how my verbal barb even landed. My composure is broken. I crash through the halls like a plane in a tailspin. I'm pretty sure that my makeup is now smudged. I'm late for a meeting for which I've completely forgotten the subject.

In high school, I studied hard, read every book assigned, always did my homework. I hated feeling unprepared. Even when I was my wildest, just after college, I stayed organized. Call it a control thing.

My ex-boyfriend, Shane, knew this. He knew how to get under my skin just by disrupting my plans. Joshua knows that weakness, too. I even knew that he would be here—knew that he'd fly out to try and bring me back. In his world, I was never gone.

Sometimes, I wish I could be more like Paul. The man seems to float through life like a blues riff, all improv, feeling his way more than overthinking it. I should just let go, but... but that's just not me.

I literally run into Mason Coles as I enter the expo hall, bouncing off his solid frame and nearly spilling my papers all over the floor.

"Watch it, now!" He catches me. "Don't want to hurt my favorite PR girl."

“I’m sorry I’m late. I…”

He sees that something’s wrong. Or maybe he just notices that I don’t call him out on calling me “girl.” “Hey, hey, what’s wrong?”

He ushers me off to the side of the hall, where the lunch tables are still set. I hate that I actually sniffle before looking up at him. “You know, it’s demeaning to call me ‘PR girl’, right?”

He snorts. “You’re right.” He makes a show of checking me out. “You’re all woman.”

“You do remember that we’re doing a D&I panel tomorrow, right? That’s actually, literally, why we’re meeting right now?”

“Still can’t believe you talked me into that.”

“It’s good for Memory—”

He keeps talking. “I think you just like spending time with me.”

This is easier. This bravado, I can deal with. In a way, it’s exactly what I need right now. I fold my arms, knowing that it’ll eventually draw his eyes into my cleavage. “Is that what you think?”

There go his eyes. “I do, as a matter of fact. Let’s blow off this practice. I’ll buy you a drink instead.”

After my run-in with Joshua, a drink doesn’t sound half bad. It’s also a terrible idea. “I don’t think so, Mason.”

“I don’t think you’re taking full advantage of the circumstances.”

“And those are?”

“We’re in Vegas, for one. Two, I see you looking.” He ducks down so he can look at me face-to-face with that cocky smile. I smile right on back. “And three, I know your husband’s into it.”

I feel goosebumps rise on my arms as my gut flutters. He's in on the secret, and this is reckless. I look around, worried that someone else might hear. He sees me looking, interprets my reaction as fear or nervousness.

He sits back in his chair, legs splayed, and throws an arm over the chair back. "Don't worry. Your secret's safe."

"Huh." I lean in, putting a hand on his knee. The man before me swells like a pet about to receive a treat. "Are any of you men capable of thinking beyond your cocks?" I glance at his crotch. "Or does that thing, like, suck all the blood out of your brains?"

Mason chuckles and leans forward. He knows when to be cool. Like Paul, he's a hard man to ruffle. He blinks slowly at me. "I'm sorry, did you say something about sucking?"

I groan in faux frustration, but it's hard not to laugh. He catches me biting back a smile as I stand. "Come on, let's go over this presentation. I added a few more slides that you should see..."

Paul

Part to play

“How are you holding up, Ron?”

We’re at a casino bar, lost in the masses of tourists and gamblers and conference attendees, anonymous in all that humanity. Eleanor is off ordering us drinks because she can cut through the crowd at the bar quicker than either of us.

“Oh, you know...”

“I’m not sure that I do.”

When he looks at me, there’s a strain in his face. Ronald Heller’s always kept himself and his emotions bottled up. I see now the pressure he’s going through just to keep that cork plugged. He looks like he wants to run his fingers through his hair and sigh, but is worried what it would do to his perfectly kempt hair.

He forces a laugh instead. “Vegas, man. It’s crazy.”

“You’ve been here what? Three nights?” He nods. “And you get any sleep yet?”

He laughs, but in a way that I can’t tell means, “You’re funny”, or “Barely any at all.” Then he changes the subject. “So, um, where’s Heather? Thought she was joining us?”

That was a good question. The original plan was for all of us to come out here together, but she got caught up at work. We’d only spoken over texts since we left her suite this afternoon.

“She’ll be along.”

“What’s... um...” He pauses, waiting for me to give him permission to ask whatever it is he wants. I give him a short nod. “So what’s the deal with you and Heather?”

This isn’t a question with an easy answer. I try to give him one anyway. “You know, we’re having fun.”

But Ronald is an intelligent and perceptive man. He’s also a man who has bared his most vulnerable self to me, and while that doesn’t entitle him to mine, he probes a little more. “She really likes you, and as... as more than just some fun.”

My heart lifts off despite my natural instincts. It’s the feeling of new relationship energy at play—a feeling I swore long ago never to fall for. The accountant in me squared this with the intensity that Heather and I entered our relationship with. A quieter voice wonders if there is more to it. The cynic laughs at it all.

I force a smile. “I can honestly say that I’ve never met anyone quite like Heather.”

For a second, he looks at me like a man who’s about to tell me that I don’t have to be afraid—or maybe that’s just my inner monologue continuing to prattle on. He begins to say something, thinks differently, and looks past me. “She’s here.”

I follow his eyes, and there she is, entering the bar. She’s changed from her conference clothes into a pair of tight, black pants and a loose and long-sleeved black blouse that was only sexy because of the cold shoulders and the fact that the woman wearing it is crazy sexy.

The last thing Ron says to me before Heather finds us in the bar is, “Life can be a whole lot more fun when you find the right person to share it with.”

It's amazing that Ron Heller can still be a romantic despite his wife and their sexual deviance. I focus on Heather. No more of this nonsense.

"You okay?" She looks uncomfortable when she joins us, her eyes tracking around the place like a trapped animal looking for an escape. "You okay?" I ask.

"Fine. Long day." It's only a partial truth. I don't press. Instead, I go in for a hug. She tenses up in my embrace, but doesn't push me away immediately.

"Careful, Paul. The optics."

I groan, but release her. We've talked about this. Here, in public, and while I'm still a client of her firm, we need to pretend that we're just friends. I don't see what the big deal is. After all, literally no one here gives a single fuck. We are in a city that practically has infidelity built into its social norms.

Still, I get it. Her profession is all one of "optics." She controls the narrative, and she doesn't even want the implication that she landed this contract because she's sleeping with the boss. Also, Vegas holds some extra significance to her than to most. That does explain her caginess.

Eleanor joins us, drinks in hand, although only for myself and Ron. "Heather, you made it!" Handing them drinks off to me and Ron, she gives her friend a long hug. I'm not bitter that this hug is okay, while mine was not. "Sorry you missed dinner. It was quite impressive."

"I'm sorry, too. Too much new work coming in. Can't complain though. Paul, did you have a chance to review those press releases I sent over?"

Eleanor clucks. "None of that, dear. Let's get you to the bar. Time to play catch up."

Heather laughs. "This isn't college anymore."

"No, this is Las Vegas."

“Oh, not you, too,” Heather groans. “You know, we studied the origins of that ad campaign in my MBA program. Pretty ingenious. Las Vegas was a place people associated first with gambling. They wanted to create an emotional connection, too, so they played up the sense of freedom that comes with this city. Here, people can be whoever they want to be. Here, they don’t need to think about their mortgages and their families and their jobs. Here, they’re free. Only, you do realize that that’s kind of the value prop for any vacation destination?”

Eleanor blinks at her, turns to me, and says, “Definitely sounds to me like she’s definitely too sober and needs to catch up, doesn’t it, Paul?”

“I don’t know. Professor Kingsley-Smith is kind of sexy.”

Heather fixes me with a crooked smile, one hand on her hip.

“And that is one thing that I never checked off my list—a sexy professor.” I give her an obvious once-over. “Although you could have changed out of your contacts to complete the illusion.”

“This one here has a hard time thinking beyond sex,” Eleanor says.

We all laugh at my expense. It’s fine. But something doesn’t quite feel right. When Heather smiles, it doesn’t quite reach her eyes.

I step closer, unable to help myself. I take her into my arms. “You sure you’re okay?”

She tenses and gives me a look that says, Later. “So you never did it with a prof?” She puts on a smile. “You missed out. Changed the meaning of ‘office hours’ for me.”

“Oh, I definitely fucked a TA during office hours. Just never made it to the top. That’s Big League promiscuity, lady.”

Eleanor and Ron watch our volley like a tennis match until Eleanor cuts in. “Come on, Heather. Let’s get those drinks and then you two can continue to discuss your sexual prowess.”

The evening is fun. My part in this conference is over. The keynote is done, I can just relax and enjoy what comes next. I can live in this moment, if only for a little while longer, before whatever it is I have with Heather goes back to “it’s really fucking complicated.”

But really, it’s all marketing magic. It’s a different place with all the same problems. If I was smarter and wiser, I would start thinking of her as Manhattan again. It’s safer for when the inevitable comes. It may not be Joshua she ends up with, but it’s a long shot that it’ll be me. I’m her rebound. I’m her Good Time.

I ignore the cold rock that falls through me. I’m not an introspective guy. I don’t navel gaze. I don’t “pine” for girls. That’s for guys like Ronald here. Or guys like Joshua. I’ve always been more straightforward than that. What would Dad think now?

A few people recognize me from the keynote. Our circle ebbs and flows as it turns into an impromptu networking session. Heather gives me the space to do my thing. I may have only been the charity’s accountant a few months ago, but I’ve always been good with people.

Denise from earlier turns up. I almost don’t recognize her. She’s changed into a black, sequined bodycon dress that ripples like liquid as she glides through the bar, headed right for me. Her curly hair is straightened now, framing her cover girl face before breaking into loose ringlets around her shoulders.

“Well, hello there,” she says. “We met earlier.”

“I remember. Denise.” She lights up when I remember her name. It’s all too easy. I go about the song and dance anyway, mostly because Heather is watching and I want to make her a little jealous. I say, “You’re alone.”

“I am. Are you?”

“Just celebrating with some colleagues.”

“The Memory Project rebrand,” she says.

“So someone did listen to my keynote.”

She smiles mischievously. “I caught parts of it.” She tucks a strand of dark hair over her ear. Her teardrop earring catches in the light. As does her wedding band. “Must have been lonely, just you and your ailing dad.”

“Dad was anything but lonely. That’s the thing about a guy who’s in his sixties but thinks he’s in his twenties.”

She laughs and does that thing with her hair again. At least it has the veneer of looking genuine, even if I know it’s not. She doesn’t really care about my upbringing or my sick dad. They never really do.

“So is this your first time at GPC?” Standard chit chat. I don’t want to put out the vibe that I am looking for a night-time companion, but I also don’t want to be rude to a potential donor.

We talk. Flirt even, because I can’t not flirt. Heather watches us, a Manhattan seemingly always full in her hand. Men come and go as well, but quickly seem to lose interest. That’s more like it. That’s more like the jealousy that I was hoping for this morning.

Denise doesn’t seem to pick up on my signals that nothing is going to happen, and somewhere into an hour of drinking, I learn why.

She takes out her phone, unlocks it. I see the app she’s opening and feel dread rise up inside of me before she even says a word.

“Hey, I hope I’m not being too forward, but I was wondering something,” she begins.

“What’s that?”

“How come you never answered my messages?”

I stare at her. She leans in, looking nervous, and whispers, “On DeBauch.”

“You found me there.” My voice is flat because this is a little too obvious. This isn’t a coincidence. She hears my skepticism, but chooses to interpret

it differently.

“I knew it. I thought it was you when we saw you take that stage, but Allison wasn’t so certain.”

“How...?”

“Well, the two of us were browsing last night. This is Vegas, after all, you know? We did, like, the proximity search thing—you wouldn’t believe how many people are on there in this city—and you were the hottest guy. Oh, em, gee, Allison’s going to flip out when I tell her I ran into you.”

She started to type into her phone, presumably a text, as I retrieved my own. Maybe her story wasn’t so far fetched? I’d used the location service for a hook up before. Did I just forget to turn it off here?

I boot up DeBauch for the first time since that fateful night with Heather, and sure enough, it’s loaded with messages to me.

“Which one are you?” I ask before I realize how callous that sounds. Heather would make some glib remark. Denise just laughs.

“Didi,” she says without bothering to look up from her phone. “Damn, she’s out with some other guy. Maybe I can get her to ditch him.”

I found the message from “Didi.” Surprisingly, it isn’t the only one I’ve received from last night, and there are some from today. I quickly shut down my location sharing before going back to Didi’s.

DIDI: Hey, good looking. Want to keep a couple lonely housewives company in Vegas?

Attached is a photo of Denise and Allison, from the neck down, wearing nothing but stockings. They stand closer, arms wrapped around each other's slim waists, their bodies as perfect as a couple twenty-somethings can be.

Denise, whose landing strip is dark brown as opposed to Allison's, who sports an inverted triangle of auburn, has a script tattooed up the side of her ribcage. I cannot read it.

Something doesn't feel right. Something's definitely off here. I look around the bar, the way Heather had before. Searching for him. For Joshua. I don't see him anywhere, but just have this feeling that he must be here. Like we're all unwitting players in his game.

"Excuse me, I need to use the restroom."

"Oh, I'm not going anywhere."

Heather is with a new man now, with a new drink in her hand. She no longer watches me furtively. In fact, she barely glances my way as I try to meet her eyes. I wonder how much she's had to drink.

In the privacy of the bathroom, I splash water on my face and try to work this out. Something is definitely off. Denise is too good to be true. I've been with countless women, and so rarely do they require literally zero work to get into bed, and here she comes, throwing herself at me—not once, not even twice, but three times if you count DeBauch last night.

About that... I load up DeBauch and my notifications. They began only when I arrived in Vegas. The last one before that was well before I hooked up with Heather. They were turned off. More worrisome, I have a public comment from today

"Exactly the experience I needed here in Vegas. To be fucked against the window overlooking the Vegas Strip is no longer on my bucket list. Five stars for Jameson. Would rec."

I clicked on the account associated with the review. I don't recognize the woman, although she's stunning.

“What the fuck?” I say aloud.

Before I can even begin to compose a text to Heather, the bathroom door opens. “This is taken,” I say.

“In that case, you really need to use the lock.” Denise. Here. Alone in the bathroom with me. This is bad. She sees the phone and frowns. “You’re not already looking for someone else, are you?”

“Did Joshua hire you?”

She freezes, and it’s in that moment that I know. “Hire me?” she deflects. Her indignation is good enough that I almost second guess myself. Almost. “What? You think because I’m on that app, you get to call me a whore?”

I raise the phone and snap a photo of her face, twisted in outrage. Even that way, she’s pretty. Even moreso. She probably does very well.

“What are you doing?”

“Record keeping. Now, can we go now? I think this charade’s run its course, yes?”

She searches my face for the possibility of salvaging this night. Seeing that she can’t, she slaps me. “You are a fucking pig, you know that? You can’t treat women this way, like you’re somehow so much better. I’ve seen those reviews. You’re on that fucking site. You fuck married women for sport. You’re a stunt cock. A sex toy. Talk about a fucking double standard.”

I set my hand on the door knob. “You done?”

I don’t wait for an answer. I push my shoulder into the door, eager to get away from this entrapment.

Heather is there at the end of the hall, waiting for me with a curious look on her face. I grin, raise my hand to wave. I’m buzzed enough that I don’t feel Denise exit behind me. I forget all about her until she wraps her arms around me from behind and brushes her hand across the front of my pants.

“That was fun,” she says, loud enough that Heather can hear.

I shake my head. She’s unbelievable. Heather takes the two of us in without a word, her expression flat. She nods, spins on her heels, and stalks away.

Heather

Just the Man

The jealousy comes on like a wave. I expect it, yet its strength still surprises me. I blame the drinks—I promised to pace myself, but those kinds of promises never work for me. I blame this city and my history with it. I blame myself for getting caught up in it all and letting my guard down.

Even as I walk away, the crash of casino noise dizzying and exhilarating, I can see that bitch's arms around Paul, can see her hand run along his cock. My gut craters. Heat licks up the back of my neck and along my scalp.

I'm not used to this. Not with Joshua. Certainly not with the controlling and abusive nature of my ex, Shane, or any of the many men I was with before. Intellectually, I know that jealousy often comes on when one's possessions are threatened, and that I never felt like Joshua or Shane or any of the others were truly mine.

But Paul is?

The Mannhattans make it impossible to think it through. I cannot follow those implications, and when I try, my insides start to constrict and stop.

Despite all of that, I'm not so distracted that I don't see Joshua hidden in the chaos of the casino floor, seemingly engrossed in a slot machine and wearing a Yankees baseball cap, sweats and a hoodie. For Joshua, it's a damn good disguise. I almost laugh. Instead, I pretend that I don't see him as I storm past.

Of course he's here, circling like a carrion bird as he waits for the death of my relationship with Paul. Once, I enjoyed his voyeurism and convinced

myself that it was how we could connect. Now I know how fucked up it really is.

Keep watching, Joshua. I know you can't help yourself.

The casino floor is dotted with other bars and drinking holes. Some are themed. Others are just places for cocktail waitresses to refill drinks and lonely patrons to sit and play video poker. Or get picked up.

“Hey. I hate to see a lonely girl frowning. Especially here.” It takes less than five minutes for the line to come my way.

“People aren’t allowed to be lonely in Vegas?”

“Not people with shoulders as pretty as yours.”

Okay, that makes me laugh. “First time I’ve ever been complimented on my shoulders.”

He’s not my type. He’s more like the persona Joshua is wearing—hoodie, baseball hat—only this guy has a full-on beard. Not a fan. Still, he likes my shoulders.

“Then maybe you haven’t worn a shirt like that.” He waves his hand in the general vicinity of my shoulders, left bare by the blouse. “I’m a big fan of nice shoulders on women.”

“Okay...” He’s drinking Bud Light out of a long neck bottle. “Get me one of those. We can talk more about your weird fetish.”

This guy looks surprised, like he put a chip on a single number at the roulette table and it hit. He hides it well, though, signaling to the bartender to get another beer. I glance out at the casino as he does, pretending not to see the disguised Joshua before meeting Paul’s eyes.

Unlike my husband, Paul stands in the open, leaning against the end of the slot machines, his arms crossed, watching. I wave at him and smile, channeling as much, Eat your heart out into the gesture as I can.

I don't blame Paul, despite my jealousy. It's one of those conflicts between head and heart. Still, I'm allowed to feel jealous. Isn't that what Eleanor said? Or, no, I'm allowed to feel... to feel...

"Hey, hey, what's wrong, Sweetheart."

I've had enough that I don't even bristle at the 'sweetheart', and when he puts his arms around me, I only just barely stem the tears. "I'm sorry, I'm sorry. You must think I'm crazy."

"No. I think you're sad and lonely. And you've now known me long enough to know how much I hate that." He also just sees a hot blonde with exposed shoulders and no other man around. Little does he know our audience...

I pull back. He ducks low to look me in the eyes. I grab him by the back of his neck and pull him in for a wet, sloppy kiss. The beard doesn't even tickle that much, so much softer than I expected. I tell him that. Believe it or not, I've never been with a man with a full beard.

The kiss is electrifying, but not because of this man, or the beard, or even my state of inebriation. It's intense because of my audience. Because I know what this does to Joshua, and I hope it does the same to Paul. I hope that Paul feels that same, sinking feeling in his gut as he watches.

God, I'm such a mess. To this man, I apologize. "I'm sorry I did that."

"You know you don't need to apologize for that, right?"

"I'm leading you on."

"You can lead me to your bedroom if you want."

I actually consider it. He's tall, with big hands, and under that hoodie, he's got strong shoulders. The beard would be an interesting experience, feeling all that soft hair brushing along my mound. It would be a fun experience, and would teach both of those men that I am not a possession to be owned—lessons they both should learn, but for different reasons.

I smile weakly at him and shake my head. “I’m sorry, but I don’t want that. Maybe you’ll have better luck. Try the pool tomorrow. Plenty of shoulders on display there.”

I leave him in the lounge, feeling bad about using him. He seemed nice enough. I keep my eyes on Paul—making sure that Joshua sees it, too. This next part is important.

“Where’s your tramp?” I say it loud enough to draw a few eyes. More importantly, I say it loud enough that Joshua can hear.

“Gone.”

“That’s a shame. She was hot. We could have had some fun together.”

He doesn’t bite.

“I could go back and see if my friend there is still free. Maybe the four of us could party.”

He looks at my beer. “He bought you a Bud Light?”

I almost crack a smile. God, this fucking man! “Now you have a problem with the kind of alcohol I drink?”

“No, just...”

“Let me guess. You thought I was better than this cheap beer?” I take an exaggerated swig. “Why did you come here? You like watching, too? I could give you a real show if that’s your kink.”

I actually see curiosity move behind those sexy, dark eyes of his. It’s infuriating. “You’re drunk,” he says instead.

“It’s Vegas, baby. I’ve been a whole lot worse before.”

“There you two are.” Eleanor’s crisp voice finds us. A moment later, the woman arrives with Ronald in tow. “Is everything alright here?”

“Just fine,” we both say in unison.

Eleanor looks between us, clearly not believing it. The plan was to go out and dance somewhere. Sizing up the situation quickly, Eleanor pivots. She steps between us, links her arms with ours, and says, “Let’s go, you two. No sense in making a scene here.”

“Too late,” Paul says.

I glare at him, politely tugging my arm back. “It’s fine. I’m going to bed. Alone.”

“Heather…” Eleanor begins.

I just shake my head. “I should get some rest. Need to get a good night’s rest for that panel discussion tomorrow.”

“Of course.”

Paul is silent as I breeze away. Joshua watches it all, and I hate that look of satisfaction I catch beneath the low brim of his baseball hat.



Paul comes to me in the night. I knew that he would. I feel his weight on the bed, crawling across it and waking me from whatever fitful sleep I’d fallen into. He doesn’t apologize. I’m glad. I don’t want him to.

“I brought you something,” he whispers.

He smells good, but boozy. I twist, looking up at him. “Does it have a cock?”

He snorts, setting something cold on the nightstand. I fumble for my glasses and laugh out loud when I see the bottle of Bud Light he’s brought,

wrapped in a cocktail napkin. “So thoughtful.”

He kisses the side of my neck. His whiskers are a lot scratchier than the man’s beard from earlier. “So you were actually jealous?”

I sit up, taking a swig of the cold, tasteless beer. He’s already naked, his hard body so tempting. I can just make out the carved pecs and thick arms in the low light. “Momentary insanity. Were you?”

“Did that guy really have a chance?”

“No.”

“So if I fuck you now, it doesn’t count as reclamation?”

“That’s the problem with you men. ‘Reclamation’ implies that I’m an object that you are getting back. You really think I’m your property?”

“You know that I don’t.” He kisses me, and I don’t resist.

“I know that if it weren’t for me, you’d be fucking that girl right now.”

He pushes me onto my back. Beer slops onto the corner of the bed before I can set it back on the nightstand. “And if it weren’t for me, what would you be doing, Manhattan?”

He mounts me, his cock thick as it slides along my cunt. “Probably fucking Joshua.”

I see it sting as it lands. Good. Finally some fucking jealousy from this man. He thrusts into me. We arch up together, groaning in unison.

He pins my hands above my head, his fingers lacing with mine as he fucks me. He seeks domination. Maybe he finds it physically, but neither of us is in control. This wouldn’t be reclamation sex even if I did fuck that other guy. This is something else—something more profound.

I look up at him, a man constructed of shadows. He hides himself there, behind a bull-shaped mask. I want to take it off, to understand him, to

unpack him—to connect. But it's not my place to remove it. It's his. Will he, for me?

I close my eyes and let myself feel him. I live in the moment, focusing on his heavy breath, the way his cock feels as it drives deep, the way our skin slides damp and slippery where we touch and our hips rise and fall together as one. Right now, this is all that matters—the fleeting sensation of pleasure so deep I want to crawl into it and lose myself.

Tomorrow will inevitably come. We can't prevent that. We cannot hold onto this moment forever. But right now, beneath this man and all his appetites, he is mine, and I am his, and this is exactly where I want to be.

Paul

Setup

I wake up alone. Heather is gone, off to breakfast where she will huddle one last time with Mason and the other members of her panel discussion. I touch her empty spot beside me. It's cold.

I should be used to this—waking alone after a night of incredible sex. I am used to this. Yet it still feels different. I miss her presence in a way that I've never felt with any of the others.

"I know that if it weren't for me, you'd be fucking that girl right now."

With my head clearer, I can reflect more on Heather's heat-of-the-moment statement. A month ago, that was certainly true. Hell, two weeks ago, I would have given Denise the ride of her life, regardless of whether it was a set up or not. Now, while it was fun to flirt with her last night, in hindsight, it felt hollow, a dead tree rotted from the inside.

I sit up in bed and think about that. Is that what I am? Empty on the inside? It's certainly the man I was raised to be.

That damn speech has me thinking a lot about Dad these days. And Mom. In my keynote, I said that I didn't blame her for leaving. That was a lie. I did. I resented her. She left us. She left me all alone to deal with my ailing father on my own.

I get out to bed and take a cold shower. Enough of the past. The future is uncertain enough. Joshua was behind Denise. The man is dangerous. After all the things that Heather told me about them, I know not to let my guard down. He's capable of anything.

Like hacking my DeBauch account? In the rollercoaster of last night, I forgot about the strange review I received yesterday, or how my account was activated when I swore I turned it off. I double check, and sure enough, I didn't imagine it last night.

It's like he's with me everywhere I go, watching from just around the corner. The door opens at the end of the long hallway, and I'm more surprised when it's not Joshua Fletcher in a thin disguise stepping out. I keep looking for him in every crowd I pass, in every clutch of gamblers. I don't ever find him, but I still feel the eyes. Like everyone is in on the secret. It's a level of paranoia that I have never felt. I cannot relax.

I attend Heather's panel discussion, which tackles diversity and inclusion at the board level for various charities and funds. Not wanting to distract, I sit in the back as they tackle some of the heaviest issues of the time.

After, there's a luncheon to dive deeper into these issues that's closed to the public. I wave at her and Mason. She acknowledges me with a smile that I feel in my chest, and is gone.

I have nowhere that I need to be, and since Heather's bed is not an option right now, I have two choices—the casino floor or the pool. The pool has more eye candy, and I guess old habits die hard.

I grab a quick bite on the way out to the expansive pool areas of the casino and resort. The sun is high, the sky is bright, and even just after noon, the place is hopping. A DJ spins club music by the pool bar, which is packed with young, attractive men and women wearing next to nothing.

I pull my shirt off, my toned chest and shoulders earning me a few appreciative looks. A pair of MILFs in bikinis glance my way, one even lowering her sunglasses to take in my hairless pecs. I wink at her before heading toward the bar to start the party.

I feel buoyant, my head and my heart full. Despite this whole scene, Heather floats above it all. As I order a beer, I imagine her poke fun at me drinking so early in the day. As I settle into my lounge and check out the other bathers, I wish she was here to ogle with me.

I browse my phone, diving into DeBauch once again—not to find a hookup, but to investigate. Since arriving in Las Vegas, five different women reached out to me. Denise (and her friend, Allison) two nights back, of course, with the sexy photo of their naked bodies there. Others are more subtle, all asking if I'm free for a drink.

How many of these is Joshua behind? I call up one, from a woman whose screen name is simply JaneF. The account does not appear to be fake. It was registered a year ago, and there are a good number of Hearts on it. I consider writing her back, just to see if she responds, but think better of it. Nothing good can come of that.

The others stand up to similar scrutiny—even Denise's. If she's a prostitute hired by Joshua, she's also legitimately on DeBauch. I start to second guess myself when a shadow passes over me.

For a second, I think it's Heather, sun catching in her hair like a golden halo, a silhouette of toned curves and smooth skin. Then she speaks, and her husky voice carries a hint of an accent that I cannot place. "On your phone when there's so many other things that you could be looking at.

I darken the phone as she settles into the lounge next to me. I cannot see her eyes behind her oversized sunglasses, but I don't need to. I see the offer in that smile. Go ahead and look. I do.

She's hot and curvy, an hourglass body with tits that spill out of her leopard-print bikini top. I catch the flash of her pierced navel before she rolls onto her stomach and unties her top.

"Do my back for me?" This is another set up. Has to be. I know I'm good looking, but even I don't get women throwing themselves at me like this. Still, I look around, but don't see anything else suspicious. No Joshua. No cameras pointed my way.

She shakes her tube of sunblock at me impatiently. I chuckle as I get off my lounge and take it from her. "I have a girlfriend."

I don't think I've said those words since high school, and while it's not precisely true, nevertheless it sends a thrill through me—just as it did back when I was a teenager.

“Good for you,” she says. “And I'm called Melena.”

I can't help but smile. It's precisely what I would have said were the tables turned. I squirt the sunblock into my hands. She has a great body, and my fingers slide across her soft, heated skin like an impromptu massage.

“You have a nice touch,” she coos.

“You're nice to touch.” Kneejerk comment. I'm leading her on, but can't help it. Most likely, this woman has also been sent by Joshua to entrap me. I have to give the man credit, though. He's picked some very sexy traps to send at me. “I'll have to thank Joshua.”

She doesn't tense the way I figured that she would. She doesn't immediately play ignorant, either. Her silence confuses me, and for a moment, I wonder if she even heard me. I sweep my fingers wide, rubbing the sunblock down her sides and along the outsides of her breasts. “I'm curious. What did he ask you to do to me?”

Now she shifts, turning her head enough to glance at me sideways. “He just said you'd be fun. Are you fun, Paul?”

So she knows my name, too. “I've never had any real complaints.”

She reaches back, brushing her hand along my cock. I'm not hard, but neither am I soft. “I can feel that.”

“Forward, aren't you?”

“Feels like we're past games, yes?” She's turned enough that I catch a glimpse of her nipple, a rich, dark brown.

“I'm not going to fuck you.” I don't stop smiling, though, nor do I stop rubbing her back. Instead, I press my fingers down her back, making sure to get the sunscreen along the top of her bikini bottoms.

“Because you have a girlfriend.”

“Because Joshua sent you. I don’t need his help getting laid.”

Her laugh, as far as I can tell, is genuine. A server comes by and sets a couple of shots of clear liquid before us. “At least drink some tequila with me, will you? I promise I will not suck your cock.”

She doesn’t fix her top as she takes the shot glasses. Her tits are perfectly formed—too perfect to be real, just like this whole situation. I take the tequila anyway, clink it against hers, and say, “To Joshua.”

She laughs, downs her shot, and lowers herself back to the lounge. I stand back up and lower myself to my own. “It was nice meeting you, Melena. Give Joshua my regards.”

“Oh, I will...”

The tequila comes on strong. Maybe it’s the hot sun and my mostly empty stomach, but as soon as I close my eyes, the world grows fuzzy and begins to lurch.

“You know, you should call your girlfriend.” I hear Melena’s voice like she’s walking away, only when I force my eyes open, she’s right there, sitting on the edge of my chair, her hip touching my arm. “You seem more than man enough to handle two.”

Something isn’t right. Her hand traveling down my chest shouldn’t feel this good. When it reaches the trail of short hairs, I groan in anticipation for what comes next.

“Come on,” she whispers. “Let’s go somewhere more private.”

Everything is super saturated when I try to open my eyes. The sky is even more blue. Why didn’t I notice the vibrant red of her bikini? When I blink, it feels like forever.

“Hey, hey, stay with me, Jameson,” she says. Her touch is as soft as her voice. The huskiness isn’t gone. “Come on, let’s get you out of the sun.”

I feel myself being guided up. I touch her hair, like a flowing river of molten gold. I can barely look past her.

“He’s had too much sun,” she explains to someone. To me, she says, “It’s okay, Paul. Heather’s here. Stay with me. Stay with your Mandy.”

And then the light eats itself and all I see is the dark.



“Such a big cock.” I wake to the British accent and the slippery feeling of a wet mouth on my dick. With a slurp, she pops off. “I want to watch you ride this big, fucking cock.”

Another woman’s giggle joins the first. I open my eyes, still groggy, the world a smear of light and shadow. Eleanor’s dark hair brushes my balls as she bobs along my cock one more time, taking it deep before slowly pulling away, releasing me with a loud pop.

My eyes don’t adjust before Heather straddles me, her long hair sweeping across her naked back. I groan, thrusting up and reaching forward to grab her hips. She rolls her pelvis, stroking my shaft with each undulation. It feels so good.

But also, so wrong.

Something’s wrong.

This picture... it’s not right.

“Fuck, that’s hot.”

Eleanor stands at the foot of the bed, her phone out, recording Heather and I having sex. Only it’s not Eleanor, I realize, standing there in a black garter

belt, stockings, and nothing else. “What the fuck?” My voice comes out thick, like the air is soup.

“Say cheese,” Denise says.

The woman riding me—she doesn’t have a tattoo on her tailbone, and she’s too curvy to be Heather. I realize it just as she turns to look over her shoulder. Melena. Of fucking course.

I move to push her off of me, but it’s too late. The trap has already been sprung, and what comes next is inevitable. The door opens and an enraged Heather—the real Heather—comes storming in, looking like she’s been chewing nails.

“I fucking knew it!”

Denise covers herself, pretending like this wasn’t all part of the plan. She’s a good actress. Melena continues to fuck me, her hands clutching my knees as I try to push her off.

“Heather, this isn’t—”

“—what it looks like? So you don’t have your dick in that slut?” She surveys the room. I follow her eyes. It’s a wreck. These two have done a great job making it look like we fucked all over the place. She turns on Denise. “You’re the slut from last night.”

“Are you, like, married? I... I had no idea. He never said anything—”

“Shut it, Girlie. No one asked you for your input.”

I manage to get Melena off me. My cock flops, still embarrassingly hard.

“Heather, I was—”

“And you,” she cuts me off. The rage seethes out of her pours. I can’t tell if she wants to scream or cry or laugh. I know not to speak. I know this is her moment, not mine. She slowly shakes her head from side to side, like she’s finally connecting the dots, and sighs. Holding up her hands, palms out, she

says, “You know what? Whatever. Marketing wins all. When in Vegas, right?”

She turns. I find my voice. “Heather, wait.”

She pauses, looking at me over her shoulder. “Like you couldn’t?”

Ouch.

“It’s fine, Paul. I get it, and I get you. I always did, right from the beginning. I just let myself see something else in a moment of temporary insanity. You’re a great fuck, and no one should be putting a yoke on a bull, anyway, right?”

With that, she storms out of my life.

Heather

SMS

Joshua: You okay?

Me: Why wouldn't I be okay?

Joshua: ...

Me: You spying on me, or spying on Paul?

Joshua: I don't give a fuck about Paul. I care about you, though, Heather.

Me: So you say.

Minutes pass...

Me: You can say it.

Joshua: What?

Me: I told you so.

Joshua: I'm not going to do that.

Me: Now you're the gentleman.

Joshua: I want to be. Heather, I know you're not ready to forgive me. I get it. But I love you, and I'll wait for you. I'll be there when all the Pauls in your life move on, and I hate to say it, but guys like Paul? They move on.

Me: See? There you go. That's basically an 'I told you so.'

Joshua: I didn't mean it that way.

More minutes pass...

Me: I know.

Joshua: So... you okay?

Me: I will be. I'm a big girl, remember?

Joshua: It's what makes you so sexy.

Me: ::eyeroll::

*Me: Paul seemed to have luck with DeBauch out here. What do you think?
Should I do some browsing?*

Joshua: Can I watch?

Me: I'm still mad at you.

Joshua: Cruel.

*Me: Or maybe I'll go to Eleanor's party tomorrow night. I hear it's
definitely going to be a real big girl affair.*

Joshua: Affair? Tell me more.

Me: No, I don't think that I will.

Joshua: Some day, maybe?

Me: You do remember that I'm pretty fucking pissed at you, right?

Joshua: I just had a revelation.

Me: This ought to be good.

Joshua: To get back at Paul, I mean. You should sleep with me. There's one thing I know about alpha guys like him, and that's that they hate to lose to other alphas.

Me: That's a brilliant idea, Joshua.

Joshua: Thanks.

Me: But you're not the alpha I have in mind.

Joshua: Hm?

Me: Bye, love! Thanks for the idea.

Hours later...

Me: I don't know why I'm sending you this, but... come to Alibi's tonight at 9. Be discreet.

Paul

Rivals

Whatever I was drugged with, it takes hours to get out of my system. I take a cold shower. I walk up and down the Strip. I go back to my room, lock the door, and try to sleep it off. By evening, only the last tendrils of nausea and grogginess are there. I'm still left unsettled.

Throughout all my fast and loose life, drugs have never been part of it. I've never needed the extra boost, and while I don't mind a little lost control every now and then, I prefer to lose myself in the sex. I double down on that commitment now.

There's an event tonight. There's always a fucking event. This one, I have to go to as the acting director of the Memory Project and a keynote speaker. After a second cold shower, I get dressed and head down.

Mason Coles is there, holding court with some other philanthropists. I wave and begin to mingle, although I'm only half present. And I stay away from the drinks. I doubt Joshua will try anything again—he's done his damage—but doesn't make me any less wary.

"You look like shit." Mason catches up with me as the event winds down.

"Had a rough day." I'm not looking for his sympathy, though, so we move past it. "Caught your round table. Nice job, man."

"Yeah, thanks. It was less awkward than I thought it would be." He glances around and grins. "And it's already paying dividends."

"Chicks love a sensitive side."

He rubs his chin. “That they do.” Looking at me, he adds, “One chick in particular, if you feel me.”

My chest tightens. I feel him. “So is that why you agreed to do the panel with her?”

“Nah. I believe in the cause, too. Let’s call it a perk.” He looks so proud of himself. Makes me want to smack him. “Speaking of perks, you reconsider the big party tomorrow?”

I’m still not quite my true self. Mason misinterprets that as contemplation. He points a finger at me, his smile widening. “You are. You are!” He reaches into his jacket and pulls out a business card. Jotting something on the back, he hands it to me. “Tomorrow night. Go to that address. Starts at ten. It’ll be tight.”

He laughs, slapping the table. “Now it’s about time for me to get to Alibis. I’d ask you to wish me luck, but since when did guys like us need luck?”

I should go to bed. I should let this next part play out without me. I’m feeling something weird. Something I’m not quite used to. I go so far as to consider calling up Ronald Heller before I realize that (a) he’s probably watching his wife getting fucked by some DeBauch stranger right now, and (b) I am not anything like him. This isn’t some cuckold thing. Whatever.

Yet I can’t stay away. I find myself outside of Alibis, a bar with lounges built around the outside of the resort’s open air courtyard. A towering, outdoor chimney dominates the space, surrounded by Adirondack chairs to make small conversation areas. They are all currently empty.

It’s pleasant outside, the blistering heat of a Vegas summer giving way to the cooler, desert evening. Each face of the chimney has its own fireplace, and all burn invitingly. Tempted by the wood smoke, I sink into one of the slope-backed chairs and pull out my phone, although that’s not where my attention is.

No. All that attention’s on the bar—Alibis—and on the patronage. It’s like a sixth sense or something. I know she’s there before I even find her. I feel

her pull on every atom in my body. When I do catch a glimpse of her through the shifting silhouettes that bleed away to distraction, I feel a great, profound loss. Loss like I'm not used to. Loss that I haven't felt since my dad.

In a short, white dress, strapless and curve-skimming, she knows people are looking, fantasizing, coveting. Bare shoulders and back, her strides long on her tall, white heels, she seems to feed off of the attention, while somehow ignoring all of it.

Mason's waiting, holding court at the bar with his jovial smile, nursing a tall pilsner glass. He stands when he sees her, and my gut tightens.

I look away, searching the crowd for the other player in this scene. I find him sitting in a booth between me and the bar, watching them over his menu, and it takes every ounce of self-control not to walk over to him and run my fist into his sharp jaw. Joshua Fletcher, a man who I hated even before he drugged me, watches as his wife flirts with another man.

"Can I get you anything to drink?" A woman in an Alibi polo and a flirty smile breaks me from my murderous thoughts.

"I didn't realize you serve all the way out here."

"Only to guys I think are hot." She's hot, but I write her off, my nerves still frayed. This could be another trap. Even if it wasn't, I'm not interested.

"Jameson on the rocks."

I don't hear her acknowledge. I don't even remember her leave.

Mason and Heather—Manhattan—have come together at the bar now, her vibrant white against his dark skin. Joshua watches the exchange like a predator, and I realize that this unsettling feeling I'm having is that of exclusion. I'm not part of this scene. I don't figure into this equation.

I look at Heather, and realize how badly I want to be part of this.

They order drinks, and when hers arrives in a delicate martini glass, the liquid the color of cherries, my stomach sinks. A Manhattan. I have no right to feel the way that I do, but there it is anyway—betrayal. If I had a therapist, he would probably tell me to own my feelings rather than deny them. My dad would tell me to get a grip and stop being a pussy. I guess that's why I am the man that I am.

What happens next is inevitable. The bar fills up as more people pack in around them. It forces Heather close to Mason. She tosses her hair, smiles, laughs at his jokes as she tells some of her own. Behind them, Joshua watches and broods. I do as well.

Mason gets closer. He reaches out, touching her cheek. I cringe at the intimacy. He says something that makes her roll her eyes. Yet she laughs.

My insides tighten. Is this how Ronald Heller feels? How can he stand it?

Mason keeps up his game. He can sense victory as surely as I can see it. He presses, whispering more, and suddenly things get serious. She actually looks out, her eyes flicking around the crowd. Joshua hides behind his menu. I'm sure I'm far enough away that she can't see me in the night's gloom, but I feel like hiding, too. Then, turning back to Mason, she nods.

I'm powerless in my voyeurism. I drain my glass of Jameson—a glass that I don't even remember being delivered—as I ponder that. Voyeur. I never considered myself one who watches, but I can't really deny that it's...intriguing. I'm so used to being the bull, to being the one watched, that I've never paused to consider what they get out of watching.

But it's frustrating, too. I can't hear what they're saying. I can't hear the flirty words. And when they inevitably go up to a room to take things further, it'll all happen away from me--out of sight. How do these hotwife husbands and cucks deal with that?

They stand, Mason's hand on the small of Heather's back as she collects her clutch to her side. They wind their way through the thick crowd, and it feels like my soul is being stretched tighter and tighter until they are gone.

I lift the empty glass of Irish whiskey until the ice clatters against my teeth. I shrug. At least I'm not feeling drugged. Not a trap, after all. I stand, listless now that Heather is gone. I float away. And I definitely, definitely do not think about why I had to fight back an erection before I could stand at all.

Heather

Mason Coles

I let myself release control. I can do that now. I can let Mason lead me out of the bar, everyone's eyes on us knowing where we're going, and it's fine. This isn't like when I was younger. This isn't like my bad boy ex-boyfriend, Shane. It's out of control, but only because I allow it to be out of control. I let myself sink into this moment.

All those things I used to feel—nervous, giddy, horny—back when I was single are here, welcoming me like an old friend. I'd felt it when I used to play games with Joshua, of course, but that was never going to end with me in another man's bed. That was never going to be real.

This? I feel Mason press his hand into the small of my back. I can smell the spice of him. This is real.

I glance back at the one pair of eyes that I care about. They're dark. They're jealous. They want me. That's thrilling. Doubt runs through me, just as intoxicating as anything else. This is exactly what Joshua wanted all these years. What a journey it has taken to get here.

The moment slides on, and we're suddenly in front of Mason's hotel room door. "I'm this one," he says as he swings the door open. His suite is huge, nearly as large as the one we've reserved for the PR agency's client meetings.

The door clicks shut behind us. I catch his form in the window reflection, looming large and dark and full of expectation—and yet I have no idea what to expect. Will he be rough, the way Joshua sometimes gets after a night of playing this game? Will he push me onto my knees, or shove me

against the wall? Will he throw me over his shoulder and carry me into the bedroom?

I have no answers, and realize how hot that feeling is—like the promiscuous version of new relationship energy.

From behind, he wraps an arm around me, his hand sweeping across my stomach and up the side of my ribs. I turn to look at him over my shoulder. The hunger in his tight expression reflects my own. He licks his lips, so full, so kissable.

I rock my head back further as he leans in and plants those lips on mine. His hand rises higher, palming my breast as he pushes his tongue into my parting mouth. I moan against him. There's nothing tentative about our first kiss. We're not school kids. Neither of us is new to this game.

I turn in his arms. Kissing over the shoulder may be a hot way to start things, but it's not the most comfortable. I want to feel him against me. I want to feel his hard body press into my own, want to touch his thick neck and grip his cock in my hand.

He's huge. As large as my wildest imagination. My pussy tightens, just thinking about how it'll feel. How sex with yet another man will feel.

I kiss Mason harder. I'm all in. I grab him by the shirt, his shoulder blades as wide as wings. We stumble back into the room, over to the sofa, kissing and groping. I see red. I feel like fire. Blood throbs in my ears.

I don't even make it to the cushions of that sofa. He pushes me onto the armrest, bending me over it as he pushes my short dress up to my hips.

"Nice tramp stamp, Princess," he groans, spotting the tiara tattoo on my tailbone. I expect a slap—welcome it. He doesn't deliver. I look over my shoulder again, in time to see him slide to a squat, pulling my thong down to my knees.

He dips down, out of view. I feel his stubble on my thighs and his tongue bathe my pussy lips. It's divine, wet yet firm. He teases my slit before his

hands get into the mix. Both hands. One slipping across my clitoris, the other hand teases my asshole. Lightning flashes in the distance. I hear the rumbling of thunder deep within my soul.

“Oh...oh God.” I don’t make it a habit to fake excitement, but I’ve been known to overplay it if it can get my guy excited. With Mason eating me out, I don’t need to overplay a damn thing. I’m out of my mind. His touch, his tongue, his fingers, rip my moans from me. “Uhhh, that feels so fucking—yes!”

I’m not forming those words. They come from somewhere completely disconnected from conscious thought, the reptilian brain suddenly warm blooded and alive.

When he presses his thumb against my asshole, the lightning arrives with fire and fury. I lift my ass. His tongue finds my clit. His thumb feels huge inside of me.

I whine as he pulls back. My orgasm still ricochets through me as I hear the metallic clasp of his belt. It sounds simultaneously divine and profoundly sinful. My heart clenches. I feel dipped in flame.

But I don’t want to just feel this threshold being crossed. I want to see it. I want to revel in it. I slide out from under him, getting to my feet. He unzips himself. I step forward, shoving my thumbs into his boxers, right at his hips, and push them down.

He grabs my head, kissing me as I free his cock. I taste myself on his lips and tongue like an exotic cocktail laced with a powerful aphrodisiac. I kiss him even harder as I feel his naked cock in my hands. I have long fingers, but they feel tiny with all that throbbing meat in them.

“You’re huge,” I say—and only partly to stroke his ego. “I can’t fucking wait to feel that thing inside of me.”

He grins. “All you have to do is ask, baby.”

I step back, reach down, and pull my short, white dress over my head. He feasts on my naked body—my bare cunt, my flat stomach, my full tits as I free them from my bra. I am his wet dream.

But right now, I'm here for me. For my pleasure. For what I want.

He pulls his shirt off. His dark skin is radiant, catching the light like rich satin. His muscles carve a hard path down his perfect body, thick chest yielding to cut abs yielding to a swinging cock too long and heavy to stand out straight. He's shaved completely, making the dark, uncircumcised manhood look supernatural.

He holds up his phone. It intensifies this feeling of bold exposure. I don't cover up or shy away, though. I'm ready for this. "Say it again," he says.

I look right into the camera. "You've got a big dick, and I can't wait to feel it inside of me." I know who will see this, and that knowledge nearly makes my voice quiver. "Show me that you know how to use it."

He tosses the phone onto the bed before advancing on me like a predator. I don't become his prey. I stand my ground, confident and in full command. He will manhandle me, but only because I want him to.

Our kiss is wild, careening out-of-control. He grabs me by the ass, lifting my five foot, nine inches like it's nothing. I wrap my legs around his waist as he carries me towards the bedroom, my pussy pressing with the full weight of my body onto the thickening erection. He smells so good, spicy, new. I dig my nails into the back of his neck with one hand, the other palming his shaved head.

We tumble into bed, his arms like columns around me, his weight crushing my tits. I spread my legs as he lifts his hips. His cock brushes along my gash, hitting my clit as he strokes my smooth mound with it.

"How am I doing so far?" he asks knowingly.

"So far, just parlor tri—iiicks!"

He reaches between us, grabbing his cock and wielding it the way I would an oversized dildo. He's done this before. Countless times. I'm breathless with anticipation for what comes next.

"You want this," he says.

He presses harder, rubbing his cock back and forth against my clit. I moan, digging my nails deeper into his neck. I want him to gasp, just as I gasp. He doesn't.

"You want to feel my big, black cock, Princess."

I try to find my center, but it's a struggle even to open my eyes. He's right there, looming above me, his face inches away.

"Stop teasing me and do it."

Mason's nostrils flare. His smile tugs at his cheeks. I catch a flash of white teeth before he adjusts over me. Before he drags his cock along my clit one last time. Before he places me against my pussy, where he cannot possibly be as large as that feels and—

"Fuck!"

He's huge and thick and intense. He slides all that girth into me in one long, languid motion that seems to go on and on. It's like he's confirming for me that yes, he is that big and yes, he is definitely that thick. He hits places that no one has in so long. Not even Paul. He makes me feel so fucking full.

My eyes actually roll back, my chest heaving forward. Mason sucks on my right nipple, adding to the sensory overload that I feel.

It's so much. So good. So overwhelming.

And only then does Mason finally unleash himself upon me.

"No more teasing," he says, his voice a rumble of threatening promise. He takes me hard, fucking me fast without ever losing his rhythm. I feel controlled, yet completely out-of-control.

“Oh, shit. Oh, my God.”

“Not exactly a thing a princess would say.”

I try to formulate some kind of witty retort. All that comes out is a long string of moans. I stop trying. I turn that side of my brain off and sink into the part of me that loves this sensation of carnal submission.

Mason fucks me. Sweat lathers our bodies as I’m pressed down and down and down into the mattress by this beautiful man and his thick cock. I can’t get enough. I mew. I gasp. I swear.

But fucking is more than just pumping. It’s more than just thrusting. It’s so much more than a cock in a pussy. Mason knows this. He uses it.

He rises onto his knees, his cock never leaving me, never giving me a break. He tugs one leg over his shoulder, twisting me to his will and wrestling away what little control I cling to. Somehow, he goes deeper. So deep it’s painful.

“Watch us,” he says, his eyes off to the side. Like someone else is there in the room. My heart jumps as I look where he does, half expecting to see Joshua.

Instead, I see our reflection in the sliding glass doors that lead out to his balcony, my pale, white skin in high contrast to his dark, glossy body.

“Better than all the interracial porn you fantasize to,” he says, locking his gaze on me through the reflection.

Shame snaps through me. I have watched interracial porn. I have fantasized about this, knowing I should be better than that. Knowing that we’re all more than our skin color or our hair color or how we look.

But then that shame falls away. I let myself release the delicious secret inside of me, just for a few moments, and be the woman I’ve tried to repress. If Mason is fine being my black bull, I’m fine being his Barbie, his blonde fantasy, his whore.

“Fuck me,” I hiss. “Give me that cock. Give me that black dick.”

Mason goes wild. I can almost see how he darkens, how his nostrils flare like a charging bull's. He splays me open, one leg up against his chest, the other down. It's raunchy. It's raw. Nothing obstructs the view of his very big, very black shaft sliding in and out of my bald and bare pussy.

I can't hold back. I don't want to. Not anymore. I reach down, watching myself find my clit, tap it, flick it. Mason sees the act, too, pounding me, faster and faster, harder and harder. Here it comes. This is it. I drum my clit so hard I can hear the slapping sounds, even over the hard pants we make.

I can't hold out any longer. I can't stave off the inevitable. I don't want to.

“Uhhh, fuck!” I arch back, my eyes tight as the sensation of all that cock burns through my core. He continues to hammer, continues to fuck. I lose my mind, rolling through my orgasms.

He turns me onto my hands and knees. I groan when his cock slides free. I cry out as he drives home again, this time from behind. This time, he takes his time fucking me. This isn't a race anymore. We're sightseeing through the world of Mason Coles, professional bull. It's quite a world.

Paul

Unknown

I cannot sleep despite how emotionally exhausting this day has been. I cannot workout because of the drinks, and I cannot go hitting on women because... because I don't really feel like it. Strange feeling, that.

I go down to the gym anyway and lose myself in the sauna. Maybe I can sweat some of this anxious energy out. Heather—Manhattan—whatever I should call her, she's in my chief rival's bed right now, and while I can deal with that, what I'm having a harder time managing is how it turns me on.

I enter the sauna alone. I leave it alone. When I shower and get back to my phone, though, I see the messages. I knew there would be messages. My hand trembles as I unlock and read. They're all from an unknown number, although the owner is obvious.

[unknown]: Looks like we both lose in the end.

[unknown]: She didn't choose either of us.

[unknown]: Doubt this'll be the last guy she fucks in Vegas. Hell, maybe there have been others.

His words are poison. Even knowing it, it's hard to ignore the bite of that venom.

There's a video. I play it. Manhattan in all of her full-frontal nudity, looking right into the camera. "You've got a big dick, and I can't wait to feel it inside of me. Show me that you know how to use it."

I groan. My cock comes alive.

I towel off, get dressed, and head back up to my room. More texts come in. I feel them shudder in my pocket like a ticking time bomb. In the safety of my own space, I let myself breathe. I turn back to the phone and read what Joshua Fletcher has sent to torment me.

[unknown]: In case you have any doubt...

This video is longer, the shot wider. The two are on their side, Mason behind her, Heather's legs splayed open as he drives his thick, dark dick into her milky white pussy. She was never mine to lose, yet I feel the loss anyway. I also feel turned on by what I'm seeing. Enough that I pull my cock out and start beating off as I watch this show.

[unknown]: This is Heather's true nature, I'm afraid.

[unknown]: Always has been. Always will be.

[unknown]: She cheated on me. She would have cheated on you.

[unknown]: She can't help it. It's in her nature.

Another video, shot once again from Mason's perspective. Heather's between his legs, looking up at the camera. Her fingers flash up and down his semi-soft cock, shimmering with spit, pussy juice, and his come.

"Look at this big cock," she whispers.

She leans in, running her tongue up one side, before sucking him into her mouth. Her eyes are fixed on the camera. On me. She pulls back with a pop, and he's stiffer now. "Have I been everything you imagined?" Her smile brings out the sharpness of her cheekbones. "Has this moment lived up to all of your fantasies?"

Is her question for Mason? For Joshua? For me?

"I bet you have more. Don't you?" she continues to whisper; her voice laden with sex. "You want to see how dirty I can get..." She sweeps her hair away, holding it back as she dips down and swallows his cock again, taking it deep enough that I see her fight back a gag. The man is enormous. "For this big, black cock, I'll do anything."

"Anything is quite a promise."

She flips her hair the other way and dips in again. "Want me to suck your balls?" She swallows one of his dark testicles. The camera shakes. Mason groans. I groan, too. She pulls off with another, loud pop. "Or want dirtier?"

"Oh, fuck, baby..." He holds her hair back as she moves her lips even lower and laps her tongue along his asshole. "Oh, you naughty, naughty little slut!"

She jacks his cock as she eats his ass, and I jack mine right along with them. I know how raunchy she could get. She didn't hold back when she talked about her past. But seeing it is so much different.

“Is that your fantasy?” She comes up for air, her smile wicked. “My tongue in your asshole?”

“It’s good, baby, but what else are you offering?”

She rolls her body along his, teasing his thighs with her hard nipples. Rubbing his cock against those eraser tips, she says, “How about my tits? You want to feel my tits wrapped around your big, thick dick?”

She spits onto his cock before enveloping it into her cleavage. Her nails are painted bright red, I note, as she squeezes her soft swells around his shaft.

“Now, every time you look at my tits, you’ll think of how good it felt to fuck them.” She pumps him, and once again the stark contrast of black against lily white is striking. “Look at that big cock between my tits. Fuck, you’re huge.” Her laugh is genuine. This is obviously a show, but even behind the facade, she’s impressed. She licks the crown as it juts out, then shifts back to a full on blowjob.

She smiles around him, and I know where this goes next. I know because it’s what I would have wanted in his place—if I was still the bull.

Taking his cock back between her breasts, she asks, “Tell me, baby. Tell me what you really want. I’ll give it to you. Anything. Anything at all.”

“You know what I want.”

How could she look so demure, so sweet, even as she continued to tit-fuck him. “I want to hear you say it.”

“And I want to hear you offer.”

She bites her lip. “My ass,” she says, almost like it’s one word. “That what you want, baby?” He just groans. “You want to fuck my tight, little asshole?”

She climbs up his body, her nudity splayed. Taking his cock, she guides it to her pussy and sinks onto it with a sigh.

“You ever have it in the ass?” he asks.

“Oh, yeah.”

“You ever have a brother in your ass?”

She braces a hand on his chest. “Mmm hmm.” She languidly opens her eyes. “And one in my cunt, too, while a third fucked my throat.”

“Day-um, girl.”

“That dirty enough for you?”

“Fucking hot as hell.”

She levels those baby blue eyes at the camera. “Now... interview over? I’m going to need your full attention when you do my ass.”

Mason chuckles. The video cuts.

And that, humiliatingly, drives me over the edge. I come hard, the ghostly image of Manhattan riding Mason Coles with his cock jammed up her ass. With the orgasm, the exhilaration of the moment sloughs away and I’m once again alone in my room with come cooling on my hand and stomach.

I clean myself up, feeling like I’m back in high school or something. I pour myself a stiff drink to remind myself that I’m not, and then, for good measure, add Joshua’s number to my contacts.

[Me]: Why are you sending this to me?

[Chief Asshole]: So you are there!

[Chief Asshole]: I just wanted you to know the truth because I didn't want you to fall for her. She's easy to love. Makes men do funny things.

[Me]: Thanks for looking out for my well-being.

[Chief Asshole]: I can share more. Mason was quite generous.

“Enough,” I say to the phone, even though I know Joshua cannot hear. I shut it down, toss it onto the desk, and finally, mercifully, pass out.

Heather

Vulnerability

Coming clean with Paul last weekend, after Eleanor's, was the scariest thing I've ever done. I don't do vulnerability. Not with any man that I've ever dated. Not even with Joshua.

I don't know why I feel so open with Paul. I'm still figuring the man out, and my feelings for him. That night, after spending the day with Eleanor and the night in bed with Paul, I didn't even want to look in his direction as I said, "I'm not the woman you think that I am." I just stared at the ceiling, frightened and exposed and naked.

And Paul? He put a hand on my stomach, kissed my shoulder, and said, "Of course you're not. I barely know you." That was the moment that I realized things could be different. With this man, I was going to try. "But," he continued, "You know what? I want to get to know you better."

Paul doesn't do vulnerability well, either. Well, lead by example, right?

So that night, into the wee hours, I told him everything I confessed to Eleanor. I told him about my evolution from high school valedictorian to coed slut. I told him about Dominic and the origins of my tattoo. I told him about Shane and the drugs and my brief stint trading sex for money.

"That's... that's intense," Paul said after I finished telling him about my early twenties and Vegas and the foursome.

"Are you still sure you want to be with me?"

"I'm not exactly in any position to judge."

“But that’s not how judgment works.” Like every time I look at another woman and judge her for being a slut. “We’re all hypocrites, right?”

“Of course I want to be with you. I don’t care what skeletons you have in your past—”

“Not just my past.” This confession was the hardest one—the one I went back to again and again. It was as much for me as it was for Paul.

“Thinking back on those wild times...”

“They turn you on,” he finished.

I cast my eyes down. “Yeah.”

“Let’s be honest here, Heather. That’s because they’re pretty hot memories.”

When I looked back up at him, I was expecting to see the kind of fire that burns inside of Joshua—the kind of entitlement that he should get some of the same. With Paul, who’s probably been-there and done-all-of-that, there’s nothing ulterior.

“And what if I said that I don’t want them to just be memories?”

I can still remember this next moment. I can still close my eyes and remember the gentleness of his hand as it slid down my naked body, and how my tummy fluttered at his touch. But I remember the words even more.

“I’m not here to tell you what to do, Heather. Or what to think. You seem to have a history of men who prey on your weaknesses. I’m not going to do that.” His fingers found my pussy, and my back arched enough to leave the mattress. “But for this to work, we’re going to have to be open with each other.”

Openness. Honesty. I’m not that great with those things, either. I kept my past hidden from Joshua because I was scared. I didn’t share it with Shane or Dominic because they didn’t care. With Paul, was I willing to give it a try?

“You’re not the man I thought you were, Paul Sharpe. You know you already have me in your bed, right? You don’t have to impress me anymore.”

“You really don’t know me, do you?” He climbed over me, sliding his cock along my still-wet pussy. “I’m always impressive.”

It made me laugh until he pressed home and he made me cry out. The man certainly was impressive.



We did circle back to the conversation, though, about openness and communication. We did so as we cooked breakfast together, although I knew I distracted Paul with my legs, exposed beneath one of his dress-shirts.

It was actually Paul who began it.

“Dad didn’t understand why Mom left. He was convinced that she’s left him for another man. He was so sure that I guess I ended up believing that’s what happened, too.”

“Was she?” I asked.

“No.” He looked withdrawn. I gave him space and figured that I wasn’t going to get anymore. He worked through whatever barrier he was holding, though. “No, she was just fed up with him. Took a long time to understand that, though.”

He still hadn’t forgiven her. I saw it in his face and read it in his reluctance. Intellectually, he had, of course. Deep down is always harder, especially in those formidable years.

“I went to community college in my first year after high school. I had to stay close to Dad. I also had a pretty good thing with a girl back then. Amy LaCroix.”

This was new and unexpected. He’d never spoken about other women in his past—not seriously anyway. What had he said once? That he’d been in love before, but then came to his senses the next morning?

I didn’t interrupt him. He needed his space.

“She was a lot like you were back then, I guess. She was studious. A good girl in a bad girl’s body. We had a lot of fun. I thought that I was in love. I thought we had a future together, or whatever.”

He looked at me meaningfully. “Until I caught her cheating with my best friend... at the time. I went to surprise her at her dorm. I could hear them in the fucking hall, but still went in. I had to make sure it wasn’t her roommate.”

I winced. “And it wasn’t?”

“It wasn’t. But that’s not the most fucked up part. I went home, crying. My dad asked what was wrong—he was in one of his more lucid moments then. I told him. I expected him to hug me, support me, do the dad thing, you know? Instead, he said, ‘You need to get yourself together. Here’s a lesson. You’re either the cheater, or the cheated. Don’t let yourself be a fucking weakling.’”

“What a role model.”

Paul laughed. “I was impressionable at the time. I guess I took that advice. That was the last time I ever cried over a girl.”

It was so sad.

“Things went downhill quickly for him after that. He didn’t last the year. He was only 48. Maybe things would have been different if he’d been healthy and I could have walked out on him, but I was the only friend he had.”

“When he finally passed, it was a relief. It’s awful to admit that, but there it is. Suddenly, I could live my life again, and I guess I took that mantra too far. No more Amy’s. No more emotional attachment. It was easier that way.”

“And now?” I was more scared to ask the question than I would ever admit, but I needed to know. We’d just agreed to tell each other everything.

He didn’t give me the easy, kneejerk answer. I was grateful for that. I was also terrified by it. “You’re the first person to make me realize that I can feel something for someone and not be a ‘weakling’.”

It was sad enough that I chuckled at the absurdity of the two of us. “Look at the pair of us. Two fucked up people. You think this can work?”

“My dad would say ‘hell no.’”

“And you?”

The way he looked at me was different than all the men before. Maybe I was seeing the real Paul beneath the bull’s exterior. Maybe I was finally, truly, letting another man in. The veneer of Jameson had worn away just enough that I caught a glimpse of his true self.

“I’m willing to give it a shot.”

I climbed into his lap. He was only semi-soft, but it was enough. It only took a couple swipes along my smooth and still wet sex and he was hard enough for me to sink on. I felt him harden inside of me, slowly filling me with his rigid masculinity. My toes curled.

“That’s so good,” I groaned, bracing my arms against his shoulders. I could feel the sinew of muscle beneath my fingers. He was a granite slab of carved flesh. I sank my nails into him, and he didn’t gasp.

He just looked up at me, past the offer of my body and all the usual places that men look. His lips parted as I smiled down at him, my bangs falling across my face.

I rocked my hips as we enjoyed one another—two people who knew how to have a good time. His hands on my ass were feather soft. He didn't demand. He didn't direct or dominate, although I knew that he was more than capable. Right now was all about intimacy, and the cocoon we wove around us.

I wanted this to work on. I'd made a lot of mistakes in the past, and I knew that I'd make more. Paul was the first man that I'd ever been with that could accept me for me. We were kindred spirits in our own, broken ways.

"I'm going to fuck up, you know," I said.

"Oh, I know."

He seemed to anticipate what I wanted. Grabbing me by the backs of my thighs, he lifted and flipped us until he was on top, between my thighs, driving into me without missing a beat.

"I'm going... to fuck up, too... One hundred percent." He touched my face, his thumb like a feather across my cheek. "So that's out of the way."

My laugh almost felt like a sob, a bubble of emotion that rose to the surface and popped before I could stop it.

"How about... you stop talking about... fucking up and just... fuck me," I said.

"Mmm. Now... you're... talking."

He took me. There's no other way to say it. He pinned me to the bed and took away the control I thought that I had. With Paul, I gave up that control. With Paul, I dared to dream that I could. I writhed beneath his powerful, driving hips and let him hold my hands against the rich cotton sheets.

I wanted the sex to go on forever. I tried, but in the end, even two people as sexual as us could eventually collapsed in sweaty exhaustion. Paul looked like he'd just stepped out of the shower.

"You're glistening," I said with a laugh.

“So are you.” He grinned, reaching out and running his fingers through my damp hair. “So fucking hot.”

I nodded. The sex was done. The fantasy was waning. Reality waited at the door, ready to spoil this party.

Paul addressed the elephant in the room. “You know that your husband’s not going away, right?”

“Right. He won’t. He doesn’t like to lose anything.”

He took me back into his arms, our skin slippery and too hot to hold for long. “What do you want me to do?”

That was Paul. Even after all this discussion of doing things together, he still wanted to shoulder all the burden. I wondered if maybe this wouldn’t work out, after all. Maybe our natures were too set. Maybe we were too broken to make anything work any longer.

“I don’t want you to do anything by yourself, Paul. I don’t need a white knight. Surely you know that by now.”

He seemed to recognize his own mistake with a grimace. “I’m still learning.”

“So am I.” I wiggled away from him, our body heat too much. Turning, we lay side-by-side, staring at one another. “We can do this.” It was as much for me as for Paul.

“So do you have a plan?” he asked.

“Still workshopping it.”

“Are you going to share?” And then, with a smile, he added, “You don’t need to do anything by yourself, Heather.”

The warmth spread through me, like a cup of coffee on a cold morning. Touché, Paul. “Mmm... yeah. Yeah, let’s talk about sharing.”

Paul

Reality Knocks

I dream of my father. We're sitting at the kitchen table, watching as a nurse prepares his lunch. She's hot, her curves on display in the kind of tight, white nurse's dress that only exists in pornography and dreams. Her golden hair flows from a white cap with a red cross on the front, and her legs are encased in white stockings that I know, in that dream way, are secured by a white garter belt.

Dad glances at me and grins before nodding in her direction. I know the look. He thinks I'm his drinking buddy again, his wingman, and that look is one that says, "Go for it. She's yours."

When the nurse turns, it's Heather. Of course it is. She wears a silver name tag that reads, "Manhattan" on it, just to the left of the low scoop of the dress, where her cleavage boils over. She touches the top of the zipper that runs the length of the front of that dress and looks at me with the cock of a brow. "This really how you think of me?" she asks.

"I guess your life story is invading my subconscious."

"Mmm, that sounds a little judgy."

"You also told Mason that you'd give him anything that he wants... as you fucked his cock with your tits."

Her smile is a pleased one. "Is that jealousy? I didn't think that you got jealous."

"Oh, he can get jealous," my dad answers for me. I forgot that he's still here. He's always here, it seems.

“He hides it well though, doesn’t he?” she says. Suddenly, she’s sitting in my dad’s lap, her legs crossed. Dad tugs the hem of that short dress up enough to bare the skin above her white stockings. “So many thoughts, swirling around in there. I think sometimes, he hides them from himself, too, don’t you think?”

My heart jackhammers in my chest. They’re so close. She caresses Dad’s face as he stares at me. His eyes are mine. His cocky smile is the one I mimicked until it was my own. “She’ll fuck you up, son. She already has.”

He pushes her down to her knees, and Heather goes willingly. She glances over my shoulder as she reaches for his zipper. “Hey, this is your dream. Not mine.”



I wake with a start. I’m drenched in sweat and my throat is parched. It’s dark. Still early morning. I’d forgotten to close the curtains and the Vegas lights leak into the room like a defiance against the night. There’s movement at the door, a shadow slipping in.

She’s quiet, thinking I’m asleep. She still wears the white dress. It glows in the dim light like a bridal slip. In the silhouette she creates, I make out her hair. It’s down, damp, freshly showered. I know why that is. I wonder if she’d just fucked Mason a final time before coming here. It’s 4:03.

She sets her high heels by the door and shimmies out of her dress. Beneath, she’s naked, her bra and panties gone, her lush curves sliding in and out of the shadows.

I roll onto my back, sliding an arm under my pillow. “Oh, you’re awake,” she says. She doesn’t sound surprised. “It’s late.”

“Or early.” My voice is full of sleep, but I feel wide awake now. I try to put a label on how I’m feeling. Jealous? Yes. Happy that she’s returned? Without a doubt. Angry that she ever left? Irrationally so, yes. Turned on? Uncertain. “You work out your revenge?”

“You know I was never mad at you...” She slides beneath the covers, down between my legs. I’m sleeping naked, and she easily finds my semi-erect cock. I push the covers back, revealing her staring up at me. “But you’re mad at me.”

“No.” But is that true? This was her scheme, after all. I just went along. She knew that Joshua would try again—although neither of us figured he’d stoop to drugging me. I was supposed to sleep with the next woman regardless, all so that Heather could “catch me.”

“You are.”

“Make it up to me.” It didn’t feel great to be used as bait, and it didn’t feel great to watch her go off with Mason Coles. But also, in a twisted way, it got my blood pumping anyway.

“I can do that,” she says, lowering her head into my lap.

As she wraps her lips around my cock, I think back to the video that sits on my phone—the one where she’s enthusiastically sucking Mason off, where she licks his balls and fucks his cock with her tits. I can no longer tell who that woman was—Manhattan or Heather or a younger Heather. All I know is that the woman sucking my cock to full length is different. There’s no performance. She’s not doing it for anyone or anything but herself.

“I need you.” She climbs into my lap, straddling me, and my cock sinks into her well-fucked pussy. She moans, grinding her hips down on me as we reconnect. “I need this.”

She’s beautiful as she fucks, bathed in the Vegas lights, as she rides me, the sheets slipping down around her ass. I pull her onto me, needing her right back—needing to feel her skin on my skin and her heavy breath against my

neck. I cup her buttocks, guiding her along my length. The sex is mutual. No one controls the other, yet both of us are in control.

She comes quietly, shuddering over me like our union is something illicit. I hold off, my cock still buried inside of her, refusing to get soft.

She falls into me, her skin clammy and hot, her breathing in tatters. Did she collapse onto Mason like this, just a few hours earlier?

I stroke her hair. I hold her close. Wherever she'd gone and whatever she'd just done, she was here with me now. Two weeks ago, that wasn't the case. Whatever outsider feelings I had last night, this moment calms my fears.

"I saw you last night," I say. "I watched you with him."

"At the bar?" she asks, confused.

I reach for my phone on the bedside table and pull it to me, opening my text thread with her husband. She takes it from me and thumbs through it, reading "Chief Asshole's" texts more than the focusing on the content of the videos. She knows about those, of course.

"He's a sadistic asshole," she mutters. "I should have known that he would do that."

"Those videos... they're pretty graphic."

"You watched them?" She looks nervous.

"Of course I did." She studies me behind a mask, worried. "You sure went all in with him."

"I'm sorry—"

"Don't be." I turn onto my side and prop my head on my elbow, watching her scroll through the phone. "I agreed to it. Nothing here was a surprise."

It's true. All of this is by design—from the fight to the hookup with Mason to Mason sending Heather's husband the videos. It's all one devious trap

designed by the woman at my side.

“Agreeing to the scheme in theory is one thing. Seeing it, though—”

“You saw me with Melena yesterday.”

“She drugged you.”

“You didn’t know at the time...”

She touches my face. “You’re right. And it stung, even though I was expecting it.” I see emotion in her eyes. Regret. “I’m so sorry you had to go through that.”

“It’s fine.”

Heather frowns. She can tell I’m shutting down, and now that she can, I can, too. “You don’t have to do that. I know you’re not like Joshua, or Eleanor’s husband.”

I almost interrupt. I almost insist that it’s fine like I’m putting a period on this conversation. The Paul before Heather would have done that. But my dream is still so vivid. ‘She’ll fuck you up, son... She already has.’

“You were into it,” I say instead.

She studies me with those flitting eyes. If she denies it, this is over—maybe not now, but it’ll act as a poison that will eventually kill whatever tenuous thing we have. “I had fun.”

I nod stoically, but the relief that floods through me is wonderful.

“And I had fun watching you.”

She raises a brow. “Really?”

“Really.” I touch her face. “Maybe I am more like Joshua and Ron.” It’s terrifying to say out loud.

“Maybe, but I don’t think so.” She nuzzles against my hand. “Would you rather I was still with him than here with you?”

“No.”

“Is your mind already trying to come up with ways to set me up with other men so you can watch?”

I chuckle at that. “No, definitely not.”

“And are you craving to learn all the naughty things I did with your chief rival tonight?”

“Well, actually... craving’s not exactly the word I’d use, but...”

Again, she looks surprised—as surprised as I feel. “Oh, yeah?”

“Like I said, I had fun watching you. It’s like watching a professional dancer perform.”

“Did you just call me a professional sex worker?”

“You have been a whore before.” I roll her onto her back and mount her. I’m still hard, and this conversation has only stiffened me. I push into her with ease, and she wraps her dancer’s legs around me. “So tell me, Manhattan, what was the naughtiest thing you did tonight?”

“I took a cock in my ass.”

“A big, black cock, right?”

“Huge.”

I fuck her hard, my body like that of a lion’s—all taut, flexed muscle, all power. I pin her hands into the bed, our fingers lacing. We move in sync. I’ve entered the dance, and show her that she’s not the only professional in the room.

“I already reclaimed this pussy,” I say.

“Yes,” she hisses with delight. “Time to reclaim this ass.”

I pull out of her pussy as she gathers her knees up against her chest, presenting her asshole. I trail my cockhead down the smooth bridge between pussy and anus. She relaxes her muscles as I push against the tight opening. It doesn't take much. A bit of pressure, Heather barks an expletive, and I'm in.

“Two dicks in this ass in one night. How does that make you feel?”

“Like a... like a bad girl. Mmmm...”

I swing her legs to the side, knees together to my left. The pressure on my cock tightens enough that I hiss and grit my teeth. “Would have thought he'd have loosened you up more with that infamous BBC he goes on about.”

She's biting her lower lip, her face twisted in pain. Sweat beads along her brow and in her hair. I consider slowing up. I consider being more tender. Then I consider her time with Mason and my competitive spirit blooms. When she thinks of tonight, it's going to be my cock in her ass that she'll remember, not Mason's.

I grab her ass cheek, which is red from another man's hand, squeezing as I drive hard into her backdoor. She's reduced to gasps and moans, painful and delirious and strangled. Her face is red, her eyes squeezed shut. She's into this—deeply into this. I know a woman who gets off on anal play, and Heather is definitely one of them.

“You like being bad, don't you?”

She moans in response.

I lean over her, keeping one hand on her ass and squeeze a tit. “Should I treat you the way a bad girl should be treated?”

Before, she needed a tender touch. She needed a reminder of what love can be like. Now she needs to know that I'm not her husband or her lover. She

needs to know that I can be her bull, too.

“You’re going to come with my dick shoved all the way up your ass. Understand?”

She nods her head vigorously, her whimpers coming out as a, “Yes, yesyes!”

I close my hand around her throat, squeezing just enough to show her that I’m in control. I spank her, my hand adding my own red mark to her rounded cheek.

“I don’t care who you fucked tonight, or how you fucked him.”

SPANK!

“I don’t care if you pull a train of guys.”

SLAP!

“Or take it airtight until you pass out.”

SPANK!

“But just because I’m okay with sharing doesn’t mean you’re not going to get punished.”

She goes off on me, her sphincter tightening so much it’s like she’s trying to snap my dick off. I don’t slow my rutting. I don’t ease up. Spurred on like a whipped animal, I ride her harder, drilling her ass until her screams escape my choking hand. I release her neck and the oxygen fuels the intensity of what she feels as surely as it would an inferno.

“Come, Paul!” she cries. “Give me your come!”

Like a switch, she’s calling the orders and I’m the one obeying. I’m close. I want to be there, to join her. I kiss her neck, her cheek. When our mouths meet, the kiss is molten.

“Do it,” she hisses. “Pump your come into my ass.” She may be whispering her nasty words, but she’s now in command. “Remind me whose ass it is.”

I can no longer hold back. I don’t want to. I rise over her, splaying open her legs again. Holding her by the knees, I rut into her as she reaches down and fingers her pussy and clit. It feels good. It feels so good. But it’s her eyes, sharp and bright and challenging, that push me over the edge. I have never felt a connection like I do with this woman.

I ram ball-deep into her ass, fold her knees against her shoulders, and roar as I come. Heather joins me, rubbing her cunt harder than I ever would dare as pain and pleasure flash across her face.

The come down from that orgasm is sharp. Whatever testosterone high I’d been riding is gone in a flash. I practically fall into her, my cock slipping free and she cradles me against her sweat-sheathed body.

“You were better than him,” she says, and it lifts me. “Although in the interest of open communication, he was pretty good, too.”

I chuckle. Our kisses are once again tender. “Looked like you were enjoying it.”

“What can I say? Mason knows how to fuck.”

“The videos show your face.”

“Yeah, that was unavoidable. Joshua would have gotten suspicious if we’d cropped it too strategically.”

“Risky.”

She laughs. “Isn’t that what makes it so exciting?”

“I hope you know what you’re doing.”

She gives me a kiss. “I hope so, too.”

Heather

Access

The sun has begun to rise in the distant foothills that ring Las Vegas, casting warm hues of red and gold through the room. I rise with it, the expensive bed sheets slipping from my naked body. I'm exposed before Paul, but resist the urge to cover myself. He watches me as I pass across the room to his computer.

"You mind?" I don't wait for his response, opening the lid. The login screen springs to vibrant life.

Paul just chuckles and recites his password. No secrets between us. His browser is open, loading a page with a half-written blog post we'd asked him to write. "You want me to close up all the porn tabs you were looking at?"

I hear him shift behind me. "Why would I need to look at porn when I have you?"

"Because I'm only one woman, and I know that no one woman will ever satisfy Paul Sharpe." There actually isn't any porn open on his computer, not that I would have been upset if there was.

"Pretty rich coming from someone who was with two guys last night."

"Hey, I wasn't criticizing."

"Neither was I."

I glance back at him. How different he is from any other man that I have been with. It's not that he doesn't care. I can tell that he does. A part of him

is jealous. A part of him is even turned on. But it doesn't drive him the way it does Joshua, and he's not seeking to exploit it like Shane. If anything, Paul is most like Dominic, although I feel like we could be more. Dom has a wife and kids now. Could that be us?

"So did it work?" Paul asks. "Or are you looking at porn now?"

Right, I almost forgot why I'd logged on here. I log into the secure site I'd been given, using both VPN and two-factor authentication, to access the trap that we'd been working on since last week.

"Okay, looks like it worked." I can see the file structure of Joshua's phone. I have access to his personal files.

"No shit?" Paul rises out of bed.

No shit at all. This was the gambit. This was why I took last night's risk. Joshua thought that Mason was with him. Really, he was our double agent. The videos that he sent of me last night were infected with a special virus that would open a backdoor into his system.

I find his videos—not just the ones Mason sent, but all the video he keeps on his phone. But only his phone. What I'm really after is the trove of video he keeps on his computer back home. I'm pretty certain that he's got dirt on the partners at his firm—something to give him leverage. He's hinted at it. Now, that same dirt is going to give me leverage on him.

But it's not here. Not yet. Which means that this charade must continue. Maybe what he has isn't enough to go into whatever vault he's set up. Maybe he needs more.

"Paul? I know you've been dying to play white knight."

"You're cooking up another plan, aren't you?"

"Maybe." I shut his laptop and rise. "All princesses need knights, right?"

Paul

Bust

“Hit?” the dealer asks.

I look down at my hand. A queen and a two show. “Hit.”

“Twenty-two. Bust.” He sweeps away my chips and moves on to the next victim.

I barely notice the loss. What began as a ruse turned real at some point. I don’t often let myself feel self-pity, but enough bourbon gives me permission—even rail bourbon.

“It’s 5 o’clock somewhere, right... Jameson.”

I blink. There, sitting beside me with a cool smile that doesn’t reach his eyes, is Joshua Fletcher. I can practically feel my knuckles crunch against Joshua’s slender jawline. I imagine the pain of it and all the warm and delicious satisfaction. But we are in public, and I get the sense that he would be just as fine pressing charges against me as he would be working with me. So instead, I just say, “I was wondering when you’d show up.”

“Haven’t you figured it out yet? Wherever my wife goes, I’ll be close behind.”

“Sounds like a cause to get a restraining order.”

My retort washes over him like water on grease. He remains as unruffled as his combed and structured salt-and-pepper hair. “You know you’re just a sex toy to her, right?”

I flinch at the statement. Joshua sees it and interprets it through his own fucked up filter.

“You think you’re more to her, don’t you?” He tuts. “I don’t blame you. She’s an amazing woman.”

I hear the admiration in his voice—the love. This man is the villain of my story, but he doesn’t see it that way. The dealer interrupts us, prompting us to make a bet. I push some chips forward without looking at the denominations. Joshua sets a single chip down, the lowest of bets.

“I should apologize.” The friendly veneer is thin. “We could have worked together, but I didn’t see the opportunity until it was too late.”

“You tried to entrap me with one prostitute, and when that didn’t work, you had another drug me.”

Joshua glances at the dealer before turning his disarming smile on me. “The things we do for love, right?”

“Is that what you call trying to manipulate other men into your wife’s bed? Seems pretty fucked to me.”

“Who are you to judge? I have my kinks. We both know that she has her own.”

“She deserves so much better than you.”

“Like you?” He chuckles, and I curl my hands into fists again. “You think you know Heather, but you’ve known her... what? Three months, tops? You don’t. I’ve known her for a decade. I’ve seen how she’s grown, but I also know who she was before me. I know what she’s capable of, more than you could ever imagine.”

“I have a pretty good imagination.”

“There was once a man who pushed her darkest impulses in ways that I never could. I’m her husband. She will always be hesitant to unleash those

impulses because of this.” He brandishes his gold wedding band like a boast as much as a block. “But you, Paul, you don’t wear one, do you?”

“You don’t have a very high opinion of your wife.”

His face darkens. “I love her. I’m also not a fool. I know who I married. She needs an outlet. You could have been that.”

“Or maybe I’m both.” He’s finally been able to get under my skin enough that I let emotion take over. “Maybe she’s comfortable enough to explore her boundaries together, with me, rather than trying to hide it—the way she does with you.” Adrenaline pumps in my blood, like I’m ready to start a brawl. “You keep reducing her to two halves, like people are so simple. There’s Shane—” I forget that he hasn’t mentioned the man’s name. “—and there’s you, and heaven forbid she’s more complex than that.”

“Well, now there’s Mason, isn’t there?” He’s ruffled. I can tell, if only in the twitch of his left eyelid. “I really should share the clip I have of her screaming for him to fuck her ass with his big black cock.”

I grind my teeth. “You know where she came this morning, after she was done with him?” I should not say this. I can feel the mistake even as it leaves my lips, but it’s too late now. “Not to your room, am I right? When she was done satisfying her slutty side, a part of you was hoping that she’d call you, find you, so you could take her back into your arms.”

Now I’m not the only one grinding my teeth.

“You waited and waited, but she never called. Never came.” I lean in. “Because she was in my bed. And it was me reclaiming her. It was me fucking her ass, spanking her, showing her that whatever she can get from guys like Mason, or Shane, or Dominic—yes, I know all about her exes—I am the ultimate bull. And in your words, that’s something that she will always be hesitant to do with you.”

He’s cowed. I’m a prize fighter and it’s time to go for the knockout punch. “Tonight, there’s a party. I’ll be going with your soon-to-be-ex-wife. It will be wild. And I will leave with her. We will do a lot of things. She will do a

lot of things—things that you will never see, never hear about. And then, tomorrow, and the day after, and the day after that, Heather and I will relive that night. They will be hot, exciting memories. Our memories, not yours. We'll make more. Because I don't pretend to like one part of her and pine for the other. I know that she's both of those things—both of those things and so much more, and while I don't have five or ten or whatever the fuck many years with her, I'm excited to discover her, and excited for her to discover more of me.”

It is the most baldly honest thing I've ever said, ever even thought in the deepest recesses of my mind, and here I am confessing it to my nemesis.

I push all of my chips in and look to the dealer, who is doing his best to seem like he's not listening to this wild story. Even for Vegas, this has to be extraordinary.

Joshua places his own, more modest bet. “Did that feel good?”

A pit sinks in my gut. I shouldn't have done that. I shouldn't have shown my weakness. Classic mistake.

His smile raises the hair on the back of my neck. I feel like I've just stepped into his trap. “You two think that you're so clever.” He reaches into his jacket and pulls out an envelope. “Malware. Viruses. Such a double edged sword. It doesn't really care what it infects. My phone... your phone. It has instructions and does its thing.” He sets the envelope in front of me. “They're kind of like you, huh, Paul. You just can't help yourself. You are what you are, right? A bull? What did you call yourself? ‘The ultimate bull’?”

“You knew...” I say.

“Where do you think she got the virus in the first place? Of course she didn't know it was me, but it's easy to set that up when I can track her own browser history.”

“Now, I know that you don't give a damn about your own career or reputation. That you'd nobly sacrifice yourself for those that you care

about.” He grins, and it’s like a lizard grinning. It says, I know you. “But what about your friend, Elie.” He says her name with such disdain. “What about her reputation? What do you think her friends, her family—everyone attending this very conference—would think if they saw her do some of the things that I have seen? Some of the things,” he taps the envelope, “right here.”

“What do you want?”

“It seems that I have been unable to get others to break the two of you up. I’m going to need you to do it yourself.” He checks his cards and taps the felt, asking for another. The dealer sets down a Jack of Hearts, giving him—

“Twenty-one. Blackjack,” the dealer announces.

Joshua doesn’t seem to care. He’s finishing his thought. “It’ll be better for both of you in the end, honestly. It may hurt. Heather may be angry. But hey, it’s better than dragging her reputation through the mud, too, don’t you think?”

“So what do you want me to do?” I feel pinned. I caged.

“Sir?” the dealer asks. I glance at him, not my cards. “Hit” Another mistake.

He flips a card. “Twenty-two. Bust.”

And like that, all my winnings are gone.

“I’ll tell you exactly what you need to do, and the beautiful thing is, you don’t even have to do anything.” Joshua’s smile grows wider. He retrieves something else from his jacket, a small, flat box. “If I fully understand your friend, Elie, she’ll do all the heavy lifting...”

Heather

Coonfidante

I can see the seams, even at a classy place like Orchid Lounge, the way a tailor will always be able to see the imperfections of a piece of clothing. It's a show here, a facade. The women may be as elegant as the strip club's name, but it is still a strip club, and they're here just for a job.

I look over at Eleanor, who in turn watches the dancer up on the club's single stage. Does she see the show? Does she see how the girl lets her mind wander, thinking about her kids or her grocery list or what to watch next on Netflix even as guys ogle her bare tits?

I sigh, sinking back into the plush, barrel chair, pull out my phone, and check it again. Joshua still hasn't transferred his files to his backup server. I've been obsessively checking the malware site for updates. Once he makes that transfer, I can be done with all of this. I can move on.

A cocktail waitress wearing little more than a bra and panties delivers the bottle of champagne.

Eleanor thanks her as she ogles the woman's cleavage, then turns to me. "Put your work away for a bit and enjoy yourself, Heather. We're in Las Vegas."

I haven't told Eleanor anything about the scheme. I wanted to keep her out of it just in case things went sour. Right now, though, I need an outlet, and Paul isn't here.

"I'm just trying to take care of one final, little snag."

“So it’s not work?” She hands me a flute of champagne. “Joshua.” She knows me well enough that it’s barely a guess.

“He’ll be there until I can figure out a way to get him out.”

“I assume you’ve got a plan for that?”

“Everyone assumes I have a plan.”

Eleanor smiles, and I smile right along with her. “Well, you do, don’t you?”

I stare at the bubbles that rise through the pale, golden liquid. It’s premature to celebrate, but I feel good enough about this plan that I do anyway.

The current dancer spinning around the pole has creamy white skin and long red hair. She wears a pair of white, fluffy angel wings, a white thong, and nothing else. The dancer meets my gaze with eyes too blue to be natural, and arousal floods through me. If she’s faking it, she’s doing a damn good job.

“So Joshua has all this footage...”

“Footage? Like video? Of you?”

“Well, yes, some. But what I’m talking about are videos of his partners and colleagues. Blackmail stuff. He’s always been a voyeur and a collector.”

“He’s blackmailed them?”

“No, I don’t think so. It’s always just been his backup plan. If they knew what he had, though, or that he’d been recording them—”

“They wouldn’t be very happy.”

I sip the champagne, letting its fizzy warmth spread through me. The redhead on stage finishes her set. I watch her gather her things. She’ll come over. I know it.

“He keeps all of this on a private server, and if I could get access to it, I’d have him by the balls. So last night, I gave him something that he couldn’t resist adding to his collection, and made sure to bury a little malware in it.”

“Trojan Horse.” She seems as impressed as I feel. “What was it you sent him?”

Here’s the part that I’m not sure how she’ll react. For half-a-second, I think about leaving it a mystery. This is Eleanor, though, and after all that I’ve shared with her, what’s one more little thing. So I tell her.

Her mouth falls open after I do. “So hold up a moment... That business with the woman at the bar, and you getting upset and storming off and then flirting with the other guy—”

“We knew Joshua was behind it.” I don’t tell her about the next day, when Paul was drugged. That, neither of us anticipated, although neither of us were surprised either.

She presses. “And you fucked Mason last night just so you could send some malware to your husband—”

“Ex-husband.”

“Not yet.”

“A technicality.”

A new dancer has taken the stage. She’s blonde and fit, her body moving like liquid over the poll. Unlike the last dancer, though, I see the act.

“You know there are much easier ways to put a virus on someone’s computer, right?”

“I don’t want it to just be on his computer, or his phone, or whatever. I need the file to make it to wherever he stores all the other incriminating videos. He’s wanted to watch me with another man for so long. There’s no way this doesn’t make it there.”

“What about just a video of you and Paul? Wouldn’t that have been so much easier?”

“And why would either of us send Joshua a video of that? Joshua’s a smart guy. It would have been suspicious.”

Eleanor sighs. “I wish you’d come to me. You know Ronald owns a cyber security firm, don’t you?”

Actually, I never knew what Ronald did, or how they had all of their money. “I didn’t.”

“I guess he’s always been a bit of a voyeur. How do you think it was so easy to set up our guest house?”

“Well, that would have been good information to know...”

My voice drifts off as I catch sight of the red haired stripper emerge onto the floor. Her wings are gone and she’s put on a dress that’s closer to a negligee, but it only makes her sexier.

“Someone has the hots for that one,” Eleanor teases. “Shall we call her over?”

“Umm, no.” Why am I blushing? “We should wait for the boys before starting up the fun.”

“Not necessarily.” She does let it slide away, though. “So you slept with Mason last night... how’s Paul doing?”

I think about early this morning, when I’d snuck back into this bed. That wasn’t the plan. I also didn’t mean to stay so long with Mason. When I woke up, though, I couldn’t imagine going back to my room all by myself. It felt too much like the Heather of old. I needed to reconnect, and the man that I wanted to reconnect with was Paul.

“Paul is Paul,” I say equivocally.

“Come on, Heather, you know better than that.”

I want to nibble on my fingertips. I want to light up a cigarette. Instead, I finish off my champagne. “Joshua sent him the videos from last night.”

Her brows go up. “Wow. That’s seriously fucked up. Paul watched them?”

“Would anyone be able to resist? Yes, he did. And...” I think about how we fucked. How he reclaimed. “...I wouldn’t say that he was turned on by them—not the way your husband or, like, Joshua gets. But he wasn’t repelled by them, either.”

“Well, that’s a twist.”

“Paul, he’s... special.”

Eleanor looks at me knowingly, reading everything I want to hide in my use of that word. “You know what I think? That you’re still trying to remain in control, even in how you end things with Joshua.”

“I know that I have a problem with that, but you’ve got to believe me, Elle, if I don’t, he won’t ever leave me alone.”

She gets it, nodding. “You also don’t need to do it all on your own.”

“I know, I know.”

She’s quiet, but I can hear her mind working, turning over and over what I’ve shared. The server comes over and refills our glasses. I thank her.

“So you were with Mason last night, huh?” Eleanor says before the girl is out of earshot.

I feel a real, live blush rise inside of me. “Yeah.”

Eleanor returns with the bottle, taking a seat at my side now, the motherly persona replaced with the gossip. This is the woman I opened up to. This is the woman I need right now.

“And?”

My laugh is more like a release of anxiety, a stopper being pulled from a bottle. “You know...”

“The biggest dick you’ve ever had?”

There goes the demure woman. “Yes, actually. There may have been others close, but... yeah. I really hate to pump up that ego. It’s already big enough as it is.”

“Well, good thing that he’s not here then, yes?” She holds her glass aloft. “Just us girls.”

I look at her lips, glossy and soft, and remember our kiss. Worse, she sees me remember it, and smiles.

Two women take the stage, entering holding hands. One is a blonde. The other is a brunette. At the pole, the brunette spins, resting her back against the brass as the other slides right up to her. With the fluidity that only comes with practice, they start to kiss.

“This is my first time in a strip club, you know,” Eleanor says. “And like so many other things I’ve done lately, I have to wonder why I never did this before.”

I look at her, my gut tightening. It’s a motherly worry that I’ve felt before with my youngest cousin when I fear they might act like me when I was their age. “So what have you been doing here in Vegas?”

“Making up for lost time.” She sees my worried look and rolls her eyes. My youngest cousin did that, too. “Don’t give me that look. It’s not that bad. I haven’t experimented with hard drugs...yet.”

“Don’t be an idiot like me. You’ve got so much more to lose than I did back then, and trust me, it’s not worth it.”

“Thanks, Mum.”

“So what does lost time mean? I’ve told you so many stories. You owe me one.”

Eleanor's smile could always light up a room. Now, this close, it's like an inferno. "You've heard of a 'Girlfriend Experience,' right?"

"When you hire an escort to pretend to be your girlfriend."

"Right." She looks at me, something occurring to her. "Wait, did you ever offer a Girlfriend—"

"No. My limited experience with sex work only ever involved sex." If my face wasn't already hot, it would be now.

"Well, there's also such a thing as a Boyfriend Experience, and darling, it's fabulous."

"Go on."

"Ronald is such a cuckold. He doesn't just want me to fuck other men, right? He wants me to date them. To make it more than just the sex. So I figured that while we're out here, we might as well try it in a controlled way. In comes Conrad."

"Your hired boyfriend."

"He was good. So good. And I'm not just talking about the sex. Honestly, I went into this on a lark, mostly to humor Ronald. I'd arranged to meet up with Conrad a couple nights ago, after the little cocktail reception we were all at. You actually almost ruined it with your little, fake fight."

"Sorry about that."

"Ronald convinced me to go out on this date anyway. I'm telling you, the man is so single-minded sometimes. So I met up with Conrad at Olympia."

"The rooftop pool club?"

"That's the one. It's gorgeous up there. Very exclusive feeling, too, and Ronald got to watch. At least the first part of the date. And this really did feel like a date. We danced, of course, and flirted, but also we... felt one

another out. We got to know each other. I opened up to Conrad in ways I never would with Mason—or even Ronald. He was like a sexy therapist.”

“And he was sexy?”

Her smile says it all. “One of the advantages of Olympia is that you get to sample the goods. He was delicious. Like a young Keanu Reeves, with the hair and the toned upper body. It all made for this amazingly magical night. I haven’t felt that way in... well, maybe ever. He was so easy to talk to. Such a good conversationalist.”

“But you didn’t just talk, did you?”

“Oh, goodness, no. By the time we left Olympia, I was so wet. But Heather, even the sex felt...special. Like, we didn’t just tear each other's clothes off. It felt more like my first time with Ronald. We kissed a lot. We slowly stripped—although neither of us were wearing much. And when we finally got it on, it was like making love. I mean, I know that it wasn’t love, and that I paid him to be like that, but still. It felt good.”

“Did Ronald watch?”

“No. That was the other thing. He wasn’t there. We didn’t record any of it. It was just me and Conrad, and that made it feel a lot more like an... affair, I guess.”

I hate to even think it, but this is reminding me a lot of how I feel when I’m with Paul.

“Sex is all about the connection,” she continues. “And Heather, I’m still thinking about it now. It feels silly, I know, but I want to text him. I have texted him. Little things, like about the weather, or what I had for lunch.”

“Does he respond?”

“He does! And it’s thrilling each time he does.”

That, too, sounds a lot like how I feel about Paul. “Are you going to see him again? Is he going to the party tonight?”

“Oh, no. That’s not something a boyfriend should see.” She laughs. “But I did extend things a few more days, just to spend more time with him.” Her eyes flash. “And I’m sending Ronald home, first.”

“Just be careful.”

“Of course. I’m a big girl. I know it’s not real, but it’s loads of fun pretending. There’s like this freedom to it because I know, deep down, that it’s not real. Short of you, I haven’t been able to talk to anyone about my life these past few months. Conrad listened, and because he’s a... professional, he’s even had some experience with it.”

“I get that.” I almost don’t say this next thing. It takes courage to get it out. “I felt that way about Paul. Like he was just some fun. A distraction. I could tell him things about Joshua that I’ve never shared. It was like an outlet without any stakes.”

She sets her chin on her hand. “But now?”

“Now there are stakes.”

“Is that bad?” she asks.

“No. It’s actually wonderful.” I can’t help but smile. “You know, I’m actually glad that Joshua sent Paul those videos. When I went to him this morning, I was so nervous that things would get between us, but they didn’t. It turned into something that we could share, together, and oh my God was the reclamation sex good.”

Eleanor giggles. “You know, don’t tell him this, but for all his macho show, Paul is closer to Conrad than he is to Mason.”

“I definitely won’t tell him that.” I laugh. “But yeah, I’m beginning to think you’re right.”

“Bulls come in all shapes and sizes?” Eleanor cracks up at her own joke. When it subsides, she reaches out and brushes the hair from my face. She meets my eyes. “You two really should come tonight. It’ll be fun.”

Before I can figure out a way to politely turn her down—again—despite being oh, so tempted, the red haired dancer joins us. “We rarely see two women as sexy as you all alone. Would either of you like a dance?”

“Heather would,” Eleanor says with a mischievous smile. I want to slap her.

She looks at me with a delight that almost feels genuine, swiveling around to sit on my armrest. “Your name’s Heather?” She bites the question off, before adding, “That’s a beautiful name. I’m Angelica.”

“Thank you, Angelica. Loved your set.”

“Pretty easy with the right audience. Are you the right audience, Heather?”

“I’m a bisexual woman who hasn’t had sex with another girl in several years. You tell me. Does that make me the right audience?”

Eleanor practically guffaws. Angelica’s pupils dilate. Okay, so she’s into this more than just as a job.

“That is so sad,” she says, batting her long, fake lashes. “But I’d be more than willing to help you out.”

“Oh, I’m sure you would... for a price.”

She shrugs. “It’s the policy here, but I promise you, I’d enjoy it just as much as you would.”

“She’s confident,” Eleanor says. “How much?”

“Two hundred for a half-hour of private time.”

“And if I paid a thousand?”

Angelica exhales. “Then it would be very private.”

I feel like I’m being bartered over like a chicken at market. Eleanor’s eyes shift past me. “And could he watch?”

Angelica looks beyond me, too, and smiles. “Of course.”

I smell Paul before I hear him. He’s come at last. “What are we talking about?” he says.

Eleanor answers. “We’re about to do something we should have done long ago.”

Paul

Suite C

Things feel reckless. I could blame it on Joshua Fletcher, but things were spinning out of control before our blackjack conversation. I'm used to this feeling, though, and normally I'd brush it off and go with it.

It's an easy thing to do as I follow the three women upstairs to the private rooms of this strip club. It's harder when I think about what I have in my pocket and how it makes everything I do feel impotent.

I'm only half present, suddenly finding myself entering a door marked, "Suite C", at the end of a hall that feels more like some rich person's home than an establishment where women take off their clothes.

A curved sofa bends around a low coffee table. It's comfortable, the velvet caress designed to feel as decadent as this place. Eleanor sits at my side, her hand gripping the inside of my thigh, as Heather sits alone.

The stripper, Angelica, is as gorgeous as any of the women downstairs. She has fair skin and a lean body that she shows off in nothing but a white g-string and a matching white top that barely covers her nipples, and her gossamer wrap doesn't hide anything.

She opens the bottle of champagne that sits on the coffee table as we all settle in. "I love this room," she says, looking around. "So many fond memories."

The champagne bottle pops.

"Are we celebrating anything special?" she asks.

“A very successful conference,” Eleanor says. “And an appetizer for what’s to come later tonight.”

“I’m the appetizer?”

“Does that bother you, dear?”

“Stimulating the appetite for a group as sexy as you? No, I’m not bothered at all.” She looks right at Heather. “Are you ready to be stimulated, Heather?”

Heather glances at me, checking on my state-of-mind. I give her a nod. Whatever happens when dawn breaks, at least I get to be there. Heather crosses her long legs, and the hem of her LBD creeps up enough to offer a glimpse of lace at the top of her nude-color stockings. “Always.”

Angelica glides into Heather’s lap like she’s made of liquid, her body all grace and sensuality. Her lips graze Heather’s before she rises, sliding her cleavage before Heather’s hungry gaze.

“Look at what you almost missed,” Eleanor whispers to me as we watch.

“You would have started without me?”

“That’s the problem with you men.” She covers my crotch with her hand. “Always thinking with your cocks.”

Heather is transfixed before the stripper, their eyes locked as she gyrates in her lap, running her panty clad mound over Heather’s thigh.

“Remember when you were shy?” I ask Eleanor.

“No. Not really.” She unzips my pants and fishes out my erection. She kisses my neck and whispers, “Your fault. You created the monster.”

With that, she drops her head into my lap and takes me into her mouth. At nearly the same time, Angelica slides to the floor, opening Heather’s thighs enough that we can all see her black panties, and makes sure that she

caresses her hair on Heather's exposed skin. The stockings, I see, are held in place by black garters that disappear up under the dress.

Heather catches sight of me and the blowjob I'm receiving. Her pupils expand. Her breath catches. She's okay with this. Of course she's okay with this.

Angelica pirouettes, tossing her hair back as she sinks her ass into Heather's lap. Heather can't keep her hands off the other women any longer. She reaches out, touching Angelica's back, running her fingers up the stripper's spine.

Now Angelica sees the blowjob. She doesn't object, but she's not as collected as I expect from a professional like her. She's turned on. I bet we could have gotten her to do this for free.

Heather unties her top, and suddenly it's the stripper who is letting things get out of control. She fights to take it back, reclining into Heather as my one-time-friend cups her tits and squeezes. "Your nipples are hard."

"I enjoy what I do."

"I can feel that."

"You're welcome to explore more."

Heather looks at me. "What do you think, Paul? Think she's wet?"

"Go on and find out."

Heather knows how to tease as well as Angelica. She does so now, taking her time as she traces her fingers down the other woman's body, like a rivulet of water gliding along her oiled and glistening body. She touches the underside of her small breasts. She slides across her ribs and down along her pierced belly button. At last, she pushes her fingers beneath Angelica's g-string. I watch her knuckles move beneath the silky white. I watch the stripper gasp as they enter her.

"Yes, she's wet."

Angelica moans.

I am intensely aware of the device Joshua has given me, a short-range radio secreted away in the inside pocket of my jacket. He's here. He's listening. But he can't see. Might as well make him wish that he could.

"How does it feel to finger fuck another woman?"

Heather pulls her fingers out. They glisten with Angelica's excitement. Slowly, she sucks them one at a time, savoring the taste. "Tasty."

Angelica bends forward, shifting her legs until she's straddling just one of Heather's, and begins gyrating.

"I had my first girl-on-girl experience in this very room," she says, arching back once again until her head rests on Heather's shoulder. "I was a customer back then."

"The dancer must have made quite an impression."

Angelica smiles to herself. "Oh, yeah." Then she turns, her knee down between Heather's thighs, her tits brushing along Heather's lips. "But then again, you're making quite an impression, too."

"I'm paying you to say that."

"Technically, your friend is." She dips low, bringing her mouth within inches of Heather's. I hold my breath, waiting for the kiss. When Heather closes the gap, though, Angelica slips away, giving her a cheek.

"Tease."

"Don't worry, Heather. For as much as your friend is paying, I will make you very happy."

Angelica lowers herself back down to the floor, her hands on Heather's knees, pushing them apart. Without ever breaking eye contact, she slides her hands up Heather's thighs, taking hold of her panties. Heather doesn't hesitate, lifting her hips to let the stripper peel away the thong.

She doesn't dive right in, though. She draws it out, blowing across Heather's sex as she rises again, using her body. She nuzzles Heather's neck, whispers something that I cannot hear. I do see her hand, see the way she trails her painted, red fingernails up Heather's thigh.

"Ahhh!" Heather gasps as Angelica finds her pussy.

Eleanor slurps off of me so she can see. She's just in time to see the two women finally kiss—and what a kiss.

"That's scorching," Elie says.

I reach into my pocket and remove the gift that Joshua gave me. "This is for you to give to Manhattan. My gift to you for tonight." Joshua's words in my mouth, just as he wanted it.

"Does this mean you're coming tonight?" Eleanor asks as she opens the box.

Heather is looking at me, curiosity behind the mask of lust. "We both are. You'll see. Open it up."

I keep my eyes trained on Heather as Eleanor takes the flat, white box from me and peels the lid off. Angelica keeps up her seduction, kissing Heather's neck as she rubs her fingers along her bare gash.

Eleanor laughs in delight when she pulls out the dog collar. The supple, black leather is adorned with a steel ring and small, silver pendant etched with the word, "Manhattan" on it.

"You had this made?" she asks. Still, I don't look. I watch for Heather's reaction—for Manhattan's reaction. She gasps, but whether it's from the revelation, or from Angelica touch, I'm not sure.

"Very kinky."

"Go on, see if it fits her. Tonight, you are in control."

'If I fully understand your friend, Elie, she'll do all the heavy lifting...'
Joshua's words ring true. I can see the wicked gears turning in her mind.

Eleanor's dress rides the line between sexy and alluring, much like the woman wearing it. It's shorter than appropriate, the white ruched material tight on her ass and hips, but the wide bands of the top balances it out. It's also stretchy enough that she shimmies out of it in one smooth motion.

Beneath, Eleanor is completely naked, not a scrap of lace to protect her voluptuous modesty. My eyes rove her curves, over her full breasts and the hourglass roll from waist to hips. Between her cheeks, I catch the flash of something shiny—the jeweled tip of a buttplug. This woman is ready.

“Ready to be my pet?”

Joshua

Listening

“Ready to be my pet?”

The mic is sensitive enough that I have to yank my earphones away. Even with the separation, it’s easy to hear the collar tighten around my wife’s neck, the clink of its clasp, her not-so-quiet gasp.

The microphone is in the pendant, Paul’s nickname for her the final betrayal. The irony makes me smile.

“A perfect fit.” Eleanor has such a refined British accent. It’s hard to imagine her being so naughty. I kick myself for not figuring out a way to get video, but relying on third parties to do that kind of work wasn’t going to happen. Audio is the best I could do in a pinch.

“We’re going to have to find a lead to match, but I do love this ring.” She must tug. Heather gasps. “I can pull you close like this.” Eleanor’s voice is a whisper, but the mic picks up everything. “I have been thinking of this moment since I let you walk out of my home without ravishing you.”

“Sounds a little stalkerish of you. You sure you’re not Joshua in disguise?”

My name is a jolt, the insult a lash along my pride. I grind my teeth.

“Does your husband have tits as round as these two?”

“Mmmm...”

“Does his pussy get this wet—?” Eleanor’s voice catches. A moment later, all I hear is kissing, wet and passionate and so close. I can hear the hum of

Heather's pleasure. I feel so close to her. I feel like I'm there, behind her, caressing her neck as she makes out with another woman.

But I'm not. I can only imagine it. I'm sitting in my car in a quiet part of Las Vegas, jerking off within range of a strip club. I drive the palm of my hand into the steering wheel of my rental car, and when that doesn't feel satisfying enough, I do it until my hands bruise.

"Cute landing strip," my wife says.

She's met with a sigh, cut off by another kiss. This time, it's Heather initiating. I know it. The woman doesn't like giving up control. Luckily, Eleanor knows who wears the collar.

"Angelica, my friend here has been eyeing you all night long. I'll give you a thousand dollars if you eat her pussy."

"Yes please." The stripper says it without even a moment's hesitation.

"I'm not done." I imagine Eleanor locking eyes with Heather, and hate that I can't see that. Hate it. "If you make her come, then you don't get anything."

Angelica, the stripper, says, "She's very close now."

"And that is right where I want her. Right on that edge. For as long as you can keep her there."

"I see your game. Yes." I hear shifting. Some slutty tramp getting onto her knees. I'm so hard. I'm so on edge, too. I rub my cock through my pants as I listen to them. "I don't have many regrets in life," she goes on. "But one of them is not letting the stripper go down on me that first time we were in here."

"See, Heather, she gets it." It's Paul who speaks, and his deep voice churns my guts in the hard and humiliating cuckold way. I remember feeling it that first time when I saw David hitting on my wife at the Christmas party, so

long ago. It's the taste I kept chasing every time we played the game. "No regrets."

I need to see this. I thought that audio would be fine. I thought that this was all I'd need, but this fantasy demands more—always so much more. Last night, the videos that Mason sent me, were just a tease for the real thing. I knew the setup. It blunted the impact.

Paul is no setup—at least not Heather's—and the dizzying feelings I feel now are sharp. Seeing it would end me. I need to see it.

I listen to them like I'm high and lost in a cloud of my own lust. I listen and stroke myself, edge myself, back off when I know I'm too close.

"Very naughty, Angelica, eating her ass. She seems to like that."

I grind my teeth as I visualize it all. Some guys are fine with this. Some guys can deal with being on the periphery. I can't. I never could. Every moan, every gasp, is like an insult. Like a woman tickling my balls, but never going further.

Even last night was like that with Mason. I spent the day watching her fuck that guy, but even those videos ended in a tease.

"I'm going to need your full attention when you do my ass." That was the last video I got. I never did see whether he went through with it. I never did get to see my wife have anal sex with Mason's big, black cock. I doubt that she did, but she left me guessing either way. Fucking bitch.

"Now, my pet, let's see how well you multitask. Can you give while receiving?"

Heather's response is that of a woman teetering on the edge, tight and full of pent-up tension.

"Let's see. Paul, time to join us. I know how much practice she's had on this dick. Now I would love to see it."

Me too, I think. Me, fucking, too.

Heather

Appetizers

“Well that was a surprise,” I say as Paul wraps his arms around me from behind.

We stand outside of the Orchid Lounge, and despite the warm electricity of the night, I shiver. My body buzzes. I’m on edge. The stripper, Angelica, certainly earned her money. I can still feel her tongue between my legs and the orgasm that I was denied. It scrambles my brain.

Turning to Paul, I say, “You know I stripped once?”

“I didn’t.” He’s neither surprised nor judgmental. It’s a different kind of reaction that one I’d get from Joshua. I never told him, either, of course. “Shane?”

I shake my head, although given enough time, my ex-boyfriend would have gone there. “No. I didn’t do it for a guy, actually. I had a friend who danced in college. She got me to do an amateur night.”

“I’d like to see it.” He glances back towards the club’s entrance. “Want to go back in? See if they have an opening?”

“Oh, don’t worry, you’ll get your show soon enough.”

He looks... uncomfortable. But it’s there and gone in a flash. “You have any other secrets you want to share?”

“So many more. But you’ll just have to wait.”

“I’ll be here.” I so want that to be true.

Fingering the collar, I look up at him. "So you want to own me?"

"Not me. You're a gift to Elie."

"You know she's going to push things, right?"

"That's the point."

"And what do I get out of it?"

"A chance to make some new memories, completely free of guilt."

I turn in his arms and look up at him. Something's not quite right, but I can't put my finger on it. "Everything good with you?" I ask.

He leans in, kisses me, and my breath runs away, just as it always does with this man. This is new relationship energy as surely as anything, but I don't care. The booze and the lesbian sex has me all fuzzy. Still, somewhere, I file this something away.

"I don't need this, you know," I say. "Just you."

He grins, and while I'm confused about so many things, there's nothing ambiguous about the way he looks at me. He's happy in such an open, supportive, heart-on-his sleeve way. The walls he's constructed, for one moment, are down.

"We're not talking about need tonight," he whispers. "We're in Vegas, right? This is all about want."

That doesn't sound like something Paul would say. We've been making a joke of Sin City's motto. I touch the collar again, but before I can give it more thought, a sleek, black stretch limo pulls up before us.

"Our ride," Eleanor says.

"Where's Ronald?" I ask. "Thought he was meeting us here."

“He is,” she responds. There’s something wicked in the way Eleanor says it. A moment later, I understand why. Ronald Heller, millionaire and philanthropist, steps out of the front of the limo wearing a chauffeur’s suit, complete with a shiny-brimmed hat and white gloves.

“Sorry I’m late,” he says. “It was harder to run my errand.”

I feel bad for him as he rushes around the limousine to open the door for us.

He hands her a black, leather cord, which she uses to stroke his cheek. “There will be consequences, dear,” she says before sliding into the luxurious car.

I follow, but before I can give him a pitying smile, I see that there’s no reason to. While this is definitely humiliating, he’s wild-eyed and exhilarated.

“Understood, ma’am,” he says to his wife, far too late, like there’s a lag in his brain caused by all the excitement.

This was never my experience with Joshua. While he was certainly obsessed with me becoming a hotwife, the edge he rode was one of jealousy and self-loathing, not submission.

The interior of the stretch limo is plush—there’s room enough for an entire wedding party, which is probably what this vehicle is normally used for. A bar stretches one side and a bench runs the length of the other, curving around the back window.

Eleanor sits in the corner, her long, bare legs crossed, holding two glasses of champagne. She hands me one, and I almost turn it down. I need to pace myself. I don’t. I take it anyway as I slip into place beside her.

Paul climbs in after us, and Ronald shuts the door behind us. “To a night of taking things over the top,” Eleanor toasts. She tips her glass against mine. I expect her to drain it like some party girl, but she’s still Eleanor. She sips it before handing it off to Paul. I follow suit.

The buzz is back, and not the alcohol-induced one. I've already kissed her. I've already touched her. But she's always left me wanting more. And I want so much more.

She touches my face, soft and feminine. I'm close enough to see the sparkle of her makeup and the mascara in her long lashes. I see her eyes dart to my lips before coming back to mine.

"Paul gave you the collar, but only you can give yourself," she whispers. "And before you do, you need to understand what you're agreeing to."

"But what fun would that be?" I see my own wide smile reflected in her. I glance at Paul, who watches just on the other side of her. I'd edged him, just like Angelica had edged me, and I see his own wild excitement. Is this Paul the Bull? Paul the Stag? "I'm down for anything."

"Anything? That covers a lot of ground."

Eleanor is a woman making up for lost time. This whole night is one of her going completely out of control. Am I ready to be a part of that? This time I don't look at Paul. He put this collar on me. If he's okay with this, I'm more than ready.

"Anything."

I hear the rasp of the leash's clip as she fixes it onto the collar. Then she pulls me those last few inches. The hesitancy of our first kiss is gone. Our mouths open fully, our tongues clashing. It's hungry. It's desperate. It's deep and passionate, soft and inevitable. It's like potential energy finally being realized.

She pulls away, but only so she can grasp at the bottom of my LBD and pull it upwards like it's a tight, slinky shirt. We kiss again as she cups and squeezes my breasts through my black bra. That goes next as her hands wander my body.

Over my shoulder, Eleanor says to Paul, "Remember my first time? With Katya?"

“How could I forget?”

“I didn’t even think I was into women.”

“And now?”

She dives forward, sucking a nipple between her lips like a striking snake. She squeezes my breasts as she does so, her eyes fixed on mine the whole time. She switches nipples, testing what I like, gauging what gets me going. More than anything, it’s the way that she looks at me that pumps the blood through my veins.

“Let’s just say I completely skipped over the bicurious stage.” She sinks lower, getting onto her hands and knees on the limo’s bench, and lifts one of my legs over her shoulder. “And I’ve spent so many nights fantasizing about being right here, right where I am.”

If I’m honest, so have I. But I have the feeling that Eleanor’s fantasy is much more than the fleeting thing that mine is.

She runs her tongue across the front of the panties, the delicious pressure just enough to force a moan. I lift my hips against her and rake my fingers through her hair.

She presses the tip of her tongue against my clit, the sensation only bearable because of the thin fabric between us. That doesn’t last. With a yank, the thong is gone and my pussy blossoms open before her.

A smile melts across her face as she glances up at me, lowering her mouth. Tasting me.

It feels so good that I actually bark out a laugh, throwing my head back. It doesn’t put Eleanor off. She covers my mound with her entire mouth, her tongue passing through my wet, swollen vulva.

She reaches up for me, and I link my hands in hers, our fingers entwining as she goes down on me. It’s a tender gesture that no man has ever shared. It

creates a bond. It says, we're doing this together. I squeeze her hands as she works magic over my clit.

I convulse as she goes down on me. I can't just lie there, taking it. It's too much. It's so good. I open my legs wider, arching back, letting go of her so I can catch my tits in my hands and squeeze them.

"You want to come, don't you?"

I can only moan in response.

"Then first, you need to make me come."

Pulling her dress up to her hips, she crawls over me, mounting my face. I'm smothered in pussy for the first time since Skyler, and if this woman's orgasm is all that's keeping me from mine, I go to work.

She tastes good, but even better than that, she sounds good as I eat her. That instant feedback from a woman is like fuel on a fire. Sucking cock is fun, but guys can be so reserved.

"Oh, bloody hell," Eleanor gasps.

I don't let up. I may be rusty, but I have been with a lot of women in my younger years. It's not a skill you forget easily. I munch down on her entire sex, swirling her clit until my tongue starts to ache. She grinds harder on me, cutting off air. I don't stop. Can't stop.

"Take it out of me," I hear her muffled command. I'm confused for only a moment until I realize that she's talking to Paul, not me. Paul, who I have almost forgotten is there. She groans above me before saying, "Now put it in her. She's going to need to get prepared."

A moment later, I feel pressure on my ass—a lot of pressure. The plug. The toy. He's putting it inside of me!

Pain and pleasure dance across my vision. I'm still a little sore from last night, with Mason, and early this morning, with Paul. Despite that, or

maybe because of the practice, he lodges the toy in. I nearly come. I want to come. I'm so desperate for it.

Eleanor lifts her hips from my face, though, and looks down at me, shaking her head. "Uh, uh, uh. You're not thinking of coming first, are you?"

I shake my head, because I don't trust myself to speak.

"Good girl." She looks up, out the window, and smiles. "Looks like you're going to have to wait a little longer. We have arrived."

Paul

Mason's Posse

"You made it." Mason greets me with a bro shake. We slap each other's backs. We play like what's about to happen is no big deal. Like we participate in gangbangs all the time. Maybe once, not too long ago, I would actually would have felt that way. "I knew you wouldn't be able to stay away."

"Couldn't let you have all the fun."

"That's my boy." He puts an arm around me and leads me out into the backyard. "It'll be like that moms-night-out, with Lacey and Kelly, only way more intense."

That night, as exciting as it was, will always be tainted by Stephanie and her guilt—and my guilt. She had fun, but we may have ruined her life. Is that what I was doing here? Ruining Heather's life?

The house that Eleanor picked to fulfill her ultimate fantasy is beautiful, like a mini-resort out here in the foothills of Las Vegas—tiled roof, stone-work and stucco details, a high privacy fence that opens into an enchanting backyard.

The house itself is mostly dark. The men that Mason has assembled are outside, milling about. "I trust these guys," he says as he leads me to them. "You can trust them, too."

Trust isn't an easy thing for me these days, but I can fake it.

Beneath the beer garden lights that criss-cross the patio, there are six other guys, besides us. Six. Three are black, two are white, and all are tall and

gym-hewn. Any one of them would meet the stock image criteria for “guy.”

Mason makes introductions. I don’t even bother trying to remember their names. They are the chorus. They are the stunt cocks. Even as we shake hands and fist bump and make conversation, my mind is on what happens later, when these guys are naked and fucking... Manhattan. When she’s straddling one of them, her back bowed back, her skin slick, her long, golden hair dark with sweat.

It gets me hard. I admit it. I have to admit it. Soon, it’ll be impossible not to.

They all know each other, although not all through Mason. Mason went to Harvard with one of the white guys, who later joined the Marines and met most of the other guys. There was something about an ex-wife of one of them that I didn’t quite pick up on, but as far as I could tell, none of these guys were attached.

“What about you, Paul? I’m assuming you’re a freelancer?” Mason doesn’t ask it, but I know that he’s listening to my answer. He’s still puzzling out what’s going on with me and Heather. Hell, so am I.

I also don’t know if any of these guys is in Joshua’s pocket. It’s a paranoid thought, sure, but now that I know what the man is capable of, I’ve been having a bunch of those.

“I wouldn’t want to disappoint any of my ladies by picking just one.”

Mason claps softly. “See, told you he was cool.”

The sliding doors to the mansion open before he can say more, and Ronald Heller strolls out. He takes in the scene, openly regarding each of these men the way I’ve been trying to hide—these are men about to put their dicks into a woman he cares very deeply for. He’s got the manic grin of an addict about to get his ultimate fix.

“The man of the hour,” Mason says with an open-armed greeting. “Fellas, this is Ronald, our audience.”

“Mason, can you go upstairs? They need to talk to you.”

“They?” he asks.

“You’ll see.”

Mason shrugs. “Be right back.” And inside he heads. The jealousy and envy strain over me like a barbell weighted to my limit. It’s crushing. It’s also exhilarating.

“How do you stand this feeling?” I ask Ron when I get him by myself.

“What, um, feeling?”

“Like the whole world is burning around you, and you’re strapped to a chair unable to stop any of it.”

He smiles at the description. “I guess I kind of like it.” Then he looks at me, seeing beyond his own fantasy. “Why are you here if you don’t? Why is she here?”

“Because this isn’t just about me and my wants.” Last night’s reclamation comes to mind and loosens my tongue. “Or about her wants, even.”

“It’s about what you want together.” Ron speaks like a man who knows exactly how I feel. But I’m nothing like this man. He left his chauffeur hat and gloves in the car, but still wears the black suit and tie, looking like the cross between a groom and a funeral director. That’s kind of like how I feel, too.

“Her husband is making me,” I blurt. That’s also knee-jerk. “He’s got photos and video.”

“Actually, I know. Eleanor told me. On a private server?”

She knows? I move past it. My mind’s a smear right now. “He has photos of Eleanor, too.”

And if the pictures ever got out, it would be devastating to the Memory Project in ways that even the Hamilton Scandal was not. The media has a greater tolerance for financial gossip than it does for sexual ones.

Ronald takes it much more smoothly than I feel. Is this more submissive bullshit? It's infuriating. "He's got a whole server of it—not just of us, but of others. His partners in his law firm. Probably more of Heather."

"Paul—"

"And he's got a wire on her right now. It's in a collar that he made for her."

This finally gives him pause. He scratches his cheek, then looks beyond me, out into the dark hills around the house. "You think he's here?"

"He's close. The wire his wife's wearing is short-range." His wife. I hate how cold that even sounds.

"And she's not in on this."

"Of course not."

"Okay." He forces a smile and claps me on the back. "I guess our hands are tied then. No sense in stopping the show now, eh?" When he drifts off, I shake my head. I don't understand that. How is a man like him so successful in life? Still, it feels good to tell someone. Not even Heather knows about the wire.

I look off into the night's landscape. Behind us, the Nevada desert stretches, rising to dark hills the ring the city. Joshua is probably out there, listening, hoping to watch, armed with a telephoto lens to capture even more blackmail fodder

And here I am, unable to stop any of it. Unable to even leave it all behind. Ronald is right. I have to be a part of this. I have to go with it all.

Mason returns, alone, with a smile that could light up the entire back yard. He rubs his hands together with glee. "We have an extra special treat tonight," he says. "Remember that chick I was telling you about?"

“The one you’ve been hotting on for months now?” asks one of his friends.

“Not months,” he chuckles. “But yeah. That one. Well, she’s here, and let me tell you from my experience last night, that one loves fucking. Kind of reminds me of Jenna,” he says to one of the guys, who grins and nods.

“Only less of the Crazy.”

“Jenna was pretty fucking crazy,” the guy agrees. “Didn’t she try to cut your dick off once?”

Mason chuckles. “She did. Worth the risk. I love a blonde who likes to take it hard up the ass.” He at least has the decency to look somewhat sheepishly at me as he adds, “Another thing that makes Heather so special.”

“I can back that up,” I say. I don’t know why. Force of habit, maybe. Looking to build credibility with this group? One-upmanship? It just came out, and with the intended results. Mason looks surprised, then impressed, then mildly chagrined.

“I fucking knew you were holding out on me.”

“Unlike you, I don’t need to go around swinging my dick to know I’m packing.”

“How long you been banging her?”

“Longer than you.”

“Oh, ho!” I get from the other guys, who watch our volley like a tennis match. Mason’s not pissed or upset. If anything, he’s amused. He’s a man comfortable and confident among his posse, and he’s the one allowing me to run my mouth.

His focus shifts to the house behind me. I hear the doors open. I hear the approval of the other guys around me. It’s showtime.

Heather

Foreplay

Eleanor is radiant in her white dress—a bride on her wedding night. Or at least a pornographer’s version of that bride. She even wears a veil, gossamer white and flowing behind from her short bob.

“What do you think?” she asks, doing a spin. “Do I look virginal?”

The halter dress, I notice, is sheer enough that I can see the outline of her white thong beneath—the eternal struggle with wearing white. It’s also very short.

I laugh. “If that’s your intent, then I’m afraid you’re falling short.”

She tugged at the hem of her dress. “It is quite short, isn’t it?”

Despite the fact that I can see her nipples through the dress, her refined accent almost makes the whole thing seem refined.

“Are you certain about this, Heather? Last chance...”

My stomach tightens. I keep getting fed these outs, maybe I should take this one. All it takes is the thought of Paul Sharpe down there with the bullpen of guys, doing his part to give Mrs. Eleanor Heller the night of her life. My stomach tightens even more.

“Why do you think I’m not certain?”

“Because you love him.” She’s so direct, so self-assured.

“I...”

“Shh... it’s okay. I know.” She takes my hands. “And it’s okay, Heather. You can love him. You can be head-over-heels with him.”

“And still want to fuck a roomful of guys?”

“I’ve never loved Ronald more, and I’ve set all of this up tonight.” She’s painted her lips bright red. I could kiss them, but don’t want to disturb the perfect application. “Now, Heather, are you certain? Last chance. I will not ask again.”

I take a deep breath. I need to do this, whatever the outcome. I nod.

She lets my hands go and steps back, giving me a once over. My being here was never planned. I don’t have a new, sexy outfit like she does. Instead, all I have are my spiky heels, a pair of her black, seamed stay-ups, and the dog collar. I feel so exposed in front of Eleanor—how am I going to do this in front of a bunch of strange men?

And yet that prospect is exhilarating. It hits me like any drug I’ve ever tried. It vibrates between my ears and along my scalp.

Eleanor clips a leash to my collar and holds up the looped end. It’s black and leather, snake-like, dangerous. “From now on, Manhattan, you are to serve whoever holds this.”

“Got it—”

She tightens her grip. “You mean, ‘Yes, Mistress.’”

Part of me wants to laugh. The other sees the danger in that. I bow my head. “Yes, Mistress.”

“Good girl.” She slides the leash into my hand. “I want you to go out there and give this to Mason. You’re his... until I join you. Warm them up for me.”

“I’ll see you out there soon, Mistress.”

“Don’t worry. That’s the plan.”

She kisses me gently, our lips barely touching. I gasp as I feel her fingertips slide between my legs. “You are my fluffer, dear. You are to fluff, not make them come. Work those boys up. I want them out of their minds by the time I come down.”

Ronald passes me on my way out, taking me in. His eyes linger on my collar. I shouldn’t blush, but do. “You look...” His voice trails off.

“Aren’t you supposed to be downstairs waiting with the others?”

“I’ll... I have to say something to Elle.” He can’t meet my eyes. Still blushing, he goes into the bedroom.

In the living room, on the coffee table, sits a bowl of condoms. There’s also an array of sex toys laid out—dildos, vibrators, leather cuffs, a blindfold. It’s the promise of the night in visual form. A shiver of adrenaline runs up my spine.

I catch my reflection in the mirror just before stepping outside. I see myself the way all the men outside are about to see me, notice the details that they will notice—how hard my nipples are, the faint lines of my bikini tan, the way my pussy glistens.

I float. I’m a cloud, ephemeral and on the verge of breaking apart. I don’t feel my heels touch the ground. I don’t feel my hand slide open the door. Yet I feel everything, and everything feels wonderful.

“Da-yam,” one guy says.

“Shiiit!” another barks in approval.

I barely hear any of it. I barely see the others. I see Mason, and I see Paul, who stands there expressionless. When he nods, ever so slightly, a weight leaves me.

Sound snaps back. I see all the guys. My body flows with the hip hop over the speakers. I know what comes next. I know what I have gotten myself into. And I’m ready.

“This is yours,” I say. I should be handing the leash to Mason. That’s what I’ve been told to do. But it’s Paul’s hand that I slip the leather strap into. It’s always going to be Paul’s. “I’m yours.”

Paul doesn’t say anything. Not at first. But the look that passes between us is heavy and full and meaningful. My knees want to buckle like a teenage girl’s. My heart pounds. I bat my eyes at him. He grins.

“Can you believe this one?” he asks Mason.

Mason chuckles. “Actually, yes I can.”

Paul hands the leash off to his friend and says, “She always wants to be the center of attention, doesn’t she?”

Mason nods, wrapping the leash around his fist and nudging me closer to him. “Women who look like her are used to it.”

“But tonight is Elie’s,” Paul says. “We can all agree on that?”

Mason answers. “Yeah, she’ll get her time in the spotlight.”

The question, though, isn’t for Mason. Paul’s gaze is as demanding as a spank. It’s intoxicating. “Yes,” I say like it’s yanked from my throat.

I’m right up against Mason when he reaches down and reads the collar. He smiles. “‘Manhattan’. Interesting choice. Shouldn’t you be a redhead with a name like that?”

“Blondes have more fun.”

He chuckles. “Okay, Manhattan. Let’s see about that.”

Mason draws me in for a kiss. I couldn’t resist it, even if I wanted to. He’s too strong, and I’m on his leash. So I kiss him, feeling Paul’s eyes on me the whole time. I don’t hold back. I reach up, touch his face. His skin is so soft, so warm. No stubble, unlike Paul’s, and exciting because of it.

When he breaks the kiss, I'm out of breath. I want more. He just chuckles and turns me towards his friends. They're already stripping, pulling their shirts off and showing off their gym-swelled upper bodies. They know the score. They know their role.

“So, Manhattan, you told me last night that you'd do anything for this big, black cock. Ready to prove it?”

The guys seem to flex and preen. To Mason, I nod. Yes, they know their role, and I know mine...

Paul

Showtime

This isn't like watching the videos that Joshua sent. I don't feel removed from it, like I'm powerless, like I'm distant. As Heather—Manhattan—makes out with Mason just a few feet from me, the emotion that runs through me is like a hurricane. As I watch her wade into the circle of Mason's friends and drop to her knees, the howling picks up and it's all I can do to stand tall.

Yet stand tall I do. I must. To do anything less would be to succumb to Joshua and his games. I glance out at the foothills beyond the house. Is he out there, watching like the pervert he is? Or is he content just to listen?

The sound of a dick sliding into a throat draws my own attention back to the scene. The men are now naked, making a ring around Heather as she blows one guy and jerks two others off. The other three men crowd her space, cocks in hands, ready to feel her touch. She doesn't hold back. She doesn't linger on any one man. She moves from cock to cock, sucking and stroking as they all moan around her.

She moans as she pops off one cock. "Mmm, are you boys all hard for me?" She takes another deep into her throat before drawing off. "I love a thick, black cock." She looks right over at Mason. "Don't I?"

Mason pulls his shirt up and over his head. His body is sleek and dark, catching the soft light of the beer garden bulbs that hang overhead. He glances at me. "And that's why you'll never really be on my level," he taunts. "White boy."

I know it's made in jest. I know this is just another round of one-upmanship. It gets under my skin anyway. I can take comfort in the fact that it probably gets under the listening Joshua's skin even more.

"You think that's why she left her husband?" I ask.

Mason laughs, joining the circle and taking back the leash. "I really don't give a fuck about that loser."

Perfect. Any chance that he's in collusion with Joshua is gone.

Mason leads the group to the patio furniture, sitting Heather on the edge of a cushioned sectional. The guys crowd around her, kissing her, feeling her up, offering their cocks. Once again, she's going from dick to dick, bathing all that erect masculinity in glistening spit.

"Fuuuuck," she groans. Mason, at her side, slides two, fat fingers into her. He tightens his grip of her collar, forcing her to take his friend all the way to the root. Another man, one of the white guys, gets down between her legs.

"Edge her. Don't let her come," Mason orders. "Boss's orders."

Seven men swarm her. Too many for her to satisfy with just her mouth and hands. They grope her. They play with her tits, licking her nipples and kissing her neck. One man gets lower and starts sucking on her toes, which nearly gets her off.

I know what comes next—what's inevitable. This is all foreplay to the main event. All eight of us are so ready for it. Manhattan is the first to beg for it.

"I need a cock in me."

"I've got you, bella," the man who'd been eating her pussy says, his accent thick and Italian. He begins to rise.

This is where she opens her eyes and looks in my direction. This is the part where she remembers me, where she puts me first, not some random stranger with a sexy accent.

But that doesn't happen. She's in the thrall of the moment. The other men part just enough as this one guy rises between her legs. He's already rolling a condom down over his uncircumcised prick. She's already reaching out to guide it to her.

No one stops her. No one halts the madness. Not even me, even as it tears at me with claws of jealousy and betrayal. This is what Joshua wanted me to see. This is a glimpse at the woman he's counting on me hating. She wants sex. She craves it above all else.

On either side of her, the men hold her against them on the rattan sectional, opening her legs and continuing to squeeze her breasts. Her nipples are hard, distended, perfect to pinch and twist. She writhes amidst all that flesh. Mason rubs her mound. "She's nice and wet for you, Gio. Break her in for us."

"Fuck!" Manhattan cries. I can see it perfectly, another man's erection rub along the channel of shaved sex. She gasps, struggling against the arms that hold her in place, and spreads her legs even wider.

"You want that dick," Mason says.

"Yes."

"You want all these dicks." He squeezes her cheeks. "Don't you?"

"Mmmhmm..." She finds me through all the men, through all the distraction. At last, she acknowledges that I'm there, her blue eyes lucid. "I want it all... all at once—" She nearly barks as Gio strokes his cock along her clit, teasing her. "I want to fuck until I pass out." She looks at Mason now. "And I want to wake up getting fucked."

Eleanor's voice rings out from the sliding doors of the residence. "I think we can accommodate that. Don't you, Paul?"

She stands like a bride at the end of the aisle, ready to join the ceremony, adorned in a tight, white dress. She steps forward. The light shifts along her just enough that I realize how thin the material is. I can see her nipples and

the outline of her panties. Her short, dark hair is pinned back, and beyond, a veil flows.

“That’s what tonight’s all about, right?” I say. “Getting fucked?” I look right at Manhattan, who watches me with startling clarity. “So let’s get fucked.”

Gio finally slides his cock into Heather’s well-prepped pussy. She arches back, digging her shoulders into the two guys on either side of her. They hold her aloft as Gio buries himself all the way to his dark, trimmed curls.

In that moment, something clicks. I get what Ron feels. I even get Joshua. I don’t exactly share it, but I grasp the fantasy. I feel all that explosive jealousy. It’s like a pressure between my eyes and deep in my gut. It sizzles. And yet, as I watch Heather, the first woman that I’ve met that I can imagine a future with, get her pussy stretched out by a man I’ve only met tonight, I feel connected to her in a way that I didn’t think possible.

“What sexy theatre,” Eleanor says, floating over to me. Ronald follows after, so silent I didn’t see him until now. “Sit over there, Ronald,” she orders, pointing to a lone chair. Taking my hand, she guides me to a lounge that’s perpendicular to the action. “Time to watch your bride get gangbanged.”



“Oh, my...” Eleanor’s moan cascades over whatever she’s trying to say. “Ohhhh, yesss...” It’s like listening to the ocean’s surf come in and go out. I hold her by the hips, her thong stretched to the side, my cock sliding in and out of her tight asshole. “I’m so... sooo stuffed...”

Beneath her on the lounge is Mason, his own cock jammed in her pussy, completing the double penetration. She still wears the veil, but the dress is long gone.

Mason and I are competitive in all things. Fucking Eleanor is no exception. When she told us that she wanted to warm up with her two “original bulls,” she knew what she was going to get. We didn’t disappoint.

I’d never done this. I’d shared a girl, of course, but never in a DP. Getting started was a bit awkward, but we’re both experienced studs. Eleanor made it as easy as possible, wearing the butt plug and conditioning her asshole. Still, it’s only now that we really start to go to town.

All but Gio stand around us, slowly jerking their cocks. I can feel their bodies like humidity on a hot summer day. It’s hard to shut that out, the hyenas, the jackals, the support.

All I need to do to stay hard, though, is to look beyond the ring to where Gio pounds away at Heather, whose long legs wrap around his muscular back. Judging from her cries, she’s very into what he’s giving her.

Eleanor takes things to the next level herself. She reaches out, grasping at the cocks around her. Like Heather before her, they swarm in for her, feeding her their erections—four thick and black, one thick and white.

“Air tight, baby!” one cries as she gags on his cock.

“Look at her go.”

“Choke on that black dick!”

Choke she does, her wet gargle only broken up as she moves on to the next cock. She seems to feast, super charged and ravenous. Her hands work the cocks that aren’t filling a hole. Her ass jiggles. Her whole body roils and judders.

As hot as that is to watch, it’s Heather with Gio that pushes me over the edge. They’ve shifted. He’s sitting now, and she’s riding in his lap, her back to me, her ass twerking in his lap. Her tattoo dances, the naughty tiara, the naughty golden girl. Below that, the anal plug that Eleanor inserted in the limo.

One of the guys breaks off from our group, a black guy named Drake. Tired of waiting for his turn, he sees the bling in Heather's ass. He's drawn to it.

"No fair Gio gets you all to himself." His voice is deep and confident. He scoops a condom wrapper from the bowl. "Is it?"

Heather checks him over her shoulder, her eyes flicking down to his readied member. "Definitely not fair."

This should be me, I think.

"As much as I love blow jobs from pretty white chicks, I'm ready for more."

Heather reaches behind her and pulls the plug free. Her anus gapes. "Me too."

As I watch Drake move into place behind her, rolling the rubber down his fat tool, my brain hiccups. That should have been me...

Drake sinks into Heather's ass. She cries out.

...but it's fucking riveting that it's not.

I explode inside of Elie.

Heather

Orgy

I feel his eyes on me. I feel them the way the horizon feels the sun at dawn. It's warm and new and I want to bask in it. Instead, I scream out an orgasm as two men pump their cocks into my ass and pussy.

The double penetration is just as intense as I remember. The pressure is real, a kettle on a hot stove that's screaming and screaming and screaming. "Yes, yes, yes!" I yell with each hard thrust. Drake has one hand pulling on my hair, the other pulling on my leash. "Fuck my ass. Fuck... my... ass!"

I say it because it's what I want. I also say it for my audience. Whatever happens next for Paul and I, we're going to have to deal with this. He might as well see the most extreme of it.

Gio abuses my tits, squeezing them, tweaking my nipples. Normally, I'd hate it. In this moment when pain rides pleasure rides pain, I need it. "I need it!" I scream, an echo of my thoughts. "I need it harder!"

They oblige, and somewhere beyond the scarlet haze of lust, Paul watches. I go off again. Or maybe I never stopped. I arch back, giving in to Drake's tug. I want to feel his cock go off in my ass. I want to feel the heat of Gio joining him. Even through the condoms, I crave it.

A third man joins us, offering me his semi-soft cock. It glistens with something, and when I take him into my mouth, I taste the spermicide of his condom and the astringent taste of come. He's already had round one. I'm here to get him ready for two.

"Look up at him, baby. Show Jarrett those baby blues. He likes that."

I do. He looks like he stands a mile tall, wearing mirror shaded sunglasses despite the night. I can see a distorted version of myself beneath him, and even there, I know I'm a mess. Sweat beads all over my body. My hair is damp with it. My mascara has begun to run.

He begins to thicken in my mouth, growing hard and long enough that it soon hits the back of my throat. I don't let up. These men won't let me. Drake uses the leash and collar to hold me in place as Jarrett fucks my face.

"Ggh! Ggh! Ggh!" My moans are wet, choked things. I know they like the sound, though. I know I like hearing them from Eleanor.

We shift. Gio and Drake join Eleanor. Other men join me and Jarrett. I lose track of who. All I know is that they're not Mason and they're not Paul. They are cocks, white, black, all attached to hard bodies that feel good when I run my fingers over them.

One man sits on my chest, laying his cock between my breasts. I squeeze them around the shaft, giving him a nice, snug channel to titfuck. He sinks his hips back into me, forcing my face between his cheeks. Unable to resist, I rim his ass as another man throws my legs over his shoulders and fills my pussy.

I lose track of the orgasms. I lose track of the time. Hours could have passed. I feel rubberized. My throat is hoarse from the screaming, the moaning, from all the cocks I've swallowed and the tugs on the collar.

Eleanor crawls over to me, looking wild. She has come on her face and in her hair. Somehow, her veil remains in her hair. She looks at me funny, and when she kisses me, I know why. She pushes come into my mouth, then laughs as she sits back.

"You know what's pathetic?" She brushes my damp hair off my forehead. "Husbands. Isn't that right, Ronald?"

She glances off to her left. I follow. Ronald is the only man clothed. He sits stiffly in one of the chairs, arms white knuckled on the arms. His pants

bulge. I get the feeling, though, that this isn't the only husband she's referring to.

Ronald just nods obediently. "This one's been good, though," I say.

"He has. Shall we offer him a reward?" She grabs my leash and pulls. I start to stand before she corrects me. "Uh uh. On your hands and knees, my pet."

I've done a lot of crazy things tonight. The prospect of fucking Eleanor's husband shouldn't shock me, but it does. This, more than anything else, feels like a bold line we're about to cross.

"I know you've always checked out Heather—"

"That's not true, sweetheart," he protests.

"With her blond hair and her tiny waist... I know you sometimes think about her when you're with me."

"Never." And yet when he looks at me, I know it's true. I've always known he's had a crush on me. I also know that it's harmless. He blushes when he meets my eyes, then looks away.

"It's okay. I checked her out, too... even before I realized how into women I was." Eleanor stops us just short of him. I look up from my knees, obediently, and he focuses entirely on his wife. "Tell you what. Heather will suck that tiny little baby dick of yours while Paul reclaims her like a real man. If you can resist coming before he does, then you can fuck her."

"Eleanor, you don't—"

"But if you are pathetic and can't man up and hold off, then you wear the cage the rest of the evening."

He goes white. I feel bad for him, but also recognize that he's as into the scenario as Eleanor. These two were made for each other. I wonder what Joshua would say to this.

Joshua. How amazing that I hadn't thought about him until now. How refreshing.

I bat my lashes up at Ronald. He's a good looking man in that soft, family guy kind of way. He's wearing khakis and boat shoes, his polo shirt still tucked in despite the disheveled state of everyone else here. He's certainly not my type, but that's more of an attitude thing than anything else.

"So you have a thing for me?" I say sweetly.

His face blows up, bright red.

"It's okay. Don't be shy. No one else here is." I reach up and run my hands along the front of his khakis, tracing the bulge. A wet spot has formed at the tip. "You haven't come yet, have you?"

He shakes his head, like he doesn't trust himself to speak.

This still feels like a transgression. If I wasn't wearing the collar, I don't think I'd ever do this. But it's time to let go of control. Time to truly give it up to this moment.

I free his cock, opening his trousers like a gift. For all Eleanor's cruel teasing, his dick isn't actually all that small—it's no Mason, or even Paul, but it would feel good sliding in and out of me. It will be fun to suck...

But not yet. Wrapping my fingers around him, I slowly look up into his eyes. "You watched me play with myself, didn't you? That night your wife was with Jamie?"

His cock twitches. He did.

"It's okay. I like to be watched, you like watching. No harm." I lean down, kissing along the side of his erection. "Now you're going to watch your wife take on seven guys at once while I give you the blowjob you've been fantasizing about." I flick my tongue along the underside of his cockhead and watch him shudder. "Think you can hold out?"

There's no way. I almost feel bad for him.

And then Paul moves into place behind me, his familiar hands on my hips, his familiar musk in my nose. “Good luck,” Paul says. “I’ve already come once while taking your wife’s ass. Outlast me, and this one—” He slaps my ass. “—is all yours.”

He enters me as I wrap my lips around Ronald Heller. The poor guy nearly loses it right away. I’m happy that he doesn’t. Now the game is on.

Joshua

Watching

This is wilder than I ever dreamed. Between the listening device that Heather wears and the telephoto lens on my dSLR, it's almost like I'm there. Better, I can snap photos and video to go back into my collection.

Heather has not only shed the competent professionalism she's always strived to cultivate—even with me—but she's ripped it away like Mason Coles did with her thong.

“Look at them,” she says, taunting Ronald Heller. “Look at what they’re doing to your wife.”

I look, too, because I can look. I can do whatever the fuck I want. Eleanor Heller, that doe-eyed woman of high society, is straddling a big, black man's cock as she does her best to blow another man with an equally big, equally black cock. She's drenched in sweat after the long night of sex, her short hair plastered to her face and scalp, her lipstick gone.

“Tell me what you see,” my wife orders between laps at Ronald's dick. “What are they doing to her?”

“She's—oh, my goodness! She's got three of them...”

I can see it in the telephoto lens. The shutter clicks as I capture the moment. Another man has moved in behind her, one of the white guys. He grabs her hips to hold her steady and pushes his cock into her ass.

Eleanor had already pulled a train with these guys. Every man, all eight of them, including Paul, had fucked her ass. This guy has no problem pushing balls deep.

“Three all at once...” The breath goes out of Ron as he nearly loses it.

I can't blame him. It's an incredible sight. I'd already come in the bushes watching Heather get DPed. It was all I could do not to load up that video and watch it again, right now.

“One in her pussy?” Heather asked.

“Yes.”

“Her mouth?”

“Uh huh.”

“Her ass?”

“Oh, God...”

He's already coming. Such a pathetic fool. And now he's going to let himself get caged up. I would never allow that. Never. He needs to get his house in order.

I look back at Heather, eager to watch her take this wimp's load on her face. Instead, she presses her thumb against his prostate to cut off his orgasm. He trembles, clutching the arms of the chair, his whole body stiff, but no come emerges. She's done that with me when she's wanted to prolong the night. Why would she help him?

When his tremors pass, Heather sits up on her knees and whispers, “Our little secret. We won't tell Elle, but you need to do better, okay?” I can only hear it because the mic is right up against her throat. I'm not even sure Paul's privy.

Ronald nods obediently, gratefully. He's going to need it.

“You know what a DVP is?” Mason asks.

I swivel right back to the action, because I know what a DVP is—double vaginal penetration. These guys were really going there?

Eleanor shakes her head, her eyes still shut from the three men fucking her.

Mason goes to her, grabbing her by the hair. He pulls her off his friend's cock, forces her to look at him. "Two cocks in your pussy, all at once."

Eleanor's eyes go wide, but not in the scared, shocked way. More like she's discovered a new kind of candy. "Sounds intense."

"You're about to find out just how much." Mason nods at his posse. They shift around her, knowing what to do. A new guy swoops in, a fresh condom on. "This is Drake, and he's about to blow your pretty little head right off."

Even Heather is unable to look away. She's stroking Ronald, but watching her friend takes a second black cock into her pussy. "Jesus," she whispers beneath her breath. Eleanor, on the other hand, screams.

The men, however, are not done with Eleanor. Mason isn't going to hold back. Pushing his friend, Drake, back, he throws a leg over Eleanor, mounts her ass, and buries his dick into her backdoor.

"Fuuuuu—" She's silenced by a fourth cock rammed down her throat.

"Wow," Heather breathes

"Never done that?" Paul asks.

"No way." Her laugh is one of disbelief. "You wish I had?"

I know that I sure as hell do. But that's not my immediate emotion—that is reserved for raw envy. There's an intimacy between Paul and Heather that I don't want to believe, but can't deny. It's exactly all I ever wanted from the hotwife fantasy. It's Melody with Garrett all over again. It's the fire that I can't resist.

"Nah. I like a girl with some boundaries."

"Who said anything about boundaries. All I said was I'd never done that."

"You wouldn't..."

“Who knows what the future will bring.”

I tear myself away from the telephoto lens. I rip the earbuds out and look away. The sky is clearer out here than it is closer into the city. Less light pollution, more stars. They look down on me in judgment. What are you going to do? What kind of man are you, letting that cocksucker take your wife?

“I’m going to fuck your life, Paul Sharpe,” I say into the night. “I cannot wait until I see the look on your face when you realize how fucked you are.”

Feeling better about myself, I pop the earbud back in. Heather is laughing. “You’re really going to answer your phone right now?”

“Oh, this is so important.”

Something feels wrong. I pull the camera back up and find Ronald. He’s... looking out into the dark. Out towards me. I feel the world come crashing in around me. Something is terribly fucking wrong.

“What?”

“I guess your husband will never know whether you also try a DVP.”

Heather catches on, too, her attention immediately snapping my way. I duck low. I’m hidden. They couldn’t possibly have seen me.

The crunch of brush behind me seals my doom. “Well, well. Look what we have here.”

I turn to see a man in a pair of slacks and a button down shirt tucked neatly into his belt. On that belt, he wears a holstered sidearm. It’s the badge that hangs on the other side of me that freezes my blood.

“You, sir, are under arrest for unlawfully spying into a domicile of another, and...” He glances down at me, where my pants around my thighs and my quickly flagging cock hanging out in the breeze. “...and indecent exposure, it seems.”

“Can I see some ID?” I manage to say.

The guy’s chuckle is humiliating. I grit my teeth as he pulls his badge off his belt and shows it to me. I can barely see it in the dark, but it doesn’t matter. I’m fucked.

“Why don’t you put that thing away, sir.”

“Come on now, officer.” I hold up my camera with its long lens. I show him the latest, raunchy scene in the ViewFinder. “You could arrest me, or you could let me go and see the wildest thing you’ve probably ever seen.”

He takes the camera from me, and for one brief moment, I feel relief. Then he says, “I’ve retrieved the camera. I’ll get his phone next.”

For a second, I’m confused. Then, I hear Ronald respond through the earbud. “Excellent, Brody. You know what to do.”

He looks right at me. “Oh, yes, I do.” He pulls the cuffs off. “Don’t want to get decent? Whatever. I’ll take you in naked if that’s your kink. Come along, Mr. Fletcher.”

A terrible rending fills my ears. The last thing I hear, before the transmission dies, is Heather saying, “Goodbye, Joshua.”

Paul

Morning After

I wake to the morning light and a woman's warm body spooned against me. She breathes with the slow cadence of peace and exhaustion. She feels wonderful in my arms.

Snippets of last night return, like scraps of another man's memory. They weren't even my fantasies, yet my cock reacts like they were. This is my fantasy—this moment right now. I want to hold onto it forever.

She stirs, turning onto her back. Her golden hair sweeps across her forehead. How does it look so good after last night?

"You're awake," she says with a croak.

"Yeah."

I can also see the memories of last night return. She takes a short breath. Worry-lines form around the corners of her mouth. She flops her head back into the pillow and sets the palm of her hand on her forehead. "Did last night really happen?"

"You mean did you really take on eight guys at once? Yes."

She slides her hand down, covering her eyes as she groans. Then, splaying her fingers slightly, she peeks through, up at me. "How are you doing?"

"You mean am I disgusted at what a slut you were?" She looks alarmed at the question, and I smile to put her at ease. "More like impressed. I'm not sure I could have kept up with eight women."

I can feel the relief flow from her. “I bet you’d try.”

“You know me so well.”

She grabs the pillow from under her and slaps me with a laugh. When that subsides, she grows sober. She squeezes one eye shut and studies me.

“Would you really have broken up with me?”

Last night, Ronald Heller did an amazing thing. After Heather told Eleanor about her failed virus attempt, Ronald got his best cyber security guys to break into his server and wipe all of the incriminating stuff away. When I told him about the wire and Joshua in the woods, he had a solution to that, too. Who knew that Ronald Heller would be the hero of the moment?

Now all that’s left are hard conversations. In some ways, things were easier last night. Joshua wanted me to break up with her after the orgy. Would I have done it? “Yes,” I say, opting for honesty. “To protect your future, and Eleanor’s.”

“You need to stop trying to be the white knight. You know I don’t want that.”

I reach out and touch her neck. Her skin is soft, bare, the collar long gone. She played the submissive well last night, but we both know that she’s my equal. “You would have done the same in my situation.”

She pinches me.

“Ouch!”

“I would have talked to you about it. We would have figured it out together.”

We had gone over this, too. There was no time to talk to her about it. Not with the wire on. Maybe after, but I don’t know what I would have done had things gone a different way. So I change the conversation with a half-joke. “Maybe I wanted to watch you take on all those guys.”

It works, but it also brings up another uncomfortable conversation.

“So are you, like...” She casts her attention away, a blush rising.

“Like Ronald? Or your husband?” That puts a bad taste in my mouth. “I want to say no. Mostly I’m not. But fuck it, if I can’t talk to you about this, I can’t talk to anyone.” Which is mostly the way it’s been all my life. “A part of me did get excited to see that, yes. Like I said, it was impressive.”

“And you didn’t get jealous?”

“Maybe a little. Especially when you were with Mason.”

We’d moved inside once Joshua was caught and hauled off. There, most of the group had taken a break. Eleanor had made a big show of locking Ronald—the savior of the night—into a cock cage. Mason, however, had spent most of the triple penetration watching and was still stiff and raring to go. When he crooked his finger at Heather, she did look in my direction for approval. I gave it, and as I watched them put on a fuck show on one of the sofas, I grew hard again.

“But you know where that led.”

“Oh, I remember.”

They had spread themselves out on the sofa, Mason behind, Heather facing out. He held one of her legs up, bent at the knees, so that everyone in the room could watch his thick, dark meat piston in and out of Heather’s bald, white pussy. She reached down as her climax neared, rubbing her clit in a blur of fingers.

She spotted me watching her and beckoned me over. I’d gone, crouching down beside her to kiss her, to caress her face as her eyes rolled back and she came hard.

“You’re not going to run away with Mason Coles, are you?”

“Nah. His cock is too big to be a regular thing.” She knows how to make me laugh. “Plus, he’s a little full of himself.”

“Didn’t you once say that about me?”

“Well, you are, too, but I’ve figured something out.”

“What’s that?”

“It’s all a show, you big softie.” She needles me. “A bit stubborn, for sure, but it’s not something we can’t work on.”



Only Ronald Heller is downstairs when we finally emerge. He’s dressed in his khakis and a golf shirt with a woman’s apron tied on. “Coffee?” He gestures towards the fresh pot with a pair of tongs, dripping with bacon grease. My stomach grumbles. “Breakfast should be ready soon.”

“Where’s Eleanor?” Heather asks.

“Upstairs with Mason still.” He glances towards the bedrooms, the whisper of a smile on his lips. He shakes himself out of his revelry. “Everyone else already left.”

I go to the coffee and pour two cups. “How are you holding up?” I ask him. It’s a heavy question that I try to make as light and casual as I can.

He pauses at the bacon, looking at no one. “You know what? I feel amazing.” He draws a deep breath and shakes his head. “I know it’s not how a... man, or whatever, should feel. But I love it.” His smile only grows. “And I love her.”

I hand my coffee to Heather, and we share a smile. “Who am I to judge?”

Despite the reassurance, Ron seems ready to move things on. “So I heard back from my guys. You’re safe. Since we were able to get into his phone—thank God for Face ID, Apple—we were able to track all of Joshua’s backups. No more chance of blackmail.”

“Thank you, Ronald.” I use his full name. This is a time for respect, and I owe him so much. “I have no idea how to repay you.”

He waves it away, but a blush is already rising in his cheeks. When he glances at Heather, then quickly away, I have some idea what’s on his mind.

Heather ignores it. Or maybe she doesn’t see it. Her own mind is elsewhere. “And Joshua?” There’s conflict in her. Joshua tried to screw us, but he’s also the man that she’s spent nearly a decade with.

“Right now, he’s being held on charges of being a Peeping Tom. Beyond that, though, is up to you. Some of what we did recover from that server would probably greatly interest his business partners.”

“So he was extorting them?”

“Not sure, but he certainly had enough on there to put a number of them in very hot water.”

She nods. “You keep it?”

“Until you tell me not to.”

“Keep it. It’s leverage. He’ll never stop unless we give him incentive to stop.”

“Yes, ma’am.”

She goes up to him. “And Ronald?”

“Hm?”

“Thank you.” She kisses him on the cheek. It’s funny, but I swear that he blushes more than he did last night, when she was ordered to give him a blowjob.

“Are you coming onto my husband?” Eleanor’s voice rings out from the top of the stairs.

I'm surprised to find her dressed already, her pink dress sexy while still being conference appropriate.

"I wouldn't dream of it."

Heather's phone chirps first. Then Eleanor's. Mine vibrates inside of my pocket. Reflexively, I pull the phone out and check the alert. It's from Henry Dawning, son of the founder of the former Dawning Foundation. My heart stops.

[Dawning]: What is "DeBauch" and why are they reporting that you are a member?!

I look up at the others in the room. They're as white as I am.

"You have to delete your accounts on DeBauch," I say. "Right now. Both of you."

Eleanor and Heather stare at their phone. "There are quotes," Eleanor says. "Oh, no..."

Ronald, the only person in the room who didn't get a text, stands confused. "What's going on?"

"I think my husband strikes again." Heather looks miserable. When she looks at me, I feel even worse.

"Would someone mind cluing me in?" I'm used to the submissive version of Ronald. It's easy to forget that in the professional world, he commands the respect of an entire company.

Eleanor sets her phone down on the island counter, face up. A news article reads: "NEW NAME. NEW SCANDAL. SEX APP ROCKS FORMER DAWNING FOUNDATION."

“At least they didn’t use the new organization in the headline,” she says. “But...” She looks at me before scrolling down. They definitely used my photo, taken during the keynote at GPC just a few days ago.

“Well that doesn’t feel good.” I wander to the windows. The world is well beyond the waking up time for most. The sun rises over the mountains. I have this sudden and strong urge to grab a bag and wander out there until I’m swallowed up by it all.

“This is... unexpected.” I hear Ronald speak behind me, but I don’t know who he’s talking to. He could be a foot away. He could be on the other side of the room.

Heather answers Ronald. “Promise me that no matter what, you would never do something like this to Eleanor. Or anyone she gets close to.”

“You know I wouldn’t.”

“I thought I knew my husband, too, and yet here we are, both surprised at how low he went.”

My phone buzzes in my hand. It’s Henry Dawning. My dream of wandering the Nevada desert crumbles. Time to face my future. I slide open the door and head outside, lifting the phone to my ear.

“Hey, Henry, how’s it going?”

Inside, I can just hear Mason join us with all his charismatic bluster. “Whoa ho, why all the sad faces?”

The rest is lost in Henry Dawning’s angry yelling.

Heather

PR Nightmare

The cleanup on this is easier than what we had to manage with the Hamilton scam. Rich people are a whole lot less tolerant of losing money than they are with a sex scandal. But there have to be consequences, and unfortunately, Paul and I both know what that consequence has to be.

I've been in the PR industry all my life. I know how to spin a story to save an organization, but there are always casualties. Life is about to get very hard, very fast, for him.

I spend the morning and most of the day with my team, crafting press releases and working with the media outlets in the philanthropy space. It's actually quite lucky that this all came out the day after GPC ended. Most people are traveling. Many may even miss a blip like this.

Or would have if DeBauch had not spilled out into the mainstream media, much the way Ashley Madison had when it was hacked. And Paul Sharpe was quickly becoming the poster boy for the cheating service.

"I'm pretty fucked, aren't I?" he says as we walk the wide halls of the conference center one last time.

I hate seeing him like this. I hate seeing how low he's gotten. Worse, this is my fault. My husband did this to Paul because of me. Joshua just ruined a man's life out of spite and jealousy.

"It's not your best day." I try to force lightness in the quip, but it's almost impossible. Instead, I have to fight back tears. I don't want to be anyone else's problem anymore. "Paul, this is my fault—"

“No.” He stops in the hall and turns to me. This is the same spot that Joshua found me at the beginning of this conference, wearing his first-timer badge. That feels like another life.

Paul says some reassuring things about how it’s not my fault and how I don’t have to bear this burden alone. How I need to stop taking all of the responsibility. I barely hear any of it.

Will Joshua always be here, hiding in the shadows? Will he always be a threat? He may not hurt me, but he will always try to destroy the things that I... love.

“Heather?” Paul draws me back into the present as color floods my cheeks.

I manage a weak smile. “Come on. Henry’s waiting.” I turn, realize how callous that sounds, and add, “And thanks, Paul.” And because I’m me and he is him, I throw in a, “Keep practicing the motivational stuff. Your TED Talk awaits.”

Paul resigns before the small assembled board that’s still in Las Vegas. Eleanor Heller and Henry Dawning are there. Eleanor is professional about it. Dawning seems more exhausted than upset. He’s an old man now and is tired of seeing his father’s foundation slowly spiral downward.

Eleanor, Paul, and I retire to the agency’s suite. It’s not even lunch, but no one stops Eleanor when she pours us all a drink. She makes small talk, because despite the wild experience we shared last night, small talk is where we’re at right now. “When’s your flight?”

“Tomorrow morning.” I glance at Paul, who sits in a cloud of his own thoughts. “We were going to do a show tonight. Relax and enjoy the city. Together.”

“Why can’t you still do that?”

She’s right. Those plans didn’t change. Just that everything else has. Now the tears come, sudden and surprising. It snaps Paul out of his state. Eleanor

wraps her arms around me, hugging me close and I sniffle. “Why am I crying?” I mutter into her shoulder.

She pulls back. “Because you love him,” she states like it’s the most obvious thing.

I find Paul through my blurred vision. He’s at my side, holding my hand. I smile at him. I do love him. I’m in love with him, and I’m pretty sure that he’s in love with me. This is why I need to do this next thing—the hardest thing in my entire life.

“Eleanor, I need to talk to Paul alone. Okay?”

She sees the seriousness in my face and feels the stiffness in my body. She knows. “Heather, don’t—”

“Please, Elle.”

She presses her lips into a flat, thin line, but nods anyway. A moment later, she’s gone. I turn to Paul and take a deep breath. Here goes.

Paul

The L Word

Heather's nervousness rolls off of her like heat. Seeing her like this is so strange. She's always so collected, so confident. She does not like showing this kind of vulnerability. She fidgets with the button of her jacket while Eleanor leaves and won't meet my eyes when she does.

Her anxiety plays out across my nerves as well. I feel a maw open up in my gut. I want to avoid this next conversation. I want to cling to the way things have been going. But that's not healthy, either.

She takes a deep breath and begins. "When we first met, you... you told me that you weren't looking for love..."

Normally so articulate, it hurts to watch her stumble over her words like this. I break in. "You're about to break up with me."

She blinks. "You know he won't stop until—"

"He's in jail."

"He can still make life pretty hard from there—"

"With what? Ron took all of his ammo away from him—"

"Will you stop interrupting me?!" She rakes her fingers through her hair.

"I'm just trying to stop you from doing something we'll both regret."

"Pretty sure it's too late for that."

“Really? Because I don’t regret anything.” I’m not trying to be witty, but she chooses to take it that way.

She rolls her eyes. “Forgot about your YOLO attitude on life.”

“Heather, I’m being serious.”

“And so am I. Paul...” She sighs, takes my hands in hers, and forces herself to look at me. “Eleanor... she’s kind of right. I’m pretty sure that... I mean, it’s silly, but I’ve... I’m in love with you.” There’s color in her cheeks, and her eyes dart away a moment later, like she’s afraid I don’t feel the same way. “In any other circumstances... But whatever. It would be a disaster. It’s already been a disaster—”

“I love you, too.”

“—and you and I will never...” She finally hears what I just said and stares pointedly at me. “What?”

It feels like I’ve uncorked something deep inside of me—something fizzy and frothy and pressurized—and now it’s all spilling forth. “You’re really asking me to repeat myself?”

Her laugh is uncertain, coming on in fits and starts. “Uh, yes. Please repeat, Mr. Sharpe.”

“I love you, too. Happy?”

She searches my face, her eyes narrowing. “Is this some new game?”

I lick my lips, my turn to feel all of my own nerves. “Not a game. Not a trick. I love you, Heather Kingsley-Fletcher.”

“But?”

“You do have a nice butt.”

I expect the eye roll or the playful slap, coupled with a sarcastic bark of a laugh. You’re an idiot. Instead, Heather throws her arms around me and

pulls me into a kiss that fills me like an orchestral swell. I want to cry and laugh and feel all at once. I want to hold her forever.

We go to the bedroom, our hands never leaving one another even as we tug and strip and leave a trail of clothes along the floor. “Definitely a nice butt,” I say, admiring the way she wears a thong.

“Yours isn’t so bad, either.” She squeezes it hard enough that I feel the bite of her nails.

“It’s from all the fucking.”

“God, can I take back the thing where I said I love—”

I cut her off with a kiss. “No take backs. No regrets.”

Her smile is sunshine.

This isn’t the first time that we’ve made love. As I lie over her and feel her legs envelop me, it’s familiar. It’s where I’ve always wanted to be.

“Haa... go... go slow. I’m still...”

“Sore? So am I.”

Heather laughs, even through the soft sounds of her pleasure. She doesn’t need to say any more. She doesn’t need to explain. I’m right there with her. Last night, we were involved in group sex. Somehow, we forged a relationship out of that.

“The way you look at me...” she says. Her face is already flushed, the way she gets when in the midst of sex. I love that I can recognize that. “It’s like you’re in my thoughts.”

“So what am I thinking now?”

“That this is crazy.”

It's pretty close to the mark. I lace my fingers with hers as I support my body over her. My hips rise and fall. Casual sex has never felt so intimate. As if reading that thought, she cranes her neck up and we kiss.

And kiss.

And make love.

And fuck.

I take her from behind, holding one of her arms against her tailbone tattoo as she braces herself with her other. She gives as good as she gets, undulating her hips in ways that boil the come in my balls.

"Oh, Paul..."

I release her wrist. She pushes herself up onto her knees, pressing her body against me. I spoon her, cupping her breasts. They're soft and pliable, swollen with excitement. Her nipples are hard as I close my fingertips over them. She gasps at the flash of pain. I kiss her neck.

Spooned like that, we fuck like we're one, unified and entwined. My pleasure picks up where hers leaves off. Her orgasm builds on top of mine. I've never felt this connected with anyone in my life. It's like she's in my head.

She reaches behind her, cradling my head and drawing me in for an over-the-shoulder kiss. "I'm so close."

"Hold out a little longer." My throat is raw.

She nods in tight jerks. "I want you in my life." Her hand trails down between her legs. I feel her fingertips on my balls. "I need you in my life."

"I'm here." She tugs at my balls, and my head goes fuzzy. "I'll always be here."

"I'm going to make mistakes."

“Mmm, I bet that’ll be hot.”

She snickers before my hand finds her clit. My lips graze her ear. “You know I’ll make mistakes, too.”

“Mmm...”

“Maybe we can even make some together.”

Her breathy laugh folds into a moan. “Can I come now?”

“Say please.”

“Go fuck yourself.” She can barely get the joke out. I press against her clit. She caresses my balls. We both lose the shape of the world together.

In that flash, I see all the possibilities spread out before me—some good, some bad. We make it. We don’t. We stand before a justice getting married. I’m in the pew as she says, “I do” to someone else, and then I take her on her marital bed as her new husband watches. She has kids. Sometimes they look just like me. Other times, they’re mixed race. Still others, they’re mine, not hers.

In all of them, though, we remain in each other’s lives, supporting and unconventional and kindred.

Heather

Closure

“I hope it was worth it.” I stare across the chill metal table in the interrogation room, arms folded. My hair is pinned up in a bun, and I wear a charcoal gray pantsuit with power heels.

He puts his hands on the table, palms up. “I’m sorry, Heather. You know I would never do something to harm you—”

“You blackmailed someone else to encourage me to participate in a gangbang.” I cross my arms.

“Didn’t look like you were complaining.” He winces at his own barb. “I’m sorry, I’m just...” He gestures around him. “A night in jail hasn’t been the best for me.”

“Don’t worry. You’ll get out soon. The Hellers aren’t pressing charges.” I let him keep that know-it-all smile for a little while longer. He thinks he’s safe because of the video he thinks he still has. “What I want to know is why did you leak the DeBauch story?”

“That could have been anyone. You have to know that was bound to come out. Let’s be honest, Paul Sharpe wasn’t the most discreet of guys.”

“But it wasn’t anyone. It was you.”

He scowls. “I only did any of this to get you back. You have to know that. I love you, Heather. I may have a weird way of showing it—”

“For sure.”

“—but I’ve always loved you.”

I sigh. This is the man who once meant normalcy after my crazy life with Shane. This is a man who I fell in love with for his confidence and his passion and how he challenged me. Should I have known that this was where it was headed all along?

“No, you don’t love me. You love some idea of me, sure, but you don’t love me. You never would have done what you did if you really cared about me.”

“What? I wouldn’t have outed your boyfriend’s sexual deviance?” Calling Paul my boyfriend is probably meant to make me feel shame and guilt. Instead, electricity sizzles in my belly and arcs up my spine. It seems to backfire for Joshua too—it hurts him, but also gives him a kick.

I realize something in this moment, and unlike the usual me, I don’t hold it in to analyze and dissect it. Like Paul, I just say it and see what happens. “You will never stop, will you?”

“Stop trying to get you back? Never. I love you—“

“See, you keep saying that. Joshua, I loved you, too. I loved your seriousness. I loved that you didn’t humor people just for their sake. I loved the way you only smiled at things that you really thought were worth smiling about, and when I made you smile, it used to light up my whole world. I even loved that you weren’t perfect. I could live with all of that. I loved you.”

The past tense feels like detoxing. I can almost feel the tension of this failed marriage leave my body.

“But you always wanted me to be something else, didn’t you? The lying. The scheming. All of those things aren’t about love. You hired a couple prostitutes to date rape another man just to break me up with him. There is nothing mutual about any of this.”

As I say that word—mutual—I think of Paul. I can’t stop the smile that follows.

Joshua knows what the smile means, too. He was always good at interpreting my thoughts. His face twists into something ugly. “I know exactly who you are, Heather. You play the professional, but deep down, you’re a hot blonde who likes to fuck. Shane told me all the stories. Did you know he called you his snow princess? I watched you last night, and it didn’t look like anyone was forcing you.”

Every word is a barb. It’s also more of what I was expecting. It makes what comes next easier. “I can be her, but that’s not all I am, just like you’re not just a cuckold who jerks off in the bushes.” He grits his teeth. I, too, can throw verbal barbs. “Let’s not forget that you also like having a PI follow your colleagues around so you can blackmail them.”

He doesn’t know I know about this. He still thinks he has leverage. Time to sweep that out from under him.

I pull out my phone and set it on the table between us. On it is a photo of one of the partners at his firm, kissing a much younger woman outside of a motel. I flick the screen. The next shows an older woman—another partner—holding hands with another woman. There are more. Snaps of receipts and incriminating documents. One of their kids has a drug problem that’s been covered up. It’s all very bad stuff, and Joshua had evidence of it all.

“Everyone has skeletons in their closet, Joshua. Yours happens to be... well, everyone else’s.”

“How did you—”

“You made a powerful enemy in Ronald Heller. And with a few emails, I could make you even more.” I pick up my phone and smile at it as the noose tightens around my once dear husband. “Or you can remove yourself from my life forever. Move on. You did it with Melody once before.”

I stand. He continues to sit, looking daggers at me.

“Goodbye, Joshua. For the very last time.” I don’t expect the emotion, but it comes, blurring my vision and quivering in my chin.

“He’s not good for you, Heather. He will never be satisfied with just one woman, just like you won’t be satisfied with just one man.”

That’s exactly what I need to steel myself. “Who said anything about just one woman or just one man?”

It’s my final sting, leaving him with the knowledge that Paul might get what Joshua always wanted. It will eat away at him. It will destroy him.

I walk out on Joshua for one final time.

Epilogue

One Year Later

I spot Heather through the crowd, a guy at her side. She has her back to the bar, and he's clearly in her space, a hand lingering on her arm as she talks to him. I recognize her mannerisms, the way she's speaking quickly, the way she meets his eyes and smiles. She's into this one.

The guy watches her, pretending to be attentive as he no doubt is already thinking about what color her panties are or how good she'll feel in his bed. I was that guy once—still am on my bad days.

Heather sees me, glancing my way as the guy tries to hold up his side of the conversation. She gives me a smile and a quick glance at the guy that says, Want me to get rid of him?

I give her the most imperceptible of shakes, moving into the spot on the opposite side of her. "Can I get a Jameson, on the rocks, please?"

Heather wears the same gray dress that she wore the very first time we met. It's a nice touch. Even better, I can appreciate it more—the tightness, the bodycon design that would hint at all but the tiniest of underwear, the fact that I see no hints of any.

"Are we really having this conversation?" she's asking the guy.

"You started it."

"Okay, fine." She glances at a couple at the end of the bar, two people dressed in suits and still wearing conference badges. "They're not fucking yet, but will be by the end of the night. No, they're not from the same

company—you can tell that from their badges—but I do think they’ve seen each other around. Same professional conferences and all that.”

“Wow. Look at you, Sherlock,” the guy says, impressed.

“Oh, and they’re both married. The guy’s wife doesn’t know, but I think the brunette has an understanding husband.”

The guy sees an opportunity. “Is that who you have? An understanding husband?”

She holds up her ring finger, where a solitaire sits on a golden band. “So you noticed...”

The two at the end of the bar get up and leave. Heather’s right, they’ve got all the nervous energy of two who are about to get dirty for the first time. I’m less convinced that she’s a hotwife. Far more likely she’s just another cheating spouse.

“So tell me, Roman, am I a cheating spouse or do I have an understanding husband?”

“What do I get if I guess right?” The way his fingers glide along her arm projects his hopes.

“See, that’s the problem with you Millennials. Always looking to get rewarded.”

“Aren’t you a Millennial, too?”

“And I like getting rewarded.” I smile into my drink at her quick answer. “So what do you think, Roman?”

“Well, the way I see it, I only have one viable answer. I can’t tell you that you’re cheating, because I’d possibly be stirring up guilty feelings. Plus, I wouldn’t want to risk insulting you.”

“I see.” She’s amused. “You’ve thought this all through. What if cheating doesn’t make me feel guilty? What if it turns me on? What if that’s why I

put this dress on and came out to this bar in a city that I don't know?"

"Hm... a twist."

"You think about your answer. I'm going to use the little girl's room." She slides off her stool, scoops up her clutch, and heads off to the restroom. Roman and I both check her out. She knows it, putting an extra swing in her hips.

"Nice legs," I say. When he looks at me, I add, "I think she's got an agreement with her old man." I don't bother looking over. I already have my phone out, and there's already a text waiting for me.

[Heather]: So?

"No way." He shakes his head. "There's just no way a guy lets a chick like that fuck around on him, even if he does get a little extra himself. There's no upgrade from that."

I type a reply under the bar as the guy yammers away.

[Me]: Definitely has potential. You?

Looking up, I grin at him. "Maybe she's horrible in bed."

"Maybe. I've certainly been with duds." He rubs the spot between his chin and lower lip. "I just don't think so."

"Yeah, I don't think so either."

[Heather]: I like his sleeves.

Roman does, in fact, have tattooed sleeves up his arms. That's interesting. She's never said anything about liking tattoos before. "Think you could handle her?"

"Never met a chick that I couldn't, and I've been with some really fucking crazy ones."

"So what are you going to do? Call her a cheater? Or a hotwife?"

He pulls a face. "A hotwife?"

I chuckle. This feels like talking to myself a year ago. "Never mind."

[Me]: If you want him, go for it.

"I've got a plan. A woman like that doesn't need more than an excuse, though. You don't put a dress like that on and sit at a bar alone if you're not at least open to the possibility of... me."

"No doubt." I nod.

He glances around the bar, where opportunity abounds. We both see it—in the shy woman who stands on the outside of a ring of chatting women, her eyes drifting for an escape; or in the brunette who sits at the bar on her phone, looking bored; or in the two off-duty caterers, young and winding down and looking for fun.

"Love these places, man," he goes on. "Hotel bars. Good hunting here."

That brings a chuckle from me. My words almost exactly—my same thoughts, once upon a time. Before Manhattan. Before Heather.

“Here she comes. Good luck.” I turn back to my drink, my heart pounding and my ears perked up like a dog on high alert.

I am not like Ronald, and I’m certainly not like Joshua, but I’m also not the same man that I was when I first met “Manhattan.” She’s changed me, and I’ve changed with her. I still find the life of a bull thrilling, but in the same way I enjoy a good meal at a new restaurant or a hard weight-lifting session. The excitement never reaches the levels I get when I do things with Heather.

After I resigned from the Memory Project, I did some soul-searching. I had enough in savings that I didn’t need to jump right back into the job hunt. Of course, I also had the Hellers for support.

And Heather.

“So what did you decide?” We’re back in the hotel bar. Heather has returned to Roman’s side. “What kind of wife am I?”

“You never told me what I get if I guess right.”

She lifts her eyes. “I didn’t. Why don’t you tell me what you want?”

“I want to take you somewhere private and show you that I don’t care what kind of relationship you have with your husband.”

“Okay...” The gleam in her eyes encourages Roman to keep going.

“You’re not looking for love. You’re looking for some fun in bad boy form.” He leans in, knowing he’s close, and touches her arm again. “And you’re wondering how much of my body is tattooed.”

Heather actually blushes. She’s off her game enough that she looks in my direction before refocusing. “How—?”

“I saw you looking.” I can feel the heat in the air. It’s like a furnace. “What I’m trying to decide is whether you’re a tease, or really are looking for a good time.”

She steps right up to him, and in her heels, she's nearly his height. When she speaks, her whisper carries just enough that I can hear. "In my hotel room, I have a box of Magnum XL Condoms. Are you big enough to wear them?"

"My preferred brand... and size."

"Then come along, stunt cock. Let's see if you're all talk."

The man gives me a proud look as he rises with her, and just over his shoulder, she flashes me her own amused smile and mouths, 'I love you.'

Watching her walk out of the bar in a dress like that with another man is one of my life's most surprising pleasures. I watch and wait, and just as she's about to step out of view, she does what she always does—she glances one last time over her shoulder and winks.

Joshua would have given his left testicle for a moment like this, but he'd never be able to handle it. The man is too possessive, too insecure. He was always in it for himself and his pleasure, and as soon as she showed some interest, he freaked.

Ronald is the other side of the spectrum. He puts Eleanor first, beyond all of his own wants. According to Heather, Elie hasn't slept with him in three months and kept him caged for a good chunk of that time. Apparently, she made him wear a cock cage when he was addressing his investors. That is not me, nor will it ever be.

But I am no longer just the guy, no longer just the bull. For the first six months, we took it safe and slow. We dated. We talked. And yes, we fucked—epic all-nighters that left me sore the next day—but always just with one another. That new relationship energy continues to this day.

We didn't intend for it to happen. We were getting a drink after a nice dinner when we saw her—a very sexy blonde nursing a cocktail. I told Heather that the woman reminded me of her when we first met.

"Why don't you try and pick her up?" she challenged.

“Not even a challenge. How about you try and pick her up?” It was a flip remark, but Heather took me up on it.

“Hold my drink.”

Turned out that the blonde, Piper, who had been stood up by her date, was as into girls as Heather was. We took her back to our place and the two spent the night exploring their bisexuality. Fucking another woman doggy-style while her head bobs between Heather’s legs is amazing. Funny how connected you can feel to someone else while actually being with another.

When the day that marked a year of our first meeting approached, it seemed only natural to come here, to this Marriott. Neither of us said it, but it felt like an appropriate fuck you to Joshua, even if he would never know.

Nick, the bartender, brings me another. “Haven’t seen you around here in awhile, Paul.”

“Yeah, I’ve been busy. I’m actually going to get married.”

“No shit. That’s wild. She must be something special.”

Upstairs, my bride-to-be is probably naked by now, and exploring the strange touch of a new man. It gets me hard. It is what it is. Call it evolution. Call it change. Call it...

Nick points at my empty glass. “Another?”

I nod, and when he pours it, I stare into the amber liquid. Into the Jameson whiskey that defined me for so long. Then I finish my thought.

Call it coming full circle.



I could hear them as soon as I step into the hotel suite—their heavy breathing, Heather’s moans and sighs, the squeak of the hotel bed’s taxed joints.

The outer room of our suite is dark. Heather’s gray dress lay crumpled on the floor before the double doors of the bedroom, Roman’s shirt beside it.

“Yes,” she gasps.

“Uh!” he grunts.

“Yes.”

“Uh!”

Light spills out of the crack in the doors, drawing me close.

“Fuck me. Fuck... me!” She’s close. I know her sounds now. I know her excitement like I know mine.

Roman obeys. When I get to the breach in the doors, his hips are a blur. He’s on her, his ass to me, her long legs wrapped around his tattoo-etched back. All the ink moves and twists like living art across his thick and corded muscles.

She reaches around, her arm shiny with sweat, and grabs his ass, urging him to fuck her still harder.

I stand inside the door. I don’t hide. I’m not skulking. I watch and enjoy, cock hard, heart pumping.

She arches beneath him, her orgasm rumbling in her diaphragm, primal and fierce. He keeps fucking her until she can’t take more. Until she puts her hands on his broad shoulders and pushes him up.

“Don’t worry, she won’t leave you hanging.”

My voice startles Roman. He nearly bolts off of her, flipping over. His stiff cock flops across his thigh. He is, indeed, a big guy.

“The fuck?!”

“Roman, meet my fiancé, Paul.”

“Told you she has an arrangement.”

“You?”

“Me. This isn’t going to freak you out, is it?”

I see him weigh the situation. He’s not done this before. He didn’t know what a hotwife is, and I know how strange the concept can be for the uneducated.

“You see, I enjoy watching Heather with other men.” I begin to unbutton my shirt. “But I can only sit on the sidelines for so long.” I glance hungrily at Heather, who’s watching quietly, propped up on her elbows.

“I’m not into other—”

“Paul’s not either,” Heather says. She rises, scooting over to me as I pull my shirt off. “So how about it, Roman? Stay?”

The poor guy licks his lips, looking from her to me and back. I think back on that first experience with Eleanor, my first time as someone else’s bull. If Ronald had been there—and had an entirely different personality—would I have been cool with it?

“Yeah, fuck it.” He shrugs. “How does this work?”

I have my pants off, still by the side of the bed. Heather turns away from him, lowers herself to all fours, and starts stroking my cock. She wiggles her ass in his direction. He gets the point, entering her just as she takes me into her mouth. Her gasp ripples around my dick as I lock my knees and stroke her hair from her face.

I’m not the bull. Not in this relationship. Not with this woman. Stag, she calls me. I like the ring of it. Watching this woman perform, I cannot wait to see what this next stage of my life brings.



“Happy Anniversary, Manhattan.”

Heather snuggles against me. It’s hours later, and it’s just the two of us once again. We’re exhausted, covered in sweat, and completely fucked out. She kisses me on the side of the jaw. “That what we’re calling it?”

“A year to the day since I first met you? Feels like an anniversary.”

She rests her head on my shoulder. “You’re a lot more sentimental than I thought.”

“You know that I had no idea what a bull was until that night? Or a hotwife? In a way, you kind of kicked this whole thing off.”

“In an even more twisted way, Joshua got us to where we are.”

I stroke her back. Her skin is still hot and clammy. “I’d raise a glass to your ex, but I don’t want to get out of bed to get the glass. Also, that guy’s an asshole.”

“Yes, he is.”

“Heard from him lately?”

“Not even a text or an email since he signed the papers.” The divorce was official as of six months ago.

“I’ve been thinking about something. If he’d been hit by a bus when he landed in Las Vegas, do you think we’d be together?”

She shifts off of me, turning onto her side and propping her head up on an elbow so she can look at me. As always, I feel her dig into my thoughts. It’s unnerving, but I let her work through it all.

“I think so? I did like you. A lot. And he was already on his way out of my life, but who could really say? I was with him for years, and a part of me still loves him. I have no idea how I would have reacted if he’d died at that time.”

“Okay, so maybe he doesn't die, but just... doesn't come after us.”

“Ah. You want to know if we still would be ‘us’ without Mason Coles and Elie and her gangbang party. Like, if we’d done normal couple stuff first. Dinner and a movie and a handjob in the car.”

“Well, maybe not exactly like that, but close enough.”

“Do you regret it? Do you regret seeing that side of me?”

“You know I don’t.” I take her hand and guide it down to my cock, which is beginning to rise again. “And I don’t regret tonight, either. Watching you with Roman. I’m not going to regret it the next time we play this game, either.”

It took Las Vegas to make me realize that I could be more than just the bull in her life. It took Joshua and his driven desire to ruin us to make me realize how much I wanted an “us” at all. And it took the both of us letting go for us to truly find one another in the end. Or at least this version of us.

Heather climbs into my lap. “If Joshua had just disappeared from our lives, we may be together, but I don’t know that we’d ever have this conversation.” She squeezes my cock, now hard, and slides it against her smooth pussy. “We probably wouldn’t be celebrating our ‘anniversary’ this way.”

I enter her, a perfect fit. We groan. I pull her down to me, skin on skin, my hands all over her back, her butt, her body. This is the reclaim I’ve been waiting for. This is the moment to which the whole night has been building.

Had things gone differently, we could be together or not. We could be living in the suburbs with a white-picket fence and a child on the way. Or we

could have gone separate ways, still friends, but not a couple. These things I cannot control, and we've both learned not to try.

All I know is what I want, this version of me. And right now, this is it. This is everything—every single thing. Right here, in my arms.

Afterword & Acknowledgements

This series has been years in the making. I'm seeing drafts as early as 2016, and the idea was there before I ever put finger to keyboard. I've written about the origins of this book both on my blog (kennywriter.com) and the forewords of the other books, so I won't repeat here.

I do have a lot of people to thank, though, because you wouldn't have this book in your virtual hands without them.

First, Ben Boswell, my friend both in real life and online, has helped me navigate the twists and turns of this series, but also of this book specifically.

Max Sebastian, Kirsten McCurran, and Javi, who I'm quickly thinking is my dark muse, all helped guide this story to its conclusion.

As always, my biggest thanks goes out to you, the readers, who make all of this possible. I love your passion for these books, and your constant emails and tweets asking where this finale is. I wish I could have delivered it to you much, much earlier, but I wanted to get this ending right, and that proved harder than I thought.

Finally, let me address the biggest question that I know I'll get from you. Is this really the ending? And what really is "beyond" this hotwife fantasy?

Truth is, I don't know. For now, I need to take a break from Heather and Paul, Eleanor and Ronald, and Mason Coles and all the rest. I'll also be honest and say that I haven't entirely ruled out something like a Stag's Eye series. I think Paul is an interesting character, and if you can't tell, I've fallen in love with Heather. The best way to test that bond is through conflict, and hey, Shane's still out there...

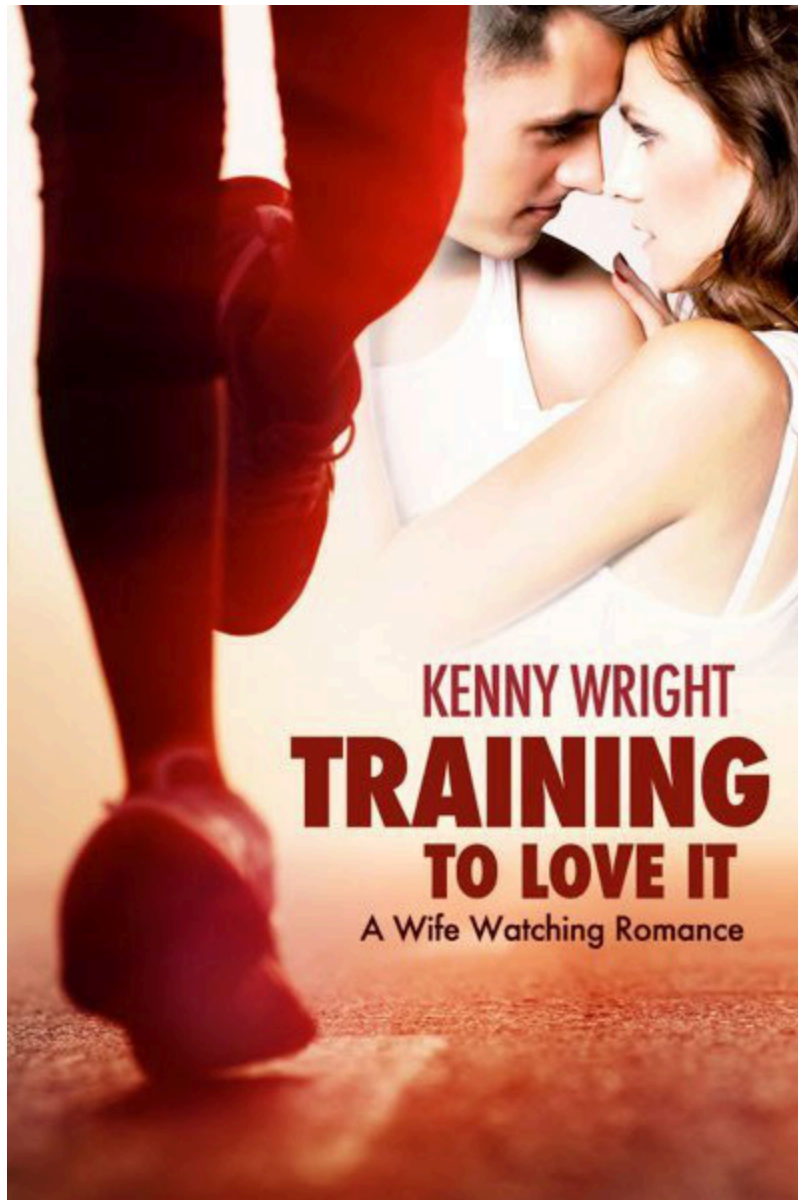
But for now, this chapter of their lives are done, and now all of us can rest.

Thanks again for reading!

Also by Kenny Wright

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Training to Love It Series (3 books)



Can a wife-watching fantasy be trained?

When Erin comes home from the gym and lets slip that her new personal trainer is a man, Tom doesn't know how to react. When he overhears Erin admitting that she's attracted to AJ, her trainer, he becomes even more confused. He wants to be supportive, but he feels jealous. He wants to be understanding, but he doesn't even understand his own feelings. Every time

he thinks of Erin with AJ, his heart begins to race. Every time she says his name, his breath catches in his chest.

AJ ends up pushing more than just his wife's physical limits. As Tom watches this newer, stronger, more assertive woman emerge with each training session, he realizes that this other man is pushing the limits of their marriage and their happy life. How far would they go for a fantasy? And whose fantasy is it? And what happens when things go too far?

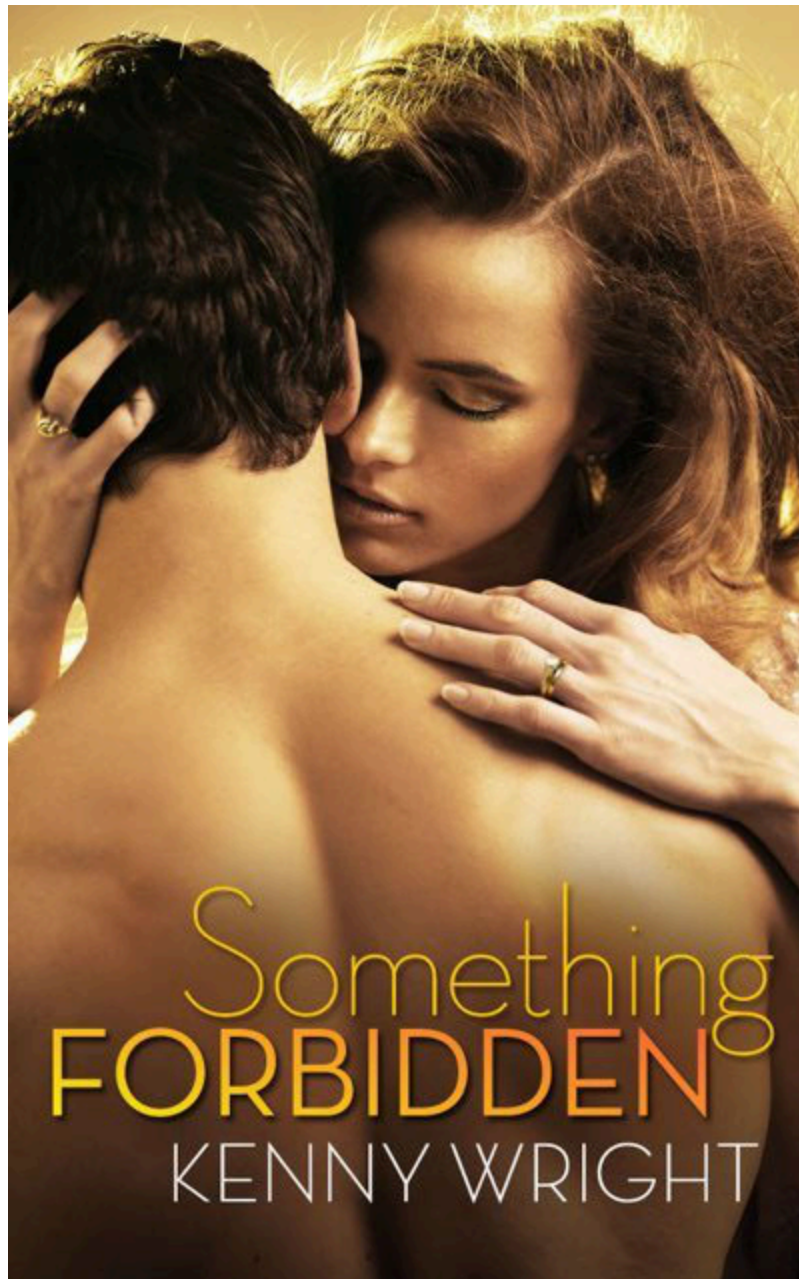
Training to Love It

Training to Love It 2

Training to Love It 3



Forbidden Series (2 books)



Wife-watching. Swinging. Consensual infidelity. These are not concepts that Maxwell Callahan understands, let alone fantasizes about. Max has a great life: husband, father, successful bar owner. He has no plans to shake it up.

And then he witnesses a couple play a dangerous game of pick-up in his bar: the wife gets picked up, the husband watches. A seed takes root and starts to grow. What would it be like to watch his beautiful wife, Katie, in the same situation?

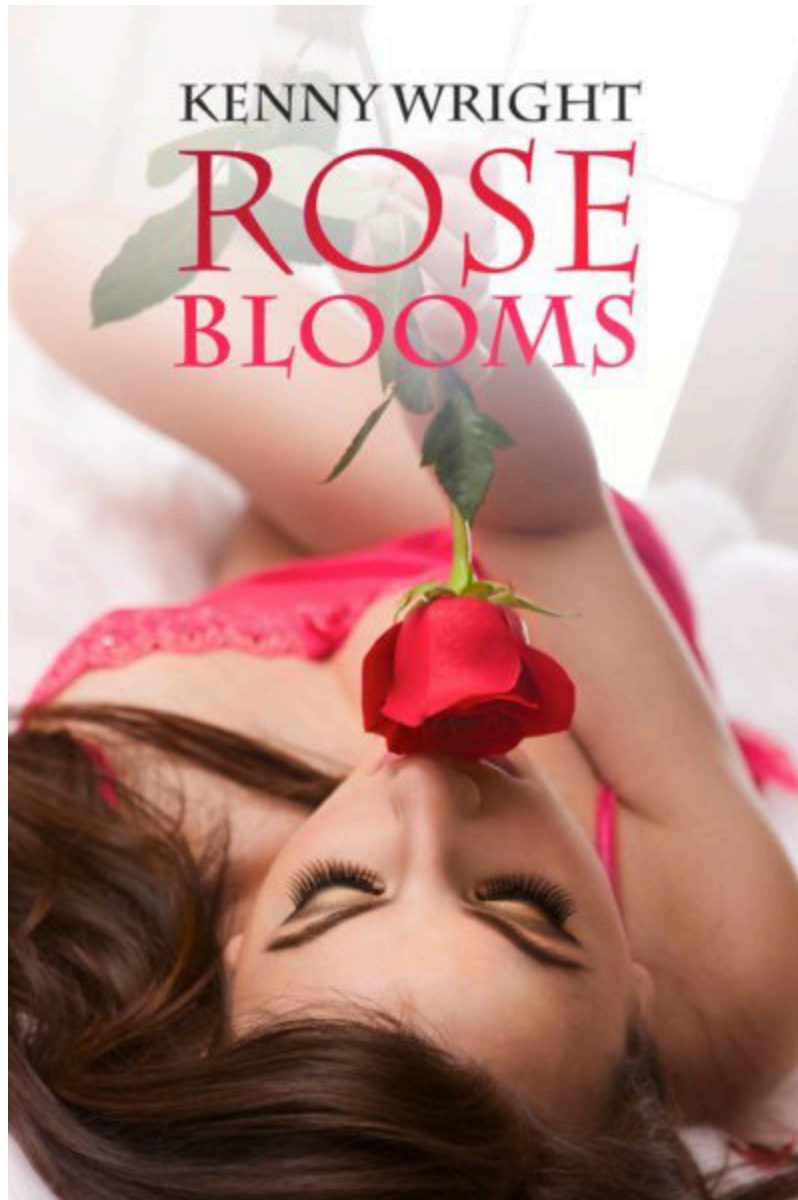
Smart, successful, yet a little conservative, he never thought Katie would entertain such an idea...until she does. This suburban couple is about to take a wild ride as they turn fantasy into reality. Don't miss this marital adventure as Katie and Max try something forbidden.

Something Forbidden

Nothing Forbidden



Rose Blooms



When Rose and Andy Shaw learn that their neighbors have separated, they are shocked. Jordan and Louis always seemed so...normal. Like them. Only their neighbors weren't normal. Louis has a dark fantasy, one that eventually pushes his marriage to the brink. He wants to share his wife, Jordan, beautiful and blonde, with other men.

Andy and Rose are reminded of a time early in their relationship, when their sex life was riskier and things were more exciting. When a new man

enters their lives and starts to push Rose's buttons, they wonder if they are more similar to their neighbors than they want to believe.

Find out what happens when Louis's fantasy rubs off on Andy and Rose discovers that Jordan has secrets of her own. Discover how vibrant this rose blooms.

[Find Rose Blooms online](#)



Annie's Affair



She cheated, and it turned him on.

Travis never thought his wife would cheat on him. Never considered it once in nineteen long years of marriage...until Rick entered their lives.

Travis never thought an affair would turn him on...until he found Annie's diary and started reading about his wife's attraction to her new, younger editor. Confident and attractive, Rick made his intentions clear. He wanted Annie, and she responded. She was tempted. She was attracted. She was conflicted.

Suddenly, Travis is able to see Annie the way Rick does—the way he used to before his perception was dulled by the long years of marriage. Annie is an attractive, smart, fun woman, with an adventurous side ready to be unleashed.

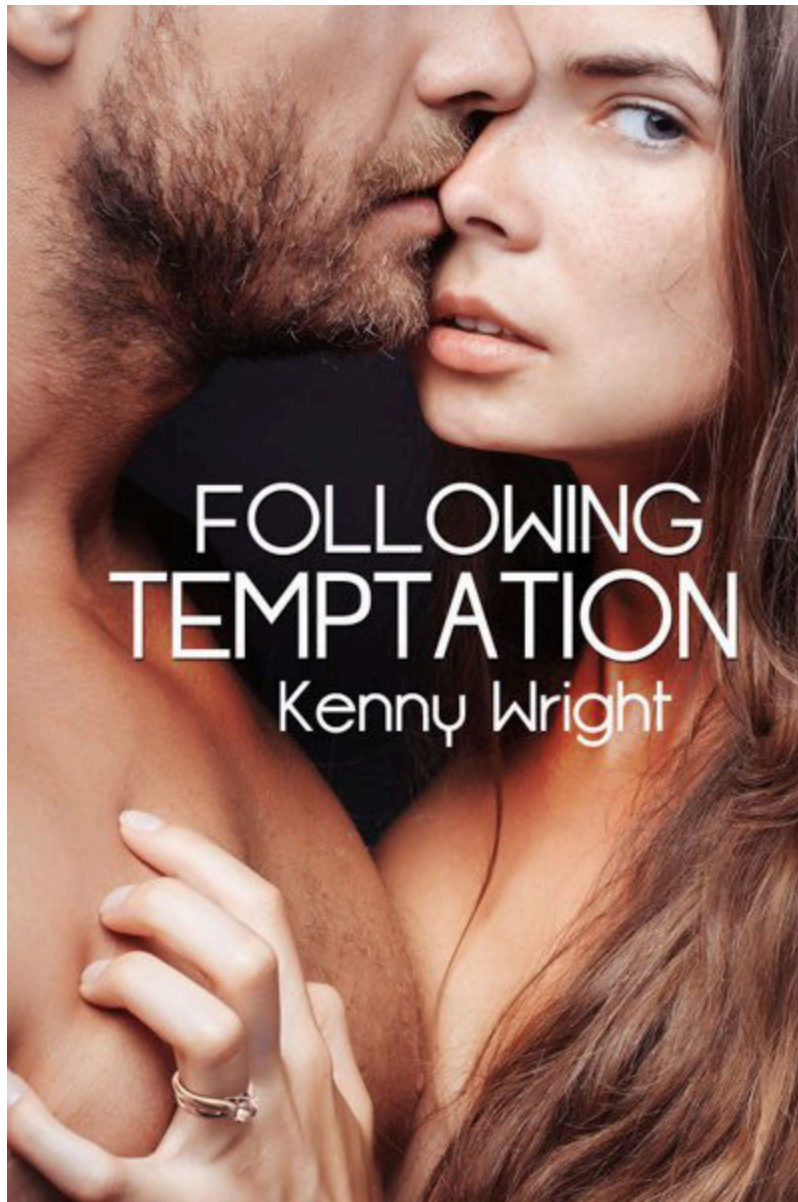
Travis never thought he'd want to watch his wife sleep with another man... until he did. And then it became his obsession.

Annie's Affair follows Travis as he witnesses his wife fall into the arms of another man, and becomes just as complicit in the betrayal as his wife.

[Find Annie's Affair online](#)



Following Temptation



Temptation waits just around the corner. Follow and see where it leads.

Life is good for Michael and Laura Richards, if a little stale. That is, until Michael follows his neighbor, Dane, to the house of the married Jessica, and watches Dane take full advantage of the voluptuous brunette. Michael shouldn't watch, but he can't stop himself, and the veneer of his sleepy suburb peels away to reveal its naughtiness.

Michael confesses the adventure to his wife, Laura, and the couple embarks on a journey of sexual awakening, following Dane and Jessica into a world that is as uncomfortable as it is irresistible. But there are layers within layers, and when Laura befriends Jessica and learns that not everything is as straightforward as it seems, just how far is she willing to follow her neighbor? Prepare yourself for a tale of voyeurism, naughty neighbors, sexy wives, and illicit temptation.

[Find Following Temptation online](#)

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About the Author

I'm just a guy who writes what I like to read: steamy, explicit erotica that's just crazy enough to be true. I write romantic erotica. I write about characters that I like, and endings that feel natural. I write stories where husbands watch their wives get naughty. I write about MILFs and erotic games and loss of innocence. I believe in a world where men read and appreciate erotica, and hope to contribute to it word by word.

Find me online at www.kennywriter.com, or follow me on Twitter at [@kennywriter](https://twitter.com/kennywriter). I also operate eroticaformen.com, which may or may not look like crap right now.



